

Phil 303 Intro to Nietzsche

Course transcript with numbered paragraphs

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Highlighting key

key vocabulary terms and concepts distinctive to this course

key figures thinkers, characters, and figures central to the lectures

Paragraphs are numbered lecture.paragraph (e.g. 3.12 is the twelfth paragraph of Lecture 3). Each lecture opens with an "At a glance" overview, which is not part of the transcript.

1. Philosophical Foundations

AT A GLANCE

Introduces the seminar on Beyond Good and Evil and what it means to philosophize with a hammer: digging down to the axiomatic presuppositions beneath thought, morality, and faith. Explains why Nietzsche foresaw that the death of God would bring nihilism and totalitarian ideologies, and why he was an ironic rather than triumphant anti-Christian. Describes his aphoristic, prophetic style and Jung's idea that some people live ahead of their time. Sketches his short, illness-ridden life and then walks through the dynamism of the 1840s to 1880s—the Communist Manifesto, Darwin, Maxwell, the machine gun—to situate him historically.

- 1.1 Well, hello, everyone. We're going to talk about Nietzsche's *Beyond Good and Evil*, essentially. That's what I'm going to attempt to cover in this seminar. And so, I subtitled this, *How to Philosophize with a Hammer*, and that's actually a quote from Nietzsche. What does that mean?
- 1.2 I think it refers to two—there are two references implicit in that statement. One is that Nietzsche attempted to break down some of the implicit axiomatic suppositions that had undergirded philosophy prior to the dawn of his thought. And so it's a technical phrase, even though it's poetic, but it's also a psychological phrase. And I think it does refer to the impact that Nietzsche's thought can have on you if you come upon it unaware.
- 1.3 He's had a remarkable impact on thought over the last 140 years, and any singular individual who has a remarkable impact on thought has gone down very deep into the structure of our presuppositions and moved them around. We have this intuition of depth. All of us know that there's a difference between something that's shallow and something that's deep. And if something inside you that's shallow moves, it doesn't move much of you. And if something inside of you that's deep is moved, it moves a lot of you at the same time.
- 1.4 Nietzsche was someone who philosophized in the depths. And so, to read Nietzsche is daunting psychologically because there's a lot of things that you take for granted that orient you in the world, that make you free of anxiety, that unite you with other people, that give you a direction and a purpose that stabilize you psychologically. And Nietzsche is one of those thinkers who goes down into the foundations and starts to shift them around. And that can be very destructive.
- 1.5 Nietzsche himself lost his Christian faith, for example, which is an example of a destruction of axiomatic foundation. Now, he attempted to rebuild something else in its stead, but that's no simple thing given that the entire edifice of Judeo-Christian thought was a collective endeavor unfolding over thousands and thousands of years. To try to replace something like that in a single lifetime, regardless of your degree of brilliance, is one daunting challenge, and it isn't obvious that Nietzsche succeeded.

- 1.6 But he did succeed in calling our attention, everyone's attention, to the nature of our unconscious and implicit axiomatic presumptions, and also while taking a hammer to the foundations. It was Nietzsche, of course, who famously pronounced that God was dead and that we have killed him, by the way, and that we'll never find enough water to wash away the blood. It wasn't a triumphalist statement.
- 1.7 It isn't reasonable to say that it was Nietzsche himself who produced the death of God that plagues our society at the current times because no one thinker is responsible for a transformation of that magnitude. But it is the case that he was able to synthesize the criticism of Judeo-Christian ethics and bring it to a—what would you say? To express that more trenchantly and explicitly than anyone else, just like Freud, not so long afterwards, was able to formulate and make explicit the idea of the unconscious, even though people had been working towards that realization for centuries.
- 1.8 And so, how to philosophize with a hammer is to go down into the depths, to look at the axiomatic foundations of philosophic thought, and to attempt to break that apart. And it's certainly the case that Nietzsche managed that to a great degree. And we're still, all of us, whether we know it or not, are still coping with that consequence.
- 1.9 Nietzsche knew, for example, that one of the consequences—that there would be two consequences of the death of God, and one would be the collapse of a system of meaning that encapsulated people psychologically and socially. The collapse of that system of meaning, Nietzsche believed, would bring about two events. One would be the dawn of a universal nihilism, a sense of rootlessness and hopelessness that would pervade Western culture and provide—and result in an intense and pervasive demoralization.
- 1.10 That, and the dawn of the attraction of totalitarian ideologies that would rise to replace God. And Nietzsche was particularly concerned about the rise of anti-Semitism. That was one, which is obviously prescient. But more importantly, even than that, was his prophecy that huge swaths of Europe—the Western world, for that matter, and as it turned out, the entire world—would become enticed by the blandishments of something like utopian communism, and that the consequence of that would be the death of tens of millions of people in the 20th century. It's quite a remarkable piece of prophecy, a multidimensional prophecy, because all of those things transpired.
- 1.11 And so, the popular image of Nietzsche is a triumphant—rationalist, let's say—celebrating the death of God. But that's not accurate, a not accurate representation in the least. He was a much wiser man than that.
- 1.12 Now, that doesn't mean that Nietzsche was an uncritical admirer, let's say, of the Judeo-Christian ethic because he also believed that deep within Christianity was a spirit. It was a spirit embedded of resentment, slave morality that would view the world as a battle between—that there was, you say, a stream of roughly Christian thought that viewed the world as a battleground between the oppressed and the oppressor, the slave and the master. He believed

that Christianity was a manifestation of **slave morality** that was constantly driven by a form of envy and that that would culminate in something extraordinarily destructive.

- 1.13 Now, I think Nietzsche's thought was weak on that part to some degree. Nietzsche is a very nuanced thinker, and there's a difference between criticizing Christianity and criticizing Christ. And Nietzsche is ambivalent on that front. I think it might be fair to say that he criticized institutionalized Christianity for its adoption of **slave morality** but didn't go so far as to assume that that was part of the ethos of what was central to Christianity itself.
- 1.14 Now, Nietzsche wasn't precisely a systematic philosopher. He wrote aphoristically. He wrote using narrative and using poetic tools, which also made him a very strange philosopher and a very strange author and professor, alienated him from his academic community because he didn't write in a dry and academic manner. He had this prophetic and poetic temperament. So, he's a very creative philosopher rather than a rigorous philosopher. And so his thought jumps from place to place.
- 1.15 He distrusted systematizers. He was also very ill for much of his life and couldn't write in long bursts. He tended to think for extended periods of time and then summarize all that thought in very short bursts of poetic prose. That's also, I would say, in some part, why it's reasonable to say that he philosophized with a hammer because his thought is extraordinarily condensed. He'll offer you something—**aphorisms**, very short statements, paragraphs that are unbelievably dense.
- 1.16 What we're going to do, and I think what will be the most fun in this seminar, is to take a variety of those paragraphs and **aphorisms** and attempt to unpack them. You can do that endlessly. For example, in a book like **Beyond Good and Evil**, it's not really a book that you can sit down and read all at once because there's so much packed into it. When I read a book, I often earmark a page if there's something that I might want to refer to later. I've read whole books where I didn't earmark a single page. I don't even bother earmarking a book like **Beyond Good and Evil** because I end up earmarking both pages of every page.
- 1.17 And so, Nietzsche famously said of his own books, "I write in a single sentence what it takes other men a book to write." Then he says, "What other men can't even write in a book?" Which is pretty good because it's a hell of an egotistical statement right off the bat, and instantly, he tops it with an even more egotistical statement, except that it wasn't egotistical because it happened to be true.
- 1.18 And so, there's whole fields of endeavor embedded inside **Nietzschean** thought. The whole corpus of psychoanalytic thought is embedded in paragraphs of Nietzsche's thoughts in **Beyond Good and Evil**. And Jung, for example, was a student of Nietzsche's—not directly an admirer of Nietzsche. He wrote, he published, eventually, a 1,400-page—I believe it was a 1,400-page book on seminar notes on the first one-third of **Thus Spake Zarathustra**. So, that's about 40 pages. Fourteen hundred pages of exposition on that, on one-third of what's a very small volume.

- 1.19 And so, there's a tremendous amount to unpack in Nietzsche. And so, it's a mustard seed issue. Christ compared the Kingdom of God, if I remember correctly, to a mustard seed, this tiny little grain of possibility that can unfold into this remarkable structure. And poetic language, in particular, image-laden language, has that proclivity to contain much more than you'd expect, given the brevity of the statement. And that's because the meaning isn't just contained in the words; it's contained in the relationship between the words and the relationship between the phrases and the sentences, and then the poetic relationship of the sentences to the corpus of thought that it refers to. And so, it can pack a tremendous amount of information into a very small space.
- 1.20 That's particularly true if you write poetically, and Nietzsche was a prophetic and revelatory writer. Thus Spake Zarathustra, for example, is written in a kind of intense, emotion-laden Old Testament language. Many people who are flirting with intellectual development fall in love with Thus Spake Zarathustra, which is this poetic work, a poetic fairytale narrative about a prophet who descends back into his community with a revelation at hand. And it's not a good example of the larger corpus of Nietzsche's work because he's actually a very clear writer and thinker. But it is an example of the degree to which his philosophy wasn't dry, rational cognition but infused with a sense of creative dynamism and poetic inspiration.
- 1.21 And again, that's partly what alienated him from the academic community of his time. And still, in some ways, Nietzsche is still a fringe philosopher because he's got this intense romanticism about him. It makes him a dramatic character. He's more like a character in a Dostoevsky novel—which is something that we'll touch on as we move through this—than your, let's say, typical dry-as-dust philosopher. He's a very, very dynamic thinker, and so it's a great adventure, intellectually and morally, to read Nietzsche. He's a remarkable person, a truly, truly prophetic individual.
- 1.22 Carl Jung believed that people lived at different times at the same time. There's some people in the world now who are really living 100 years in what will be the future. They're the people who are establishing what the world is going to be far down the road. There are people now who live hundreds of years in the past, and maybe the bulk of us are somewhere ensconced in the present. There are a few people out there who are on the edge of what will be. Dostoevsky and Nietzsche were certainly on the edge of what would be in the mid-1800s, and they had some sense of what was going to unfold over the next 200 years and could see that with unerring accuracy.
- 1.23 I suppose that's because they could—like Jung, there are people who are capable of seeing the deep undercurrents in society and seeing which way the wind was blowing or which way the zeitgeist was shifting, the spirit of the times. I think it's often people who are dreamers who are particularly capable of that because the dream tends to inhabit the edge of the knowable. And all three, Dostoevsky, Nietzsche, and Jung, were intensely poetic and imaginative people. Dreamers. And their writing is imbued with the spirit of the dream, the creative spirit of the dream.

- 1.24 And that's partly, I suppose, what distinguishes a prophetic figure from a more programmatic thinker is that they're more involved in the language and the realm of the image and the dream. That's a richer realm, although it's more difficult to make explicit. You know how hard it is when you remember a dream, even to be able to account for it programmatically and systematically, to transform it into words, how much you lose when you do that. The dream gains in richness what it loses in precision and explicit content. And there are geniuses who can stand on the border between the dream and the word and translate the image and the dream into the word. And Nietzsche was definitely one of those figures.
- 1.25 So, let's walk through—we're going to walk through his biography a bit so you have some understanding of the structure of his life. And then, we're going to position him in his historical context so you have some sense of what's going on in Europe and the rest of the world at this time. And then, we're going to turn to the exposition of some of his thoughts from *Beyond Good and Evil*.
- 1.26 So, he only lived 56 years, from 1844 to 1900. He was very ill for much of that time, and so managed to accomplish what he did accomplish despite the fact that he was working constantly against insuperable odds. He was so ill that he could only work, as I said, for short bursts of time. One of the things that's remarkable and admirable about Nietzsche, and we're thinking about from a practical and moral perspective, is that despite the fact that he was extraordinarily ill, one of the villages he lived in in Switzerland, he was regarded as the Saint. That was his nickname because he was such a pleasant person and was so good to everybody he met—and was still struggling to wrestle with these deep questions, despite the fact that he was so ill that he was half-blind and could hardly write and was sick to his stomach all the time and was suffering from some illness that eventually manifested itself as a psychosis, and then a series of strokes that killed him at a very early age.
- 1.27 That's worth thinking about, too, because we have this sense that if terrible things happen to you, you'll turn out to be a terrible person and that that fact is justified by the presence of your unfair suffering. Well, you can understand that if you meet someone who's been terribly hurt, who is terribly ill, who isn't behaving properly, you can say, "Maybe if I was in that situation, I would behave the same way." But the problem with that is that you do come across people, and you'll come across them in your own life, and maybe even be one of those to whom terrible things have happened and will happen, and that will be the case for all of us, by the way, who are still nonetheless doing everything they can to make the world better, rather than worse. And I think that Nietzsche was definitely one of those people.
- 1.28 I say that with all due care because it's certainly also the case that Nietzsche and his philosophical hammerings did destabilize the entire structure of Western civilization. You could think of him as someone destructive in that regard. But I've always thought of Nietzsche, especially in regard to Christianity, as the kind of critic you really want to have around because if you're sure of yourself, but your foundations are unsettled and in need of repair, it might be your best friend who comes along and taps on the weakest spot so that you know where they are. And that might be, initially, very destructive to you because it might even speed the process

of your crumbling. But if the consequence of that is that you can rebuild something out of the ruins that's even stronger, then that's part of the process of creative destruction.

- 1.29 And I think that Nietzsche was, ironically—I'm pushing it here, possibly—ironically an anti-Christian, that he knew perfectly well that the best defense was a rigorous offense, and that if you had respect for something, you could take all the hammers and tongs you had at your disposal and apply it to that. And it's certainly the case that reading Nietzsche helped clarify my understanding of the Christian ethos, for example. If you subject something to radical criticism and it remains standing, then that's an indication of its integrity and its utility.
- 1.30 Now, whether the Judeo-Christian ethos can actually withstand the Nietzschean criticism—we combine that with the Freudian criticism and the implicit criticism that emerged out of Darwin and, say, out of the Enlightenment period as well—then perhaps it's not obvious that anything remains at all, although I think that's a pessimistic overstatement. We're going to find out that there's a lot more there down in the foundations that will withstand any challenge that we ever imagined. And I think if we do discover that, I think we're in the process of that, that we can thank Nietzsche for laying the groundwork for that, because without the questions that he had generated so trenchantly and so devastatingly, then the quality of the answers would have been much lesser.
- 1.31 So, for example, Jung—we'll return to Jung for a moment. Jung was very much influenced by Freud, especially in his formulation of the unconscious. But he really spent his entire career trying to answer a question that Nietzsche posed, which was, "On what basis should we erect our morality?" So when Nietzsche demolished the structure of Western morality by pointing to the death of God, Nietzsche proposed that human beings would henceforth have to create their own values because Nietzsche also believed, at least as a young man, that God was a human creation rather than the other way around.
- 1.32 He believed once we dispensed with God, we would have to create our own values. And you can understand that, at least on the surface, as a reasonable proposition. If the values that once served us have now vanished, what else are we going to do but create our own values? And Jung took that suggestion extraordinarily seriously, asking, "Is it actually possible for an individual to create his or her own values?" Because that's a Nietzschean presupposition that we could do that. Now, Nietzsche believed it would have to be a whole new kind of person. That's the overman, or the übermensch, the superman, who would be capable of doing that. He knew it was an extraordinarily difficult task.
- 1.33 The psychoanalysts, starting with Freud, showed, and also taking a page from Nietzsche, that the problem with the idea that you might create your own values is that it's not obvious at all that you're the master of your own house. So, for Freud, for example, you are essentially a collection of loose biological inclinations, id-driven impulses that might serve you as lesser gods and pull you in all sorts of directions. For Freud, it was lust, aggression, and the impulse towards death were your primordial gods, and they're instantiated within you at a biological level, and

you're their plaything. You're their toy. It isn't obvious that you can be the master of your own values in a manner that would allow you to create them.

- 1.34 And Jung took that idea much, much further because the other question that emerges would be that, even if you did create your own values, let's say, what would stop the person sitting beside you from creating their own values, and you creating your own values? And why would you assume that those would have any union? And if they didn't have any union, then why wouldn't you assume that you'd devolve into constant conflict? So, part of the problem with the idea of generating your own values is, "What unifies us?" And you might say, "We don't need to be unified." It's like, "You do if you don't want the Hobbesian state of brutal nature to reign because if we're not united in our outlook and our values, then as soon as you want something other than what I want, we are definitely going to be at each other's throats."
- 1.35 Jung started to delve into that, as did the developmental psychologist, Jean Piaget, trying to understand how it might be that—how you might understand the boundaries of value construction. Is there a universe within which values have to operate in order for them to unite a given person psychologically or for them to unite a multitude of people socially across large spans of time?
- 1.36 You might think about that as the question of what constitutes a playable versus a non-playable game. Can it iterate? Can it sustain itself? Can it fortify itself across time? Maybe that's the kind of game you want to play if you ever get married. You want a game that you can continue to play but also one that improves across time. Maybe those games have a set form or pattern of form that they have to occupy in order to have those properties.
- 1.37 Of course, Nietzsche speculated about that as well, which is something that we'll see very brilliantly. You can see in his own thought the genesis of ideas that might have been the answer to the question that he posed, and certainly were unraveled by other thinkers like Jung, like Freud, like Piaget, to provide an answer to the questions that he offered.
- 1.38 So, he was born in 1844. At the age of 25, he was offered a full professorship at the University of Basel in classical philology. He didn't even have a PhD at that time. He had to get an honorary PhD from another university. He was awarded an honorary PhD from another university, I believe, as a precondition for taking up that professorial position. It was unheard of at the time. And so, it was obvious that Nietzsche's brilliance was recognized by the academic community at a very young age.
- 1.39 And that's quite remarkable because he was a very romantic spirit, not a well-behaved person. The fact that he was recognized by universities as a consequence of his stellar intellectual achievement is even more striking because he was a controversial person, but so brilliant that despite the controversy, he was a hot intellectual property, and those are relatively rare.
- 1.40 So, he was a full professor of classical philology at the University of Basel and devoted himself to the understanding of Latin and Greek texts. That's classical philology. In 1879, he resigned. In 1880, he collapsed with paralysis in his vascular dementia, an emergent psychosis. All sorts of

people have speculated on what might have been wrong with Nietzsche, and no one really knows. Maybe it was syphilis; maybe it was mercury poisoning from the treatment of syphilis. His father died very young of something that looked akin to a brain illness, I think at the age of 36, and so maybe there was something hereditary going on.

- 1.41 Other people have speculated that his own philosophy drove him to the edge of madness and then beyond. I don't believe that. I read Nietzsche's works in sequence, and I don't believe that there's evidence of an emerging pathology that's a consequence of his thought. I might say that speculation about the death of God took his own foundations out from underneath them, and he collapsed into a catastrophic and depressive nihilism and then died. And that does happen to people. But I don't think that that fits with the facts.
- 1.42 I do think instead that there's a fundamental optimism about Nietzschean thought, which is quite remarkable. That's in keeping with some of his basic propositions because he believed that we weren't motivated by the will to survive, but by the will to express what he called power. And he had a very particularized definition of that—that life consisted in the attempt to expend ourselves in life. And he tried to live in accordance with that ethos, and I think very successfully.
- 1.43 Let's look at the world in the late 1800s in the time period that he lived, because it's a good idea to get a sense of the dynamism of the times and what revolutionary activities were underway and underfoot in Europe, in the West, when Nietzsche was formulating his thought. It's a very dynamic period. It's at the height of the Industrial Revolution, the utter transformation of the world.
- 1.44 In 1865, if I remember correctly, the typical person in the Western world lived on less than \$1.50 a day in today's terms, just barely clinging to the edge of the margins of hand-to-mouth sustainability. The entire world was poor in a way that we can hardly imagine. And that was starting to transform with incredible rapidity in this amazing transformation of the industrial and technological revolution that's raised the whole planet by now out of abject poverty and continues to do that at an ever-accelerating rate. It's a very, very dynamic time in the late, in the last half of the 1800s.
- 1.45 So, let's walk through some of the cardinal events. In 1840, in the U.S., the Western expansion is continuing into what eventually becomes California and Oregon in 1840. I threw this in just because I was Canadian. Upper and Lower Canada merged into a single province. Canada was integrated as a state in 1867. We think of Canada as a new country, but it's actually quite an old democracy with an even older history. New Zealand was founded in 1842. Hong Kong was ceded to Britain in '45. Texas became the 28th state in 1846. America, the U.S., incorporated a huge swath of the Southwest, taking that territory from Mexico, and incorporated Oregon, Washington, Idaho, Wyoming, and Montana from the U.K.
- 1.46 In 1847, a physician named Semmelweis proposed that surgeons should wash their hands when moving from patient to patient. It was an early manifestation of what later became the germ theory of pathogen transmission. And, of course, his colleagues hounded him into insanity and

death for his unmitigated gall in proposing such a demented theory. At that time, surgeons used to pride themselves on the filth on their surgical uniforms because that showed how much surgery they had conducted. And so, they'd move from patient to patient in a cloud of miasma and death. Women were killed with amazing regularity in hospitals because of the transmission of disease from one to another as a consequence of the filthy physicians who were attending to them. Semmelweis cottoned onto the fact that perhaps all this dirt and blood was not a very good idea. And he was eventually proved right, although he wasn't around to see that.

- 1.47 In 1848, the Communist Manifesto was published. And so, that's interesting as well because, as I said, Nietzsche prognosticated that the ideas that came to a culmination in the Communist Manifesto would prove extraordinarily attractive to people motivated number one, by envy and number two, lost in the nihilistic chaos that's a consequence of the death of traditional morality.
- 1.48 Do you have to orient yourself with some form of systematic thought? The answer seems to be yes because otherwise the world's too complex. You have to be able to reduce the complexity of the world to something approximating a systematic perspective, or you drown in difficulty. And so, if one system of value collapses, then another is going to beckon to you because you have to do something to organize all the multiplicitous proclivities of your psyche into something approximating unity.
- 1.49 And so, what that means, maybe, is that we're always in the situation of the Israelites in the desert. In the Exodus story, the Israelites leave the tyranny of Egypt. You could draw an analogy and say, "We left the tyranny of the Judeo-Christian ethic." And where did we end up? Well, in the promised land. It's like, well, that isn't how the story goes. You go from the tyranny to the desert, not to the promised land. One of the things that happens in the desert is that you're enticed into the worship of idols because you need some centralizing tendency to guide you and unite you. And so, if you lose one, there's going to be a terrible unconscious longing for another.
- 1.50 And, well, you see that manifested in the Communist Manifesto. And you all know, or perhaps you know, of the terrible consequences that arose as a consequence of the formulation of that ethos. It was a new attempt to develop a system of axiomatic presuppositions, the basic foundations of a state, that was almost entirely derived, at least in principle, from a rational approach. The communists always insisted that they had scientific materialism at the basis of their system of thought, which I think is a radical overstatement. First of all, it's not that easy to derive an ethic from science. And second, it isn't obvious at all that communism was driven by, say, love of the common man.
- 1.51 I would say instead that it was driven to a tremendous degree by an unacknowledged and omnipresent envious resentment, and I would also say the proof of that is in the pudding, which is that, while the spirit of envious resentment taken to its logical conclusion would result in the deaths of many, many people because the spirit of envious resentment is murderous to the core, and that is exactly what happened every time the communist presuppositions were actually realized in any given state.

- 1.52 The radical leftist types say, "That's not true communism," but the perspicacious analysts of communism—foremost among them, Solzhenitsyn—laid out in the early '70s an unassailable argument that the murderousness of the communist regimes was a necessary consequence of the a priori axioms of the philosophical system.
- 1.53 Same kind of idea there that, in a phrase as innocuous as, "From each according to his ability to each according to his need," which sounds extraordinarily compassionate and generous on the surface, has inside of the ethos that, if allowed to unfold in a natural environment, produces in the end result something that's indistinguishable from the genocidal murderousness of Stalin and Mao. And you think, "Could that all be embedded in a phrase that innocuous?" And perhaps the answer is, "Not all of that in that one phrase, but in the cloud of ideas that surrounds that phrase, certainly." The proof is when you planted that seed in various places, the same tree grew and bore the same evil fruits.
- 1.54 In 1848, the first women's rights convention in the U.S. at Seneca Falls. In '51, Louis Napoleon leads a coup in France. In '52, Italy moves towards unification. We think of these countries as so ancient—Italy, for example—but it wasn't unified in 1852. From '53 to '86, France and Britain defended the Ottoman Empire and defeated Russia. Commodore Perry, in 1853, brought gunboats into the harbor in Tokyo and forced the opening of Japan, a great shock to the Japanese, who regarded themselves as the center of the world and were radically overpowered by this overwhelming technology that the Americans could bring to bear. That's an amazing story in and of itself.
- 1.55 In 1855, the Bessemer process enabled the mass production of steel. Of course, that revolutionized the construction of cities and the entire industrial landscape. First oil refinery in 1856 in Romania. A lot of things happening at the same time. In '59, the Suez Canal was constructed. The Big Ben was completed. In 1859, Darwin published The Origin of Species, which was another death blow to a kind of rote Christianity, I would say, because The Origin of Species was the first account that provided a plausible mechanism whereby life might have generated itself rather than being part of the created order. That was another bit of philosophizing with a hammer, although this time, it occurred on the scientific front.
- 1.56 When I was your age, let's say, I would say that it was likely Einstein who was regarded as the foremost scientist of the last 150 years. But I would say it wasn't long after that before Einstein, as profound as his contributions were, was supplanted by Darwin. I don't think there's a scientist of the last 150 years whose impact has been greater than that of Charles Darwin. The theory of evolution provided a uniting framework for all the sciences above the level of chemistry, an incredible work. Very hard on Darwin himself, psychologically, because he was a Christian, and he knew that there was a tension between the implications of his work, say, and the narrative that had been laid out in the Christian ethos. It isn't obvious at all that he was able to reconcile that gulf.
- 1.57 He was not pleased that his work was—he was not pleased about the fact that there was a contradiction between his work and the faith that he abided by. He knew how useful that faith

was in providing people with psychological unity and social purpose and suffered from panic attacks, for example, for much of his life. Now, it's never easy to diagnose someone who's here now when you talk to them, let alone retrospectively. But that's a tremendous amount of psychological tension for someone to bear as the first person who bears that. Darwin really did understand the implications of what he had written, as well as understanding what he wrote.

- 1.58** In 1860, the first recording of the human voice. From '61 to '65, that was the American Civil War fought fundamentally over the issue of slavery. In 1861, the Russians abolished serfdom, so slavery was rife in Eastern Europe and in Russia up to that point, and it's part of the universal heritage of mankind. It's not the existence of slave-free societies that's the human norm. It's the reverse of that. And the miracle, I would say, of the West is that, and perhaps of the Industrial Revolution, but also of the ethos that drove that revolution and distributed its fruits to such a wide range of people that slavery was regarded as intrinsically wrong and on a wide enough scale and deep enough so that even people who were economically motivated, perhaps, to perpetuate slavery, were forced, starting in the U.K., to contend with the fact that, regardless of its potential short- and medium-term economic viability, it was unethical to the core.
- 1.59** So, in 1861, the Russians abolished serfdom. James Clerk Maxwell publishes his famous equations, uniting light and electromagnetism, laying the groundwork for much of modern physics. Lincoln issued the Emancipation Proclamation, deeming all men to be free in the United States. In 1863, Manet exhibited the first Impressionist painting, and those early exhibitions caused riots in Paris because the Impressionists were forcing people, or enticing people, inviting people, to see the world in a completely new way.
- 1.60** When we look at Impressionist paintings now, we think, "They're kind of classically beautiful." But that's only because we now see like Impressionist painters saw. They literally taught us to see the world in a different way, and that was very hard on people to begin with. So, you have no idea how much the way you see the world is a consequence of you mimicking great artists across time. They literally taught you even to understand what constitutes beautiful, even to know, for example, that there might be such a thing as beauty in the natural world, and then to see that as part of your day-to-day experience. That's all taught to us by great artists who are geniuses of perception, obviously, and they can see things where other people see just the predictable; they see miracles where other people see the predictable and the familiar.
- 1.61** Robert E. Lee in 1865 surrenders, end of the American Civil War. Slavery is banned in the U.S. with the 13th Amendment, and Lincoln is assassinated. It's 1865. The same year, Mendel formulated the laws of inheritance. In 1866, the Meiji Restoration in Japan and the beginning of Japanese modernization, which took place at an extraordinarily rapid rate. First transatlantic telegraphy cable. In 1867, the purchase of Alaska and a devastating famine in Sweden. That's worth noting, too. That's not that long ago. Sweden is a very modern, rich, industrialized society. We can't even envision something like famine occurring there. But it's not that long ago when the world was poor enough so that even in relatively rich and developed nations, the threat of famine was often extremely real.

- 1.62 In 1869, Tolstoy published *War and Peace*. In '71, the Franco-Prussian War produced a united Germany and Italy. From 1875 to 1900, 26 million Indians perished from famine, and in 1876, 13 million in China. In 1876, the U.S. Gilded Age begins. So, that's when the Americans really started to march forward on the world stage, the time of the great industrialists and this immense generation and distribution of wealth in this huge, emergent democracy in North America—the beginning of the domination of the world by Americans, politically, economically, and culturally.
- 1.63 In '76, of course, the U.K. is still on the top of the world at that point. Queen Victoria is the Empress of India. In '77, Serbia, Montenegro, Romania, and Bulgaria become independent. Commercial telephone exchange in '78 in New Haven, Connecticut, and so that's the dawn of the connected age. It's the new Internet, the telephone. And, well, everyone knows the consequences of that because now you carry that around with you all the time and spend half your life looking at it.
- 1.64 In 1879, Edison invents the light bulb. In 1881, pogroms wash through Russia in the rise of this terrible flood of anti-Semitic propaganda. That's the early manifestation of what, of course, culminated in the Holocaust and also motivated, eventually, the establishment of Zionism in the settlement of Israel.
- 1.65 In 1884, the first self-powered machine gun. That's a bigger invention than you might think if you don't think about it because a machine gun makes one man into an army. That's the end of horses in battle for obvious reasons. It's the end of phalanxes of soldiers marching forward because all that means is you die. It's the initiation of an entirely new form of warfare and also of slaughter and mayhem on a scale that was completely unimaginable prior to the emergence of the machine gun.
- 1.66 You saw that technology really start to make itself manifest in the First World War because it started out with standard battles using cavalry, using horses, and horses were used throughout the entire First World War, but obviously with less and less success. Part of the reason for trench warfare was the presence of the machine gun—hundreds of rounds of munitions in an amazingly short period of time. We have guns now that will fire tens of thousands of bullets in a second—an unbelievable, devastating force, the force of an entire army in one machine.
- 1.67 In 1885, the first internal combustion car. The Singer sewing machine was popularized. In 1889, the Eiffel Tower has inaugurated this new tower of steel that becomes the **archetype**, I suppose, of the skyscrapers that now dominate the landscape of the cities. Bicycles sweep Europe in 1890. In '92, the first gasoline tractor. The Olympic Games are revived in Athens in 1896, a sign of the world coming together as an integrated society. Sports led the way there, in some ways. In 1898, the first Zeppelin airship, so now people can travel through the sky from place to place. The Exposition Universelle was held in Paris in 1900, featuring the new artistic movement Art Nouveau.

- 1.68 All right, so that's a bit of an overview of where we are in history. And you can get a sense of the dynamism of the times, especially the industrial spirit of the times—this burgeoning, widespread industrial economy that's lifting immense numbers of people out of sustenance-level living, which we tend to romanticize as fortunate 21st-century city dwellers, but was a pretty damn dismal, difficult, cold, brutal, miserable, ill-fed slog for 95% of people not very long ago.

2. Nietzsche and Dostoevsky

AT A GLANCE

Surveys Nietzsche's central ideas—perspectivism versus objective truth, the problem of many moralities, resentment and master-slave morality, life-affirmation against nihilism, and the Apollonian and Dionysian—before turning to his biography: the pastor father who died young, the wild student years, Feuerbach, Schopenhauer, Kant, Wagner and Liszt, the ill-received *Birth of Tragedy*, the wandering years, Zarathustra, and the 1889 collapse in Turin over a flogged horse. Reads the uncanny parallel in Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*, Raskolnikov's dream of Mikolka beating the mare, and introduces Ivan and Alyosha from *The Brothers Karamazov*.

- 2.1 All right, so a little bit of an overview of **Nietzschean** thought. He contrasted truth and **perspectivism**. There's echoes there of the battle between empiricism and rationalism.
- 2.2 So, here's three problems. The world's very complicated. It's hard to see. Everything you see is way more complicated than you can see. So, when I see you, people sitting here—first of all, I only see you in a tiny slice of time, no idea about your past or your future. So, you're localized in time. I only see your front. I only see your surface. I don't even see much of your surface because you're hidden by clothes. But even given that, you're very, very complicated biologically.
- 2.3 I can't see the familial networks that you're integrated into or the social networks that you're a part of, the biological systems that you're part and parcel of. I can't see any of the microstructures that make you up. I mean, on any of the cells that compose you or the molecular structures that compose those cells or the atomic structures that compose those molecules. All that's opaque to my vision. So, whatever I'm seeing is just a slice of what's there.
- 2.4 And so, the one question emerges, which is, "What is there?" Another question that emerges is, "What is the slice?" And then, another question emerges, a philosophical question, "What's the relationship between the slice?" That would be what I see and what's actually there. "How do you conceptualize that relationship?"
- 2.5 The empiricist might say, "All of our information comes to us from sense data." We derive all of our representations from our encounter with the real world. But the rationalist would say, "Yeah, but we can't see the real world without laying an interpretive structure on the world to screen us from what's there because it's too much and to allow only a certain amount of the world to make itself manifest to us." And so, how do we know that what we see isn't just a projection of our interpretive structure rather than what's there itself, especially given the necessity that an interpretive structure must exist?
- 2.6 So, **Nietzsche** was very interested in the relationship between **perspectivism**—you have to have a point of view—and the idea of objective or transcendent truth because it's not obvious how to reconcile those things. You have to bring a perspective. You have to have a perspective to live.

Life itself requires a perspective, but a perspective means that you're imposing a structure on the truth.

- 2.7 So then, another question that emerges out of that is—and Nietzsche posed this question, as we'll see, specifically—"How do you know that the perspectives that sustain you as something that's alive are in any sense aligned with the truth of the objective world?" Is it necessarily the case that truth itself, conceptualized objectively, would be something that would serve life? And if it wasn't true that truth itself served life implicitly, then is there a truth that supersedes objective truth that's devoted to the sustenance of life?"
- 2.8 Nietzsche was very good at posing questions like that, and that's a very thorny question. He undertook a generalized critique of, I would say, morality and of religious thought itself. Morality—so, here's a Nietzschean idea. So, Nietzsche noted that as Europe expanded around the world, it contracted a case of indigestion. Perhaps this is what did in Rome. So, you can imagine that a culture that's confident and expansive has a united ethos and has faith in that ethos. "Here's what we believe without question, and we all believe it." And that enables us all to move forward without doubt. Well, now you go into the world, and you find all sorts of other people, other cultures, who believe other things.
- 2.9 Nietzsche said, "That poses—that presents two problems to you." The first problem is, "How do you know you're right?" These other people have organized themselves according to principles that aren't identical to the principles that you've organized yourself by. They worship different gods. You might say, "We know we're right because we conquered them." It's like, well, that means your ethos is that might makes right, and that's actually a relatively weak ethos.
- 2.10 But then, you also have the problem that when you incorporate those people, it's not like those ideas disappear and they were powerful enough to have overtaken that entire people. What makes you think that, when you pull them into your own culture, they won't overtake you? That's part of the reason that people who are more conservative are concerned about immigration. It's like, well, what carrying capacity does the society predicated on a certain ethos have with regards to bringing in people whose fundamental axiomatic perceptual structures are, in principle, somewhat different? The answer is, "We don't know," because it's good to have some novelty because that helps you grow and expand, change, and adapt. But then, do you really want to bite off more than you can chew? And the answer is, "We don't know how to balance those things."
- 2.11 So, Nietzsche not only said, "We're going to have the problem of many moralities, and that's a problem because which one's right? But there's a worse problem that emerges out of that, which is, if they're all different, what makes you think that there is such a thing as right?" And that's the pathway to nihilism. It's not only do you lose faith in your own system, in contrast to, say, another system, you stop being Christian and you become Buddhist, which so many people in the West have pretensions to that now. The cataclysm isn't that you shift from Christianity to Buddhism, or to Islam, for that matter, or scientific materialism. The cataclysm is that you search

through all of those, and you decide that, because there's a multiplicity, nothing can stand, and then you're in the pit of nihilistic doom.

- 2.12 One of the consequences of that is the hopelessness and confusion that accompanies that, but also the lurking desire within you, if you're nihilistic, to re-ally yourself with something that's totalitarian so that you have some certainty. And so, that's a problem that Nietzsche knew full well was going to make itself manifest. That problem of the comparing, the comparison of multiple moralities, raises the specter that no morality is in and of itself absolute. And then what?
- 2.13 Then, you have no foundation to stand on. You need a reason to move forward in certainty because otherwise, you move forward in doubt. And the problem with moving forward in doubt is you don't move forward. Anything can stop you because, first of all, you're not motivated to go because you don't believe in the destination. But second, you're weak, rife with doubt. Virtually anything can stop you. That's a radical demoralization on the psychological front but also on the social front. You can't unite yourself in cooperation and competition with other people. That makes a whole culture weak.
- 2.14 Nietzsche also studied this deeply, this idea of ressentiment, resentment, and tied that into master-slave morality. We'll walk through that in some detail when we get to Beyond Good and Evil. He believed in the affirmation of life as an antidote to nihilism. His idea of the 'will to power' isn't a will to fascist power. Now, his sister got a hold of his notebooks after he died. She had married a radical anti-Semite and a man who was very fascist in his leanings and tilted Nietzsche's thought towards this fascist expression of a will to domination and power. But Nietzsche didn't mean by 'the will to power,' the willingness to use compulsion and force, although his thought is somewhat ambiguous on that front because he was also an admirer of the aristocratic tradition. And so, well, the devil's in the details, and Nietzsche is a nuanced thinker.
- 2.15 It isn't obvious to me that he successfully managed to re-present a vision of a united ethos that would replace Christian morality. In fact, I think he failed on that regard. I also think that his idea that we could, and would have to, invent our own values, I think, is fatally flawed. I say that with all due respect because Nietzsche is a remarkable thinker. The mere fact that someone didn't get all the way to the end doesn't mean that the journey they took is worthless or not worth tracking, learning from, and repeating.
- 2.16 Anyways, there is this affirmation of life in Nietzschean thought that he believed was something necessary morally as an antithesis to beckoning nihilism. As I said, as a person, he seems to have been admired by the people who knew him for his kindness, for example, even under duress. But Nietzsche also believed and acted out the proposition that a certain life-affirming courage was the right stance to take in relationship to the catastrophe of life. It's worth thinking about, too.

- 2.17 And I think it's—and I'm not attributing this thought to Nietzsche, but you can think about that as a necessary manifestation of necessary faith. And you might say, "Why is faith necessary? You could just let the facts speak for themselves." It's like, "The facts don't speak for themselves. And faith is necessary because you have to step forward into the unknown." You don't know what's going to happen. You have to determine if you're going to be guided by the principles that you uphold. It's the principles that structure your contact with the unknown.
- 2.18 If you throw yourself into a marriage, it's not like you know what the outcome is going to be. You don't have the facts at hand. You make a decision that you're going to manifest trust in the person that you love. You're going to link your life up with theirs, and you're going to abide by that principle as something that guides you into the chaos. That's a faith-based affirmation of life. You might ask as well, "There's a principle there that guides you in marriage, but there are similar principles that might guide you in your interaction with others or even in your decision to get up in the morning and face the catastrophe of the day. What principle should orient you?"
- 2.19 Well, at least with Nietzsche, one of the fundamental values he put forward was this necessity of a life-affirming perspective despite the vagaries of the evidence. He said, for example—no, we have this idea, and Freud developed this to some degree, that maybe you had a cataclysmic childhood and that put you on a bad road towards a certain neurotic pathway. And there's a determinism about that, an inevitability. It's no wonder if you were tortured so badly that you turned out so badly.
- 2.20 The problem with that, as Nietzsche pointed out, is there's a multitude of interpretations of even a traumatic event. Imagine you're bullied endlessly in junior high. Might say, "It's no wonder I became a bully. Look at the examples I had around me." But you can imagine and meet and read about people who drew exactly the opposite conclusion, which was, "I learned from being bullied continually that there was nothing worse, and I swore that I would never take that path." Those are opposite outcomes, so you can't lay out some narrow, simple-minded deterministic account of the outcome because the data is the same set, and the outcome is entirely different.
- 2.21 And so, Nietzsche knew, and that was part of his perspectivism, that any—it's one of the first postmodern interpretations of reality itself—that any event is susceptible to a multitude of interpretations, including a multitude of potentially valid interpretations, including those that compete. And so much for a simple-minded determinism in terms of something as complicated as the events of your life—what moral do you derive from your experiences?
- 2.22 It's like, well, that's the same question as, "What is the story of your life?" And that's another question. It's big. There is, "How much is the story of your life dependent on your will to faith?" Because you could say, "I insist upon extracting a life-affirming narrative, regardless of the catastrophes of my experience." And that's something we're thinking about. That allies faith with courage because it's necessary; I would say it's arguably necessary. All of us will undergo terrible losses in our life, including the loss of our own life, the loss of the lives of everyone around us, all those who die before us. That's definitely coming down the pipelines. There's no

shortage of catastrophe in your life. So you might say, "Why not draw the most negative of possible conclusions?" And that's a real question.

- 2.23 One answer to that is, "Take heart and take courage. And despite all that, strive to walk uphill and do good, despite the fact that the facts, in some sense, might indicate that you have justification for doing something different." And that's worth knowing that you have that moral obligation. Arguably, you have that moral obligation to uphold the good and the valuable and the truth and the true and the beautiful despite the catastrophe of your existence, and that might include, that could easily include, unfair victimization at the hands of other people or the heavy hand of cataclysmic fate.
- 2.24 Certainly, Nietzsche experienced the latter in spades. He only lived to be 56 and was unbelievably ill for most of that time. His dad died very young. He had a brother that died when he was two, and there was no shortage. And he was in war quite frequently, so Nietzsche was also quite a courageous person, a good horseman. He's someone who went out there and lived the catastrophe of his life.
- 2.25 He developed a doctrine of the Apollonian versus the Dionysian. There's a bit of a hint of Freud there because the Dionysian was a celebration of romantic impulse—the life of emotion and motivation. The more romantic artists of the 20th century still live a lifestyle like that. It's often characterized by a kind of hedonism. But the upside of it is that there's a vitality in it, an embodied vitality, that is easy to contrast with a kind of abstracted, dry-as-dust rationality that has a kind of cowardice in it as well, because there's something to be said for throwing yourself into life, even with the possibility of error beckoning.
- 2.26 Nietzsche wrote a fair bit about Apollo, the spirit of rationality, versus the spirit of Dionysus, and construed the dynamism of Western culture actually as an integration of those competing forces. And you could think of the Dionysian, in some sense, as the id and as the realm of motivation, the realm of fundamental emotion, and the rational as an attempt to make that propositional and logical, and that there are pathologies of both extremes, and that something like the integrated spirit is the proper balance between rationality, rational integration, and the existence of those underlying motivational states.
- 2.27 So, you could think of—there's lots of ways to construe this. One of the ways you could think about your capacity to be peaceful as an adult, let's say, is that you've learned to inhibit your aggressive impulses. That puts the Apollonian and the Dionysian in antithesis. But you could also say that isn't what happens when you become unified; it's that you take your capacity for aggression and you integrate it into a higher-order structure that is rational and coherent but that still retains the dynamism of the motivation.
- 2.28 And I think the people that you meet who are truly alive, they're not sexless people incapable of aggression, but they are people who have those lower order motivations, those more primordial and unidirectional motivations, integrated into something like an upper unity that has a rational

coherence across time, can serve its own purposes across the medium- and long-term, can integrate with other people, but still retain the dynamism of the **Dionysian**.

- 2.29 **Nietzsche** also noted, and I think lived out the proposition that the immersement in the **Dionysian** was a necessary source of revitalization. That's why people go to raves. That's why they go to rock concerts. That's why they want to dance to put themselves back under the grip of those more primordial drives. They're really subpersonalities because there's tremendous vitality associated with that, as opposed to a bloodless, abstracted, rational, top-down intellectual pretension. That's also, as I said, often indistinguishable from a kind of cowardice, cowardice in the face of the raw biology of life.
- 2.30 **Nietzsche** also—and he's **Freudian** in this sense—noted, and maybe he was the first philosopher, maybe, to do this, the first biologically oriented philosopher to note that, well, you're a multitude of wills, and those wills have a biological grounding. You might claim to be speaking for rationality, but God only knows what unconscious biological motivation has gripped your rationality and is using it to put forth its claims on your behavior.
- 2.31 **Nietzsche** was one of the first philosophers to ask the questions like, "What unconscious motivations —biologically instantiated—are driving even the philosophy that claims to be rational?" What force is Western rationality actually serving? Of course, the **Postmodernists** and the Neo-Marxists pursued that line of thought to a great degree, essentially concluding that all of our pretensions to rationality and objective truth are nothing but manifestations in some twisted sense of this **Nietzschean will to power**. It's all about dominance. It's all about oppression. It's all about me obtaining a position of authority and superiority in relationship to you. And all of my rational thought, even all of my scientific thought, is nothing but a manifestation of that fundamental drive.
- 2.32 Now, I think that's a preposterous claim, but it's not without merit, partly because there are people who orient themselves in the world like that. There are people who run on nothing but power. And it's certainly the case that the drive to domination and oppression is a major motivational drive. That doesn't mean it's the only one, and it certainly doesn't mean that it's either the superordinate one or that it should be, or inevitably is, the superordinate drive. That's where the **Postmodernists** and the Marxists go wrong. But underlying that is a perfectly reasonable set of propositions, which is: don't be so sure that your rational thought is merely a consequence, let's say, of the **Apollonian**.
- 2.33 So, little biographical information about **Nietzsche** to situate him. His father was Carl Ludwig, a pastor and teacher who only lived to be 36 years old. As I said, the evidence suggests that he died of an ailment that was quite similar to Nietzsche's. So, that's an interesting thing to keep in mind. His mother was Franziska. I don't know much about her. His sister was **Elisabeth**. She took care of him for 10 years after he devolved into this psychosis and sequence of strokes that eventually killed him. He learned Greek, Latin, Hebrew, and French at Schulpforta, a private school. It was a former Cistercian monastery, a very high-quality school that's still in operation today.

- 2.34 He was an amateur composer. When he was a young man, his compatriots included a set of wild, blasphemous, drunken poets. It sounds actually like quite a lot of fun. So, that's a good thing to see on the Nietzschean front, because my observations in my life—what's William Blake's line? "Wisdom through excess." It's a hell of a line and obviously a very dangerous ethos. But there is this idea, too, that I think is right, that especially when you're young, you have to throw yourself into excess to some degree, partly because how in the world are you going to find out where the actual boundaries are?
- 2.35 We know from the psychological literature, for example, that adolescents tend to do such things as shoplifting and breaking rules of that sort. You might say, "Is shoplifting, minor shoplifting, in and of itself a mark of pathology?" I can certainly say, "It's socially destabilizing and shouldn't be encouraged." But if you look at the outcomes—imagine there's two groups of adolescents, three. They break rules some of the time. That's one group. They never break rules, and they always break rules.
- 2.36 Well, in the they-always-break-rule categories—that's the antisocial types, childhood conduct disorder, the juvenile delinquents that become criminal. They're just breaking rules nonstop. One percent of the criminals manage 65% of the criminal activity. People specialize in antisocial behavior. It's typical Pareto distribution. A tiny proportion of the people are doing all the creative work. It applies to criminality just like it applies to the distribution of income.
- 2.37 So, breaking rules all the time—that's not such a good idea. It's not going to work out well for you because your life won't go well if you're criminal, especially if you're stupidly criminal. It's very hard to be criminal and not stupidly criminal because it's not an ethos that endears you to others, and it's not a good long-term strategy. And so, too much rule-breaking, that's not good.
- 2.38 But then, if you look in the population of teenagers that never break rules, and more and more teenagers are in that category now—they don't date, they don't have any early sexual experiences, they don't drink, they don't get their driver's license. They're very constrained and obedient. You think, "Great, they are disciplined." They are not. They're just constrained and obedient. That's not disciplined. That's not the same thing. And so, what you see in the group of young people who never break rules—much higher rates of depression and anxiety because it's not that they're moral; it's that they're cowardly and inhibited and infantile.
- 2.39 Nietzsche actually did a lovely job of differentiating this, and I think we'll probably run across it when we go through *Beyond Good and Evil*. One of the questions he brought up consistently about morality is, "Are you moral, or are you just too cowardly to break the rules?" And worse, maybe you're just too cowardly to break the rules, and you don't want to admit that, and so what you do is claim that your cowardice is actually evidence of your morality. That would be the sort of person who would shoplift in a riot, right? Because there's no real internal morality. There's actually only fear of the consequences. And then, when the consequences are lifted, someone like that will run riot when they have the opportunity.

- 2.40 And so, one of Nietzsche's questions of conscience, if I remember correctly, and I think that was in *Twilight of the Idols*, is, "Are you intimidated into obedience, or are you a moral agent?" And that's a very good thing to ask yourself whenever you think you're acting morally. It's like—let's say you refuse to be promiscuous. It's like, "Are women throwing themselves at you?" And if the answer is no, well, then what makes you think your lack of promiscuity constitutes a virtue?
- 2.41 The mere fact that you can't engage in something that might be regarded as immoral because you don't have the opportunity is no indication whatsoever that you're moral. It just might be an indication that no female can stand you, which is a much more likely, that's much more likely probability given the pickiness of women, even in the face of attractive men. So, I would say Nietzsche was no coward on the existential front. I like to see that there is evidence that his life was in accordance with his philosophy, that one flowed naturally out of the other and in a manner that I think was life-affirming.
- 2.42 1864. On graduation, he studied theology and classical philology at the University of Bonn. He was actually aiming at the ministry, and that's interesting, too, because it means that his faith, implicitly and explicitly, was of a sufficient motivating power so that the ministry was a pathway that was open to him. But after one semester, he lost his faith, which was very hard on his mother.
- 2.43 He's a very modern person in that regard, too, because the typical pattern—I don't know for your generation, most of you seem to be somewhere between 20 and 35, I would say—when I grew up, most people went to church, and the typical pattern would be that in adolescence, people would lose their faith and leave the church. Now, most people don't go to church, so you don't have faith to lose in the first place. But Nietzsche was an early adopter of that proclivity, let's say. And that's another bit of evidence that he was someone who was living 100 years in the future, let's say.
- 2.44 In 1862, in one of his earlier writings—I don't believe this was published—he argued that historical research discredited Christian teachings. And I think what he meant by that was that Biblical history couldn't be read simply as empirical history, something like that. And so, at minimum, if Christian teachings were true, they weren't true in the way that empirical history is true. And that argument still rages.
- 2.45 He read Ludwig Feuerbach, a philosopher who wrote a book called *The Essence of Christianity*. And in that book, Feuerbach argued that people created God, rather than the reverse. To modern people, that seems self-evident. And that means that we suffer from the opposite delusion that people suffered from, let's say, in the 1850s, where it was obvious that human beings were the creation of God. We think now it's obvious that God is the creation of people. And the truth of the matter is nothing is so obvious.
- 2.46 The world is a very complicated place, and the notion that there's a transcendent implicate order isn't a mere primitive superstition. And cognitive neuroscientists, among other people, are grappling with that reality in great detail at the present time. So we'll see how that all —you

might say people stretched up to God at the same time God descended. That might be another way of thinking about it. That's certainly another alternative, and we'll explore to some degree what that means as we walk through Nietzsche's thought.

- 2.47 In 1865, he awakened to philosophy under the influence of Schopenhauer, who wrote a book called *World as Will and Representation*. And that's a lot different than world as objective reality, right? World as will—that brings this objective into it. And representation—well, what do you see when you look at the world? As we asked earlier: are your perceptions the world? And the answer is, well, the answer is, "It's complicated." Not in detail, only in a slice at minimum, and how that slice is related to the actual structure of the objective, or even if there is such a thing as the independent, transcendent objective, that's open to a serious question.
- 2.48 So, Schopenhauer was investigating that on the representation and will side. He believed that the knowledge of objects was phenomenal. So, a phenomenon is something that shines forth to you. Your experience is phenomenal. You perceive not objects but phenomena. And what's the difference? Well, it's complicated.
- 2.49 That has a function. That's why you see it. This has a function. The thing you sit on, that's a chair. Why is a bean bag and a stump—why are bean bags and stumps both chairs? They share no sets of features in common because you think, well, two things are in the same class if they share sets of features, objective features. How about a chair? How about a stump and a bean bag? No features in common. They're both made of matter. That's not a very inclusive category. Well, the answer is, "You can sit on both."
- 2.50 Well, that begs the question, "If the basis for your perceptual category—chair—is a function, then what makes you think that the world you see is one of objects?" And in fact, I think the answer is—I really believe this has been settled on the cognitive neuroscience and computational front—you do not see objects; you see micro-narratives. Everything you see is something that serves a purpose.
- 2.51 And it makes sense if you think about it. Practically, for a moment or two, you're trying to orient yourself in the world and to use the world to further your life. So, what you see in the world are those objects that afford utility. Those are affordances. That's a term that comes from the neuroscience of perception and affordance. A chair is that object that affords you the opportunity to sit, to be seated.
- 2.52 And see, it makes a hash of any simple empiricism because if the objects from which you're deriving your conception of the world are saturated with purpose in their microstructure, then you're not deriving a model of the objective world as a consequence of your perception because the ethos is there, to begin with.
- 2.53 I'd say, "Why do you see a chair?" Well, so you can sit. "Why do you need to sit?" So you can rest. "Why do you need to rest?" So you exhaust yourself. "Why not exhaust yourself?" Well, because then you die. There's a direct link between the perception of the affordance and the fact that you want to stay alive. It's embedded right in the perception. It's not a secondary

overlay on an objective perception. That's well established, partly because there are so many things to see in the world.

- 2.54 In anything that you're looking at, you could get lost in the details forever and be unable to perceive it all. You have to narrow it dramatically. You ignore almost everything in every act of perception. You ignore virtually everything and concentrate on only something tiny. What is that? And why that? Part of the answer is, "Does it serve your will?" Is it a representation that serves your will? That would be the Nietzschean question, which would be the will to power, the will to express the essence of your life as you move forward through the confines of your life.
- 2.55 And so, that begs an even deeper question, "To what degree are your object perceptions so-called saturated with motivation and emotion, with biological intent right at the level of the perception, not laid above that at the level of emotion, like a secondary overlaid emotion." Because we think, as moderns, we think, "You see the objective world, and then you assign a value to that perception." It's like, "No, you can't see the world without the implicit value." It's not possible. There's no screening mechanism without the implicit value.
- 2.56 And then, the question becomes, "What's the structure of implicit value?" That's actually—that is the question, by the way, that is tearing our culture apart: what is the structure of implicit value? Because the left-wingers figured this out. The Postmodernists figured this out—they're students of Nietzsche as well—that our perceptions are saturated with value. But then, they leapt to the Marxist conclusion that all that value that saturates our perceptions is nothing but the expression of the will to domination and power.
- 2.57 And so, they said, "We need a story to orient ourselves." It's necessary by which to orient ourselves. And the story is one of domination. Well, that's a pretty damn dismal story because it means that the ruler of the world, in some cosmic sense, is nothing but the expression of the desire to dominate. They can't come up with a more—I believe, you can't come up with a more corrosive proposition than that.
- 2.58 And I would say that is not the proposition that Nietzsche developed. His will to power is not the same will to power at all as the Marxist formulation of power in relationship to the oppressor and the oppressed. They are not the same thing at all. It's really too bad that the same word is even involved because it's hard to know. What does power mean? I can force you to do something, but to have the power to do something means to have the ability, the energy, and the material resources at hand to undertake something. In that sense, power is the mere capability to make opportunity manifest.
- 2.59 That's not the same thing as the willingness and ability to dominate and exploit. Even within the word 'power' itself, there's that ambivalence. But all power is not merely oppression; it's also ability. And so, I suppose the Nietzschean will to power is something like the implicit desire to manifest the full range of your abilities. It would be something like that, to expand everything you have in the service of being. It's not a preservation ethos. You don't want security. You don't want protection. In fact, the opposite in some real manner: you want to expose yourself as

much as possible to the vagaries of the world to compel your development in as multidimensional manner as possible.

- 2.60 Kant had worked on similar problems. He believed that we couldn't see the world without imposing a priori perceptual axioms on the world. He thought that time and space themselves were axiomatic structures undergirding perception. That we didn't perceive time and space; we used them as mechanisms of perception. So, they're axiomatic. They're elements of implicit faith. Kant was very interested in exploring the domain of the axioms necessary to structure perception and was one of the first philosophers to make a very strong case that perception itself, the operation of the world, was impossible without this a priori structure.
- 2.61 And then, you might think—well, you can think about that biologically as well. It's not like you're a free-floating, bodiless spirit that can perceive the world. Whatever you are took 3.5 billion years to aggregate itself across time. You come into the world with this remarkable embodied structure, which lays an interpretive framework on the world. Without that, there's no possibility of perception at all. So, you bring to reality an a priori interpretive framework.
- 2.62 Then, what's the nature of that a priori interpretive framework? What should it be? That's another question. Not only what is it, but what should it be? And then, what does it necessarily have to be? You might say, "You could guide yourself with just aggression and lust." And why not do that? And the answer seems to be it doesn't work very well, even in relationship to fulfilling the demands of aggression and lust in the medium- to long-term. You can't play it out as an iterating strategy. You're a 2-year-old, right? It's fully impulsive. And maybe you get what you want in the second, but not in a way that makes sure it's going to be there tomorrow.
- 2.63 So, you can think of that as an intrinsic constraint on the manner in which will might have to make itself manifest. And then, you can think that that's complicated by the fact that not only do you have to contend with your multiple iterations across time, the fact that you're going to be here in a month and have to live with the consequences of your action, but that you have to live in a web of social relationships with others. And unless you treat them in a particular manner—well, if you treat them badly enough, they're going to be very aggressive towards you, and they're certainly not going to cooperate. And if you treat them well—whatever well means—maybe they'll fall all over themselves to offer you what you need and want.
- 2.64 And then, you can imagine there's only a certain number of ways that you can treat other people that is going to make that outcome happen. And you know what that is because you know what people you want to be around. And when they're at their best, you think, "I wish everyone could treat me like that all the time." And there's no real difference between that wish and wishing that you could be the person that could do that for other people. It's the same thing.
- 2.65 Then, the question is, "What might that pattern be?" Nietzsche associated that with his phraseology, this will to expansive power, this desire to integrate the Dionysian and the Apollonian, and to march forthrightly through life. There's not a lot of sociological analysis in

Nietzsche, and I actually think that's one of his weaknesses. He's a very psychological thinker like Dostoevsky, like Freud, like Jung.

- 2.66 I don't believe that he paid enough attention to the minimum set of axiomatic presuppositions necessary to make a sustainable society at the family level, at the community level, at the state level, at the political level. He never got married. He never had a family. He wasn't able to integrate himself into a community, even on his own. And his intense, romantic, creative philosophizing made him a very isolated and lonesome individual. And he asked Lou Andreas-Salomé, one of the strangest women in the last 160 years—she had a large influence on Jung as well—he asked her to marry him three times, and she refused. He had a strange relationship with her and the man that she was with. It's worth looking into as a side note if you're interested in such biographical details.
- 2.67 But it isn't obvious that he managed his life effectively on the communal side. Jung pointed to that as a pathology not only of Nietzsche with regard to his philosophizing but to the philosophizing of other Western intellectual males who were single bachelors. So, that's a reflection of an inadequacy in their philosophical orientation to the world, arguably. And you can debate that. Can you be healthy and wise, single? And I would say, I think the answer to that is no, but you could at least debate it.
- 2.68 I think that if you're—because sometimes you might think you have to be the dramatic, romantic outsider who breaks all the rules to break new ground. And there's some credibility to that viewpoint. But you might say, "What makes you so sure you can be healthy in the absence of an intimate relationship and children and a family that's functional and a network of friendships and a plethora of business arrangements? What makes you think you don't need all those interactive constraints to keep yourself straight in your actions and your thought?"
- 2.69 And with the alternative of that is to think that you're somehow self-creating and that you can organize it all within. And that idea eventually leads to something like the radical claim of subjective identity. It's the Postmodern claim that everyone makes now, "That I am, that I am. Whatever my identity is, goes." No, it doesn't. You have to get along with other people. If you want them around, you have to negotiate your identity all the time. If your philosophy doesn't reflect that, then maybe it's wanting. I think that is an open question with regards to Nietzschean philosophy.
- 2.70 Military service in 1867. Apparently, he was a fine rider, another example of his ability to be physically courageous and to take part in romantic and adventurous activities in the real world. He wasn't an effete intellectual. In 1868, he met Richard Wagner, the great German composer, master of mythology, and fell under his sway. That was an indication of this Nietzschean proclivity to be enraptured by poetry and music. That's the Dionysian element of high culture, in this case, but outside of the standard philosophical realm.
- 2.71 There's something deeply musical and narrative about Nietzsche's writing, which gives it its dramatic force. He's a very fun philosopher to read, I would say, especially for young people,

because the philosophy is so adventurous and romantic. It's not dry and academic at all, and so that makes it very exciting.

- 2.72 As I said, in 1869, he became a professor of classical philology. In 1870, he was a medical orderly in the Franco-Prussian War, which I imagine was—you can barely imagine how brutal an occupation that must have been in 1860. Filthy battlefield conditions and no antibiotics, no real modern notion of sepsis. Oh, God. Brutal, brutal. And there's some indication that perhaps that's when he contracted syphilis. That's the speculation.
- 2.73 He also knew Franz Liszt. Liszt was an early—he was one of the first musicians, perhaps, at least on an international scale, who produced the same sort of furor as Frank Sinatra, say, or the Beatles. He had huge crowds of adoring fans wherever he went. And what did he call Liszt? Liszt, comma, or the Art of Running After Women. And so Franz Liszt was a great musical genius. He could sightread any piece of classical music, regardless of complexity, at the first sitting. So, he could sit and open a Beethoven sonata he'd never played and play it without error. Liszt's music is also wildly romantic and builds these castles of sound, these columns of sound, that are absolutely remarkable. He was a popular sensation, like Richard Wagner in the late 1800s, in part for a while, of Nietzsche's circle of romantic deviants, let's say.
- 2.74 In 1872, he published *The Birth of Tragedy*. His colleagues evinced little enthusiasm for this radically creative work. That's something that hasn't changed in academia at all. Academia tends to be populated by people who worship the products of the intellect, their disembodied intellect. There's an element of, I would say, cowardice in relationship to the romantic that accompanies that.
- 2.75 We did some studies of what predicted success in graduate school in science, and creativity was correlated zero. We also looked at whether creativity, as a temperamental predictor, predicted university grades. It doesn't predict it at all. IQ does. General cognitive ability. So, smarter people do better, and conscientiousness does. So, disciplined hard work predicts success as a graduate student, and as a scientist, and as an undergraduate. It's the second-best predictor after general cognitive ability. No predictive power of creativity.
- 2.76 You can get cynical about that and say, "Why don't the universities reward creativity?" And the answer is, "How the hell do you reward creativity?" By definition, the creative person jumps out of the evaluative landscape. It's like, so maybe I would evaluate you on a set of criteria. But if I play within that set of criteria, I'm not creative. So, how the hell can you expect an institution to reward creativity? It couldn't be an institution if it rewarded creativity.
- 2.77 And that's actually the problem with institutions; they tend to ossify because you need creative input across time. Because things change, they tend to reward diligent striving towards an identified goal, which is lovely if it's the right goal, and cataclysmic if the goal has to shift. And the creative person comes along and says, "Hey, you know all that work you're doing? Well, you're going that way, and the right direction is that way." And how is an institution supposed to cope with that? What institutions generally do when that happens is die.

- 2.78 That's why you see these huge institutions that dominate the S&P 500, for example, or that are on the Dow Jones Index; they last for 30 years. And the typical family fortune lasts for three generations. What happens is an institution arrays itself around a creative insight, and it plays that out to exhaustion, and then it disappears. And so, maybe if you were fortunate, you could produce an institution that was dynamic enough to reconfigure itself, but that almost never happens. First of all, it's very unlikely that any institution will rise to the top to begin with, given how many institutions there are. Then you think about how unlikely it is that the same institution is going to do that twice or three times. It just doesn't happen.
- 2.79 Anyway, Nietzsche was a very creative philosopher, extraordinarily creative philosopher. That put him at odds with the standard academic tradition, because the standard academic tradition, too, is one of incremental progress. So, if you're a typical run-of-the-mill scientist at a university—well, first of all, most of the things that you discover just aren't true because you're not any good at what you do.
- 2.80 Here's a question: How many bad restaurants do there have to be for there to be one good restaurant? The answer is, "We don't know," but zero is the wrong answer. We could only have good restaurants. No, you couldn't. You have to have terrible restaurants where people stumble forward, barely mastering the beginning processes of cooking, before you can produce anyone who can be an expert at it. You need a lot of mess, and waste, and noise to get anything of value.
- 2.81 In the scientific community, it's the same thing. Most scientific papers simply—they're just wrong. These aren't facts that are being laid out. The ideas are shallow, and that's partly because many of them are published by graduate students. It's their first damn publication. What do you expect? They barely hit the threshold to be able to publish. What's the probability that they've discovered a new useful fact?
- 2.82 There's these whole societies that have gone thousands and thousands of years, even societies as dynamic as the ancient Egyptian societies, where the archeological record shows zero technological improvement in spans of thousands of years. And yet, we expect entry-level graduate students to have actually discovered a useful new fact. It's very improbable. And so, you have to expect that institutions are going to populate themselves with people who are moving incrementally at best and very, very minor flashes of creativity.
- 2.83 You see this in grant applications in science, too. If you put forward a grant application that contains a radically new idea, the probability that you'll get funding is zero. What you have to do, and this was especially true when I worked in the U.S. because the grants are actually quite large, and so it gets even worse, is not only do you have to do the next blatantly obvious thing that anybody who knows the literature would be familiar with and also see, because those are the people who'd be reviewing your grant, you basically have to have done the studies before you apply to fund the studies. Because what the grant agencies want is, "Have you done some pilot studies?" What that means is, "Can you ensure us that what you're hypothesizing is definitely going to make itself manifest?"

- 2.84 Well, if that's the horizon of creativity, you can see that that's not creative. It's like, we already did this. Now, it's not quite that bleak because what happens is people apply for a grant to do one project, and then they don't do it. They do the next thing they were planning to do. Everybody knows that. It's partly because, by the time you get the damn money, the ideas that you put forward are two years old, and if you have any sense at all, you've either dispensed with that or you're on to something new. So, it's not quite that dismal, but you get the idea.
- 2.85 In any case, Nietzsche's work wasn't accepted either by his colleagues or by the general public. What was it? I think we'll come up to this. One of the next books that he published, he printed 40 copies and gave most of them away to his friends. He met with very little success in his life on the publication front. It was the same with *Beyond Good and Evil*.
- 2.86 And so, it's another example—a painful example—that's echoed in the life of someone like Van Gogh, who I think Van Gogh's paintings now have sold for more than any other paintings in human history. But I think he sold two paintings his whole life. So, that's another problem with living 100 years into the future. It's like, "You're right, but it's a little early. No, you don't have a market." "This is going to be the next big thing." It's like, "Yeah, way after you're dead." So, that's not so good. That's not so good.
- 2.87 So, because this book, *Birth of Tragedy*, was not well accepted, he attempted unsuccessfully to transfer to the University of Basel, but they didn't take him, partly because they weren't very happy with his work. From '72 to '76, he worked on the *Untimely Meditations* collection of four essays. And in 1878, he published *Human All Too Human*, which was a book of *aphorisms*. In 1879, he resigned. He was short-sighted. His vision was extremely impaired. He had terrible migraines and serious digestive trouble, and that was just the beginning of his catastrophe.
- 2.88 He worked as an independent author from '79 to '89 in Switzerland, Italy, and France. When his eyesight started to fail dramatically, he actually started to type. So, one of the first great writers who turned to technology to augment his ability. In '82, he published *The Gay Science*. At the same time, he met Paul Rée and Lou Andreas-Salomé, which we talked about. He fell in love with her, but that wasn't returned. He proposed marriage to her three times. He planned to establish a commune with Rée and Salomé. His sister opposed that. She served as his protector and his exploiter, I suppose, at the same time—a complex relationship.
- 2.89 And he started writing *Thus Spake Zarathustra*. He wrote much of the first part in 10 days. It's a really revelatory work. It's very, very dreamlike. It's like a fairy tale. And it's written in a style—it's very unlike anything he ever wrote. Because Nietzsche is a very—even though his writing is packed with information, the bulk of his writing is very clear. He's a very, very lucid writer. It's difficult because of the density of ideas, but very lucid, whereas *Thus Spake Zarathustra* has this Old Testament tone to it, both on the narrative end and on the stylistic end.
- 2.90 It's often the case that a revelatory idea bursts forth in image and poetic language. Generally, what people do, especially if they're writing academically and scientifically, is they move away from the dream and the image and the poem. They take all the romantic emotion out of it, and

they make it into something that's semantic and propositional. And I suppose that typifies Nietzsche's more normative writings, but *Thus Spake Zarathustra* is far into the dream. And so it's a very, very dense and rich book, but also one that's even more difficult to unpack because it's still so dreamlike.

- 2.91 He tried in 1883 and failed to obtain a lecturing post at the University of Leipzig due, in his own words, to his attitude towards Christianity and the concept of God. Atheism was still a sufficiently radical stance at that point to make anyone who put forward such views, an object of skepticism to those who were more traditional in their viewpoint. In '85, he printed 40 copies of the fourth part of *Zarathustra*. That was it. Distributed them to friends.
- 2.92 He broke with his publisher, Ernst Schmeitzner, over the issue of anti-Semitism. So, anti-Semitism was starting to emerge broadly across Europe at this point, and Nietzsche was not the friend of anyone who was anti-Semitic. It was particularly interesting because, of course, the Nazis eventually attempted to claim Nietzsche as their own, partly because his writings had been warped as a consequence of being filtered through his sister, who eventually married a very prominent anti-Semite. But Nietzsche himself believed that that was—well, he said in his own words, "Anti-Semitism should be utterly rejected with cold contempt by every sensible mind."
- 2.93 He printed *Beyond Good and Evil* at his own expense, but his continued illness made prolonged work impossible. It was at that time that his sister married this well-known anti-Semite, Bernhard Förster. In '88, he published *The Twilight of the Idols* and *the Antichrist*—great books, very short. That's truly where Nietzsche was philosophizing most intensely with a hammer. *Ecce Homo* in 1888 as well.
- 2.94 In '89, Nietzsche broke down. He witnessed the flogging of a horse in Turin, threw his arms around its neck to protect it, and then collapsed, and so that's an indication of the goodness of his heart, you might say. This man was a soldier in a number of wars. He's a tough character. He's bounced all around Europe. He's sophisticated enough to be consorting with the cream of European society at that part. He's no prude, and he's no coward, and yet he's compassionate enough.
- 2.95 So, while this is the event that precipitated his illness, it's a great historical irony in this. So, Nietzsche—I'll do a lecture on this at one point—Nietzsche and Dostoevsky's thoughts parallel one another to a degree that's uncanny. Nietzsche is really a character in a Dostoevsky novel. That's the best way to think about it. And even more than you think now, Nietzsche was more aware of Dostoevsky than earlier scholarship had indicated. So, there might have been more explicit overlap in their thought than people have contemplated heretofore. But I think it's more a matter of parallelism in some sense. They were both people who were living 150 years into the future, and because they were both in the same place, the same set of ideas made itself manifest within them.
- 2.96 Dostoevsky explored that primarily in narrative, where Nietzsche took that a step further in abstraction and explored it in philosophy. This meant that Nietzsche was more explicit than

Dostoevsky, because philosophers were more explicit than the novelists. But it also meant, I would say, that Dostoevsky could get even farther than Nietzsche. I'll give you an example.

- 2.97 In *The Brothers Karamazov*, two of the characters are Ivan and Alyosha. Ivan is a very charismatic atheist, and Dostoevsky put some of the most powerful pro-atheistic arguments that have ever been laid out on the page in the mouth of Ivan. Ivan wins all the arguments with Alyosha, his younger brother, who's a monastic novice and kind of a naive person, like a very good person and recognized as good by everyone around him, but without the charisma of his older brother and without that cutting rationalism that characterizes this brilliant Ivan. And Ivan puts forth these devastating atheistic arguments that Dostoevsky was wrestling with in his own mind.
- 2.98 But in the book itself, in *The Brothers Karamazov*, Ivan wins all the arguments, but it's clear that Alyosha is the morally superior character. He's the better man, and Dostoevsky is unable to reconcile the fact that Ivan is the master of rational argumentation with the fact that Alyosha is the better man. But he can show you that as the story unfolds. And that's the advantage of narrative over philosophy, at least in principle.
- 2.99 Nietzsche couldn't lay out the philosophy of someone axiomatically good like Alyosha. The philosophy hadn't matured to that point. Nietzsche, in some sense, could lay out the philosophy of Ivan, but Dostoevsky could lay out the character of Alyosha, and it was a particular goal of Dostoevsky to do this because he did something similar in a book called *The Idiot*. The main character in the book, *The Idiot*, is Prince Myshkin, who's an avatar of Christ. It's quite obvious in the text. Everyone regards him as a fool. But he's a holy fool. He's a very good man. He's a prince, and he doesn't act like an aristocratic, power-mad prince should act. He acts like a holy fool, and it's clear in the book that he's, again, the better man, and that's encapsulated in a very lovely way in the narrative.
- 2.100 Anyway, Dostoevsky and Nietzsche's thoughts parallel one another to an uncanny degree. So, for example, in *Crime and Punishment*, Dostoevsky's character, Raskolnikov, is possessed by the kind of rationalist arguments that Nietzsche knew would emerge in the aftermath of the death of God. And Raskolnikov actually tries to construe himself as a *superman* who can create his own values.
- 2.101 Now, without reference to Nietzsche—Dostoevsky didn't know about Nietzsche—Raskolnikov convinces himself to commit murder. Dostoevsky sets up the story so brilliantly because he makes Raskolnikov a sympathetic character, and he gives him every good reason to commit murder. Dostoevsky delves into this notion. It's like, "Are there circumstances under which murder becomes ethically required?"
- 2.102 Raskolnikov believes his sister, in a sense, is going to sell herself into prostitution to further the financing of Raskolnikov's studies to become a lawyer. Now, she's not a prostitute. She's going to marry an older man who's kind of a tyrant, a cold, bitter tyrant, who would provide her with sufficient financial resources. She believes that's morally acceptable because she wants to

support her mother and her brother. Raskolnikov wants to be a lawyer so he can do all the good things that he could do with an education.

- 2.103 At the same time, he's under the thumb of a landlady who's grasping malevolent, nasty, horrible, corrupt character who also tyrannizes a mentally challenged niece and basically keeps her in a state of slavery. And so Raskolnikov thinks, "I could just kill the landlady. I could get her money, I could free my sister, and all the people this landlady is oppressing would be free, and so would her tyrannized niece."
- 2.104 And then, he's torturing himself, and he's hungry and broke and sick because he's hungry and broke, and so he can't think very clearly. But he's torturing himself with recriminations about his own moral cowardice in his inability to commit this act, which he now regards as moral. He's dispensed with the tenets of Judeo-Christian ethics. He doesn't believe that murder in and of itself is wrong, believes that if he was elevated to the point of being the **superman**, that he could take unto himself the power to make such decisions, and he works himself up into a frenzy.
- 2.105 This is part of the story, and it overlaps with this horse story in an extremely uncanny way. So, I'm going to read it to you because it's quite interesting. So, this is Raskolnikov, and he's plotting this murder, and he's up in his little horrible, wretched apartment, starving away, and he has this dream.
- 2.106 "Raskolnikov had a fearful dream. He dreamt he was back in his childhood in the little town of his birth. He was a child about seven years old walking into the country with his father on the evening of a holiday. It was a grey and heavy day, the country was exactly as he remembered it; indeed, he recalled it far more vividly in his dream than he had done in memory. The little town stood on a level flat as bare as the hand, not even a willow near it; only in the far distance, a copse lay, a dark blur on the very edge of the horizon. A few paces beyond the last market garden stood a tavern, a big tavern, which had always aroused in him a feeling of aversion, even of fear, when he walked by it with his father. There was always a crowd there, always shouting, laughter and abuse, hideous hoarse singing and often fighting. Drunken and horrible-looking figures were hanging about the tavern."
- 2.107 Russia, hey, what a place.
- 2.108 "He used to cling close to his father, trembling all over when he met them. Near the tavern, the road became a dusty track, the dust of which was always black. It was a winding road, and about a hundred paces further on, it turned to the right to the graveyard. In the middle of the graveyard stood a stone church with a green cupola where he used to go to mass two or three times a year with his father and mother, when a service was held in memory of his grandmother, who had long been dead, and whom he had never seen. On these occasions, they used to take on a white dish tied up in a table napkin, a special rice pudding with raisins stuck in it in the shape of a cross. He loved that church, the old-fashioned, unadorned ikons and the old priest with the shaking head. Near his grandmother's grave, which was marked by a stone, was the little grave of his younger brother who had died at six months old. He did not remember him

at all, but he had been told about his little brother, and whenever he visited the graveyard he used religiously and reverently to cross himself and to bow down and kiss the little grave.

- 2.109** And now he dreamt that he was walking with his father past the tavern on the way to the graveyard; he was holding his father's hand and looking with dread at the tavern. A peculiar circumstance attracted his attention: there seemed to be some sort of festivity going on, there were crowds of gaily dressed townspeople, peasant women, their husbands, and riff-raff of all sorts, all singing and all more or less drunk. Near the entrance of the tavern stood a cart, but a strange cart. It was one of those big carts usually drawn by heavy cart-horses and laden with casks of wine or other heavy goods.
- 2.110** He always liked looking at those great cart-horses with their long manes, thick legs, and slow even pace, drawing along a perfect mountain with no appearance of effort, as though it were easier going with a load than without it. But now, strange to say, in the shafts of such a cart he saw a thin little sorrel beast, one of those peasants' nags which he had often seen straining their utmost under a heavy load of wood or hay, especially when the wheels were stuck in the mud or in a rut. And the peasants would beat them so cruelly, sometimes even about the nose and eyes, and he always felt so sorry for them that he almost cried, and his mother used to take him away from the window.
- 2.111** All of a sudden there was a great uproar of shouting, singing and the balalaika, and from the tavern a number of big and very drunken peasants came out, wearing red and blue shirts and coats thrown over their shoulders. 'Get in,' shouted one of them, a young, thick-necked peasant with a fleshy face red as a carrot. 'I'll take you all, get in.' But at once there was an outbreak of laughter and exclamations in the crowd.
- 2.112** 'Take us all with a beast like that!' 'Why, Mikolka, you're crazy to put a nag like that in such a cart?' 'And this mare is twenty if she's a day, mates!' 'Get in. I'll take you all,' Mikolka shouted, leaping first into the cart, seizing the reins and standing straight up in front. 'The bay has gone with Matvey,' he shouted from the cart—'and this brute, mates, is just breaking my heart. I feel as though I could kill her. She's just eating her head off. Get in, I tell you! I'll make her gallop! She'll gallop!' and he picked up the whip, preparing himself with relish to flog the little mare. 'Get in. Come along!' The crowd laughed. 'Do you hear, she'll gallop!' 'Gallop indeed! She's not had a gallop in her for the last ten years!' 'She'll jog along!' 'Don't you mind her, mates, bring a whip each of you, get ready!' 'All right! Give it to her!'
- 2.113** They all clambered into Mikolka's cart, laughing and making jokes. Six men got in there and there was still room for more. They hauled in a fat, rosy-cheeked woman dressed in red cotton, in a pointed, beaded headdress and thick leather shoes; she was cracking nuts and laughing. The crowd round them was laughing too and indeed, how could they help laughing? That wretched nag was to drag all the cart load of them at a gallop! Two young fellows in the cart were just getting whips ready to help Mikolka. With a cry of 'now,' the mare tugged with all her might, but far from galloping, could scarcely move forward; she struggled with her legs, gasping and shrinking from the blows of the three whips which were showered upon her like hail. The

laughter in the cart and the crowd was redoubled, but Mikolka flew into a rage and furiously thrashed the mare, as though he supposed she really could gallop.

- 2.114 'Let me get in, too, mates,' shouted a young man in the crowd whose appetite was aroused. 'Get in, all get in,' cried Mikolka, 'she will draw you all. I'll beat her to death.' And he thrashed and thrashed at the mare, beside himself with fury. 'Father, Father,' he cried, 'What are they doing? Father, they're beating the poor horse!' 'Come along,' said his father. 'They're drunken and foolish, they are in fun; come away, don't look!' and he tried to draw him away, but he tore himself away from his hand, and, beside himself with horror, ran to the horse.
- 2.115 The poor beast was in a bad way. She was gasping, standing still, then tugging again and almost falling. 'Beat her to death,' cried Mikolka. 'It's come to that. I'll do for her!' 'What are you about? Are you a Christian, you devil?' shouted an old man in the crowd. 'Did everyone, ever see the like? A wretched nag like that, pulling such a cartload?' said another. 'You'll kill her,' shouted the third. 'Don't meddle! It's my property, I'll do what I choose. Get in, more of you! Get in, all of you! I will have her go at a gallop!'
- 2.116 All at once, laughter broke into a roar and crowded everything: the mare, roused by the shower of blows, began feebly kicking. Even the old man could not help smiling. To think of a wretched little beast like that trying to kick! Two lads in the crowd snapped up whips and ran to the mare to beat her about the ribs. One ran each side. 'Hit her in the face, in the eyes, in the eyes,' cried Mikolka. 'Give us a song, mates,' someone shouted in the cart and everyone in the cart joined in a riotous song, jingling a tambourine and whistling. The woman went on cracking nuts and laughing.
- 2.117 He ran beside the mare, in front of her, saw her being whipped across the eyes, right in the eyes! He was crying. He felt choking, his tears were streaming. One of the men gave him a cut with a whip across the face, but he did not feel it. Wringing his hands and screaming, he rushed up to the grey-haired old man with the grey beard, who was shaking his head in disapproval. One woman seized him by the hand and would have taken him away, but he tore herself from him and ran back to the mare. She was almost at the last gasp, but began kicking once more.
- 2.118 'I'll teach you to kick,' Mikolka shouted ferociously. He threw down the whip, bent forward and picked up from the bottom of the cart a long, thick shaft, he took hold of one end with both hands and with an effort brandished it over the mare. 'He'll crush her,' was shouted round him. 'He'll kill her!' 'It's my property,' shouted Mikolka and brought the shaft down with a swinging blow. There was a sound of a heavy thud. 'Thrash her, thrash her!' 'Why have you stopped?' shouted voices in the crowd.
- 2.119 And Mikolka swung the shaft a second time and it fell a second time on the spine of the luckless mare. She sank back on her haunches, but lurched forward and tugged forward with all her force, tugged first on one side and then on the other, trying to move the cart. But the six whips were attacking her in all directions, and the shaft was raised again and fell upon her a third time,

then a fourth, with heavy, measured blows. He was in a fury that he could not kill her at one blow.

- 2.120 'She's a tough one,' was shouted in the crowd. 'She'll fall in a minute, mates, there will soon be an end of her,' said an admiring spectator in the crowd. 'Fetch an ax to finish her off,' shouted a third. 'I'll show you! Stand off,' Mikolka screamed frantically; he threw down the shaft, stooped down in the cart, and picked up an iron crow bar. 'Look out,' he shouted, and with all his might, he dealt a stunning blow at the poor mare. The blow fell, the mare staggered, sank back, tried to pull, but the bar fell again with a swinging blow on her back, and she fell on the ground like a log.
- 2.121 'Finish her off,' shouted Mikolka, and he leapt beside himself, out of the cart. Several young men, also flushed with drink, seized anything they could come across—whips, sticks, and poles, and ran to the dying mare. Mikolka stood on one side and began dealing random blows with the crowbar. The mare stretched out her head, drew a long breath and died.
- 2.122 'You butchered her,' someone shouted in the crowd. 'Why wouldn't she gallop then?' 'My property!' shouted Mikolka with bloodshot eyes, brandishing the bar in his hands. He stood as though regretting that he had nothing more to beat. 'No mistake about it, you are not a Christian,' many voices were shouting in the crowd. But the poor boy, beside himself, made his way, screaming through the crowd to the sorrel nag, put his arms around her bleeding dead head and kissed it, the eyes and the lips. Then he jumped up and flew in a frenzy with his little fists out at Mikolka. At that instant, his father, who had been running after him, snatched him up and carried him out of the crowd. 'Come along, come! Let's go home,' he said to him.
- 2.123 'Father! Why did they kill the poor horse!' he sobbed, but his voice broke and the words came in shrieks from his panting chest. 'They are drunk. They are brutal. It's not our business!' said his father. He put his arms round his father but he felt choked. He tried to draw breath, to cry out—and woke up. He waked up, gasping for breath, his hair soaked with perspiration, and stood up in terror. 'Thank God that was only a dream,' Raskolnikov said, sitting down under a tree and drawing deep breaths. 'But what is it? Is it some fever coming on? Such a hideous dream.' He felt utterly broken. Darkness and confusion were in his soul. He rested his elbows on his knees and leaned his head on his hands.
- 2.124 'Good God,' he cried. 'Can it be? Can it be that I shall really take an ax, that I shall strike her on the head, split her skull open, that I shall tread in the sticky warm blood, break the lock, steal and tremble, hide all spattered in the blood with the ax? Good God, can it be?' He was shaking like a leaf as he said this. 'But why am I going on like this?' He continued sitting up again as it were in profound amazement. 'I knew that I could never bring myself to it. So what have I been torturing myself for till now? Yesterday, when I went to make that experiment, I realized completely that I could never do it. Why am I going over it again then? Why am I hesitating? As I came down the stairs yesterday, I said to myself that it was base, loathsome, vile. The very thought of it made me feel sick and filled me with horror. No, I couldn't do it. I couldn't do it. Granted, granted, there's no flaw in all that reasoning. Oh, that all that I have concluded this last

month is clear as day, true as arithmetic. My God, anyway, I couldn't bring myself to it. I couldn't do it. I couldn't do it. Why then? Why am I still?'

- 2.125 Well, that was the beginning of the end for Nietzsche. And that parallelism in the story and the events of his life is remarkable, given the parallelism of the ideas that they were running through. A remarkable narrative coincidence.
- 2.126 Nietzsche wrote a bit more after this breakdown. They call them his delusion notes. He said, one, "I had Caiaphas"—the judge of Christ—"put in fetters. And also, last year, I was crucified by the German doctors in a very drawn-out manner. Wilhelm, Bismarck, and all anti-Semites abolished." Delusional writings. He commanded the German Emperor to go to Rome to be shot. He spent years in a psychiatric clinic in Basel. At that time, the *Twilight of the Idols* was released, and his work received its first real public attention.
- 2.127 Diagnosis? Tertiary syphilis. Syphilis, a sexually transmitted infectious disease, can mimic almost any disease. It was an absolutely terrible scourge. Maybe the worst thing that hit Victorian Europe at the last part of the 1800s. Maybe manic depressive disorder, meningioma, mercury poisoning, and then this hereditary illness that his father suffered from. In '98, '99, he had two strokes, was paralyzed, unable to speak or walk, contracted pneumonia in 1900, and died on the 25th of August. Yes, so that's a good time to stop.

3. Questioning Truth

AT A GLANCE

Begins the text itself. Explains the aphoristic style through Heraclitus, Plato, and Ambrose Bierce, and what an aphorism does as a propagating seed of insight; discusses irony, sameness, and the pragmatic basis of similarity. Walks through the structure of the book's sections, from the Prejudices of Philosophers to Aftersong, pausing on hidden axioms, Postmodern power reductionism, de Waal's chimpanzees, the ultimatum game, and why truth is a virtue and a weapon. Then reads the opening paragraphs on the will to truth: the Sphinx, what in us really wants truth, Shelley Taylor's positive illusions, and why not rather untruth.

- 3.1 All right, so we'll dive in today. We walked through some contextualizing, talking about Nietzsche's life and the times that he found himself surrounded by. Today, we're going to start digging more specifically into the particulars of his philosophy and concentrating on **Beyond Good and Evil**, which, apart from **Thus Spake Zarathustra**, is Nietzsche's most well-known and perhaps his most comprehensive work.
- 3.2 It's hard to rank-order his writings in terms of brilliance, but this would be in the upper 50th percentile, certainly. A good place to start for anybody who's watching or listening who might be interested in reading Nietzsche, I wouldn't recommend beginning with **Thus Spake Zarathustra** because it's not typical of his work in general, and it's a very difficult work to unpack. A lot of the unpacking is already done in **Beyond Good and Evil**.
- 3.3 It was published in 1866, and it was Nietzsche's first attempt to provide something like a comprehensive overview of his entire corpus of thinking. Now, he wasn't a particularly systematic thinker, nor did he aim to be. He was an **aphoristic** thinker, an imagistic and poetic thinker, a romantic thinker. And so, **Beyond Good and Evil** is not a systematic argument that runs through the entire text. It's more like a series of images highlighting different ideas that have to be assembled by the reader into something approximating a coherent whole. Flashes of insight, flashes of revelation—that might be a good way to think about it.
- 3.4 Now, Nietzsche also was a very literary philosopher in his writing style. And instead of laying out programmatic arguments, he used **aphorisms**, and he was also an ironic writer. So what's an **aphorism**? The word is derived from the Greek 'aphorismos,' and I suppose you could think of an **aphorism** as an attempt to formulate something wise in the shortest possible space using the most elegant formulation, the least number of words; so, wisdom in its most concise form.
- 3.5 So, some **aphorisms** that you might be familiar with include **Heraclitus**, the ancient Greek philosopher who said, "It is not possible to step into the same river twice." And it's a compelling phrase because it contains a paradox. It's like a Zen koan in some ways. Well, at some levels of analysis, a river today and the same river tomorrow are the same, but obviously, the water that composes the river is not the same at all. It's not even the same second to second, and this

aphorism highlights the incredibly complex problem that any two objects are similar and dissimilar in a near innumerable number of ways.

- 3.6 That begs an even more fundamental question, which is, "What do we mean when we say that two things are the same or that two things are different?" We could say that, well, two people are the same, and obviously, there are elements of similarity between people, but there's endless numbers of differences, and so the idea of identity, similarity, is a very, very complicated one. It's not obvious how we solve it.
- 3.7 I've been thinking about that a lot for a very long time, and I think our natural proclivity would be to assume that you can characterize an object, let's say, by a list of features. And then, if you compare two objects and try to determine similarity or difference, you'd compare the list of features and look for overlap, and the more overlap there is, the more they're the same. The problem is that there's a never-ending list of features that characterize any given object. So, that's one problem.
- 3.8 The second problem is, "How do you rank-order those features in terms of importance?" You might say, "What feature most cardinally defines a human being?" That's a very difficult question to answer. So, you have the problem of rank-ordering the features. And then, well, those are the two most difficult problems.
- 3.9 There are ways of circumventing that. So, you might say, "Two things are the same if you could replace them in the pursuit of an action with no alteration in the pursuit." So, you could have a plastic drinking glass and a glass drinking glass, and you could say they're the same. And the reason they're the same is because you could swap one for the other and continue your current operation unhindered.
- 3.10 That introduces the notion that there's something like a pragmatic or practical utility that's at the bottom of our judgments of similarity rather than something like a list of objective features, which, as I said, can be endless and also raises the difficulty of prioritization of the list. And so, "Can you step into the same river twice?" One answer to that question is, "What do you mean by the same?" The river is the same if you use the same bridge to cross it. And the reason for that is you're actually defining the river in reference to the bridge, and you're defining the bridge in reference to your journey. The river is the same enough two days running, assuming there hasn't been a flood and the bridge is washed out—it's the same enough so that you don't have to reconceptualize your notion of what constitutes the river in order to attain the goal that you're pursuing.
- 3.11 But what you have to really understand is, if that's actually the basis on which we make our judgments of similarity, that we're introducing a telos, or a value structure, into the idea of a category itself. Two things are the same insofar as they serve the same purpose, the same human purpose, the same set of human values. That's another place where subjectivity then is introduced into the notion of object perception itself. It's a very deep problem. All that's packed

in, in some sense, that whole mystery, is packed into the **aphorism**, which is why people haven't forgotten it for thousands of years.

- 3.12** Plato: "Necessity is the mother of invention." Well, what does that mean? How much adversarial force do you have to confront in your life before you're sufficiently motivated to generate something like a creative or original solution? And that's a very good question, too. We might delude ourselves into thinking that what we would want optimally, if we could have what we wanted, would be an easy and secure life, but it isn't obvious at all that that's what we want. What we seem to want more deeply is the right amount of adversarial tension.
- 3.13** There's a deep biological reason for that. A lot of biological systems calibrate themselves using opponent processing. There's a push in one direction and a push in another. So, for example, if you want to move your hand very smoothly, you can do it like that, and that's pretty smooth. But if you really want it to be smooth, you do this, and you push with one hand against the other, and then you can make unbelievably tiny micro-adjustments because of that tension. Now, you think within a relationship, you might want security and freedom from anxiety and opportunity, but that isn't all you want. It might not even be the fundamental thing you want. What you want is enough adversarial tension so that you're pushed to the limits of your ability so that you stay in the zone of proximal development so that you expand and transform.
- 3.14** Then, you might say, well, you want something like a partner in play, and play is optimized adversarial interaction. Imagine you set up a game—I don't care what the game is—one-on-one basketball. It's like, "Who do you want to play with?" You want to win. Well, do you? Then, maybe you're 6'7, and you're a pro basketball player, and you play a 4-year-old, and generally speaking, you pretty much stomp them without any problem at all, and your victory is assured, and everyone would say, "Why would anyone play that game?"
- 3.15** That's actually an interesting question because if victory in the game is the end, then you've specified victory with 100% certainty. So, why is that a bad strategy? The answer is something like, "You want to match yourself in a game with someone who's pretty much as skilled as you or maybe even slightly more skilled, so they push you to the edge of your ability so that, while you play the game and aim at victory, the real victory is that you expand your skill as you play." That might actually be a very—imagine that the opportunity to partake in that process voluntarily is the very definition of play itself. Then you could think, "That's one of the indicators that play might be one of the highest forms of human endeavor because it puts you on the optimized edge of transformation." So, you don't want security. You want optimized adversarial combat, something like that.
- 3.16** People who say, "All games should be cooperative," don't understand this in the least. No, you actually want to optimize the competition. That's part of this issue of 'necessity being the mother of invention.' Without optimized deprivation, for example—I think this is one of the potential problems with pornography because you don't know how much adversarial tension there has to be between men and women to keep the whole romantic enterprise going, and 'none' is the wrong answer.

- 3.17 How desperate do men and women have to be to come together? Well, you might say, "It's never desperation that drives people together." I say you're a fool if you think that because we need everything that we can gather around us to drive us together, especially if we want to stay together in complex circumstances over the long run. That's a very difficult thing to manage. And so, if you deprive yourself of necessity, God only knows what else you deprive yourself of.
- 3.18 It's also with children. You don't want to overprotect them and do everything for them. You don't want to do that when you're caring for old people. The rule for caring for old people—and it's also the same rule for children, I would say—do not do anything for anyone else that they can do for themselves because you take from them the necessity that's the mother of invention. And that's a good thing to know, even morally, when you're trying to determine how you should care for other people, because you might think, well, you should sacrifice yourself to the point where everything's easy for the person you're caring for. That happens with mothers and children particularly. That's a very bad solution. Don't do any more than necessary.
- 3.19 The Freudians said, "The successful mother necessarily fails." So what did they mean? Well, when you're taking care of an infant from, say, zero to six months, you do everything for them pretty much, because what can they do? They're so dependent. So the right ethos is—really, it's completely self-sacrificial at that point. Although the baby can respond and smile and return some affection, and so forth, it's still pretty much a one-way street. But if you're still doing that by the time your child is two, you are a dangerous thing. You need to pull back as the child moves forward and stay on that optimized edge of development.
- 3.20 "He who hesitates is lost." I don't know the source of that, but that points to the notion that frequently in life, everything comes together in a certain way that offers a particular opportunity and sort of beckons there in front of you, and there's a moment for it. And if you are faithless and enshrouded in doubt, then you'll miss your opportunity. Well, then, who knows what treasure you've given up.
- 3.21 So, those are **aphorisms**, and Nietzsche wrote in an **aphoristic** style, and that was partly a stylistic choice, but it was also partly a reflection of his ill health because he couldn't sit and write for protracted periods of time. He had to think a lot and then condense and get as much down in his little space as possible. And that's also partly why reading Nietzsche is reading someone who is **philosophizing with a hammer** because there's a tremendous amount of information encapsulated in very few words. And so, reading **Beyond Good and Evil**, it's something—you can read the whole thing at once, although I don't think that's a very good way of reading it because you need to read a paragraph, and this is what we'll do when we walk through, and you need to let it sink in.
- 3.22 It propagates. It's got a seed in it that will propagate through the whole structure of your system of interpretation. First of all, there's only so much that you can take because that's quite a radical transformation. And second, it takes a while, so you can browse Nietzsche, pick it up, and read a few paragraphs. It's worthwhile to go through it sequentially, but it's not the same as reading someone who's making a sustained argument. It's flashes of insight and brilliance.

- 3.23 Insight is an interesting phenomenon because you get an aha moment. And what that seems to do—that seems to occur when a variety of different separate conceptions that are part and parcel of the manner in which you see the world snap together under the influence of a heretofore unseen uniting principle. So, "Here's how these things that I thought were different are importantly similar." Part of the reason that's exciting is because it's more efficient. All of a sudden, you have a conceptual scheme that might require one or two propositions to make functional rather than a set of 10. It's more efficient: "Here's how these things hang together."
- 3.24 If you do dream analysis with people in psychotherapy, one of the ways you can determine whether or not the analysis of the dream is functionally appropriate—that's different than true, let's say, functionally appropriate—is that the person has an aha moment. It's like, "Oh, I see how these disparate ideas are connected by the dream narrative." And dreams are trying to do that. They're part of the mechanism by which your implicit perceptual structures are recalibrated as a consequence of incorporating novel information.
- 3.25 That's also partly why you have to sleep and wake and sleep and wake, because your brain is reconfiguring itself at night, shifting its categories around. You can tell that your brain is shifting its categories around because you think about how strange and surreal dream imagery can be. It's playing with fundamental categorical perception, and you can get away with that at night. It's experimentation because you're paralyzed and you're not going to run around and act out your novel preconceptions before they've been tested to a greater degree than they are merely in the context of the dream.
- 3.26 Irony. Well, irony is the spice of life; that's a reasonable way of thinking about it. It's the interleaving of something serious with something humorous or the introduction of paradox into logic. Here's some ironic statements. Ambrose Bierce was a master of this. He wrote a book in the late 1800s called *The Devil's Dictionary*, which contains a number of words that, as is typical with dictionaries, and then provides them with an ironic definition. So, Bierce would say, "These definitions are more true than the definitions that we generally use." But in Bierce's case, he's shining light on the underground or darker part of the conceptualization.
- 3.27 *The Devil's Dictionary* is a very funny book. It's quite remarkable because it's not easy for a comedy to maintain itself over a period of 140 years, something like that. Now with the *Devil's Dictionary*, still pretty damn funny. "Admiration." It's very witty. "Our polite recognition of another's resemblance to ourselves." Yeah, no kidding. "Advice: The smallest current coin." Yeah, that's a rough one. "Back: That part of your friend which it is your privilege to contemplate in your adversity." And then, this is one I particularly love. It's so funny. It's so witty. "Friendship: A ship big enough for two in fair weather, but only one in foul." Yeah, right. So that's pretty good, eh? That's four jokes. They all made you laugh. They're 140 years old. He was a master of irony, Ambrose Bierce. He must have been a killer at a dinner party, assuming he was reasonably extroverted.
- 3.28 Nietzsche concentrated—Nietzsche's philosophy is characterized by this aphoristic style, which makes it very dense and poetic, image-laden and striking, and then, by the use of irony. And

that, again, makes him a very rare philosopher. He's one of these people who really stands on the border between semantic differentiation, pure logical argumentation, and romantic, poetic, and artistic expression. And so, it makes reading him a real treat; especially, I think Nietzsche is someone whose thought really appeals to people who are more on the creative end of the spectrum, who are higher in openness to experience—that's the personality trait—who are open to aesthetic experiences as Nietzsche was, and so if you're an artist, musician, as that someone who likes literature, then Nietzsche is a wonderful philosopher to encounter.

- 3.29 Here's the structure of the book. These are the different sections. We'll just go through them very briefly so we can orient ourselves. "On the Prejudices of Philosophers." What does that mean? Well, Nietzsche is interested, like the psychoanalysts, in the underlying unspoken presuppositions of an argument. So, that's one of the levels at which he's conducting analysis. "What is it that isn't being said here that's a precondition for this argument?" Now, that's an interesting idea because you might think that an argument can be complete in itself, but it can't be. It can't be self-contained, and part of the reason for that is an argument can't contain the whole world. There have to be things it leaves out.
- 3.30 And then, you might ask yourself, "What do you do with everything that you're leaving out?" Right now, you're leaving out a lot of the world, but here you are in the world and managing it. So, you're leaving out a lot of the world, but simultaneously, you're managing the whole world. And obviously, you're not intelligent enough, conscious enough, to process the entire world in a differentiated manner and to attend to every detail. You're not as sophisticated as the world is complex.
- 3.31 Then, you might ask yourself, "What do you do with all that complexity? Where is it?" You can think about this for, like, 50 years. You hide the complexity of the world in the axioms of your argument. You say, "If we took such and such for granted, then this would be the case." And you might think that if you're assessing a philosophical doctrine, you would be assessing the part that is "then this would be the case"—the actual argument. But Nietzsche would say, "Wait a minute. The axioms contain way more of the philosophy than the explicit argument."
- 3.32 And the axioms are hidden because it's like, the founders of the American state proclaimed, "We hold these truths to be self-evident," and then they make their arguments like, "Yeah, fair enough, but what about that which is self-evident?" First of all, is it self-evident? Second, why is it self-evident if it is? And why are those particular self-evident in relationship to your argument? And then more: "What purpose that you're not talking about does the selection of what you deem to be self-evident serve?" And those are very complicated questions, and Nietzsche certainly posed them. "Is there a will underlying a given philosophy that the philosophy serves, perhaps even without the consciousness, without conscious intent or even realization on the part of philosophers?"
- 3.33 Now, the Postmodernists went mad with that speculation, and the psychoanalysts did to some degree as well. When I was your age, let's say, it was all the rage to analyze any literary work in terms of its unconscious Freudian sexual motivations. So the hypothesis was, "Sex is lurking in

here somewhere," and it's not a bad hypothesis. If you're trying to posit a fundamental motivation that might be lurking, looking for sex and looking for aggression, that's a pretty rich playing field. The probability that human beings are producing something that those motivational systems aren't playing a role in determining is very low. So, it could be a reasonable enterprise.

- 3.34 The problem with it is it can turn into a kind of boneheaded algorithmic reductionism. And certainly, that's what's happened with the **Postmodernists**, where everything is deemed to be about nothing but power, regardless of what the philosopher might be talking about or the historical time period or the nature of the relationship between the communicator and the audience. It's all about power, and that's very convenient if you want to use power because that's all there is.
- 3.35 It also requires very little cognitive effort on your part. I mean, part of the reason I believe that the **Postmodern** alliance with the Neo-Marxists, which produces the supposition that everything is about power, is very attractive to people who simply aren't very bright because you can learn the game rules in 15 minutes, and then you can explain every single human interaction that ever took place. "It's all about power."
- 3.36 You see this with very bad therapists, and they do this often to the great detriment of their clients. Freud, of course, outlined the relationship between early childhood trauma and fixations in development and the later emergence of psychopathy, psychopathology, various forms of mental distress and illness. The foolish therapists make the axiomatic assumption that if you're suffering, the reason for that is some traumatic childhood experience. And then, generally, they'll push that even further and assume that it had to be sexual in nature. That is not how **Freud** approached the situation because **Freud** was a genius and never made a simplistic, reductionistic assumption of that sort. So, "On the **Prejudices of Philosophers**."
- 3.37 "**The Free Spirit**." "**What Is Religious?**" A definitional inquiry. "Epigrams and Interludes." And you can see that this is almost like a drama that he's laying out. Epigrams and Interludes. It sounds like something that might occur in a dramatic production between scenes, an interlude. "Natural History of Morals." That's an interesting phrase as well because he's trying to, at least in part, understand morality as part of the biological enterprise. That's a very modern way of approaching the situation and one that is continuing to bear fruit in the 21st century.
- 3.38 People like **Frans de Waal**, for example, a great primatologist in Holland, has shown quite clearly that the chimpanzee patriarchs who use psychopathic domination as their route to reproductive success, let's say, the idea would be the roughest, toughest male chimp, climbs his way to the top, dispenses with all his enemies, and propagates his genes into eternity, and the entire social hierarchy of the chimps is nothing but **will to power**. De Waal has shown that even among chimps who are quite brutal and who do have a patriarchal social system, so to speak, the chimps that use nothing but domination and power don't tend to be successful in the medium-to long-term. They have short, brutal rules, and they tend to be destroyed by their opponents,

partly because, no matter how tough you are, two chimps slightly subordinate to you who team up are going to tear you into pieces.

- 3.39 And of course, those are constraints on human machinations as well. Maybe you're powerful enough to get away with your tricks, but there's a lot of other people out there. If you're not very good at bonding with other people because you're incapable of reciprocal interactions, so you're a psychopath, well, don't you think that the people who can cooperate together, even if they're doing that and competing at the same time, which is what happens, let's say, in a sports team—don't you think they're going to take you out? There's a lot more of them than there are of you.
- 3.40 What that implies is that there's some natural constraint, and a very real constraint, even in the objective sense, on the mere expression of self-serving power. Now, it's also the case that psychopaths who are self-serving are also not really self-serving in a sophisticated way because psychopaths exploit other people, but they also exploit their future selves. So, psychopaths are notoriously unable to learn from experience, which means they repeat the same errors over and over. And you might say, "What's the consequence of an error?" And the answer is, "The tomorrow 'you' suffers." And if you don't care about that, that's not exactly self-serving. It's narrowly and impulsively self-serving.
- 3.41 Now, you could make a case, and I think this is a good case to make, that if 'you' served yourself properly— that would be the 'you' that's now, the 'you' that's tomorrow, next week, next month, next year, five years from now, when you're old—that's a whole community of people, and very different people, and if you acted now to serve all those people properly, simultaneously, that would be indistinguishable from acting in the best interests of the people around you, so that the proper self-serving ethos that's sophisticated is indistinguishable from something like, "Treat your neighbor as you would want to be treated."
- 3.42 That's a very interesting idea because it brings forth the possibility that there's a natural constraint on the structure of moral interactions that's a consequence of extension across time and situation. People act as if that's the case. I mean, there are great experiments that are conducted in—I'll play a game with you. You two can play this game. So, the deal is, I'm going to give you \$100. This is not going to happen, by the way. This is a fictitious \$100. You have to offer your compatriot in the game some proportion of that. Now, if he rejects, he gets one—you can make one offer. That's it. If he rejects it, neither of you gets anything. OK, so here's your \$100. How much are you going to give him?
- 3.43 60.
- 3.44 Will you accept 60?
- 3.45 Yeah, sure.
- 3.46 Okay, good. Now, 60 is an interesting choice. Now, what you find—so here's the classical economic prediction. I give you \$100, you give her \$1. You take it. Why? Well, do you want a

dollar, or do you want nothing? The rational choice is to pick the dollar. Okay, no one will accept the dollar. They basically tell the other person to go to hell. And then, if you do this with people who are impoverished and you actually play it, the impoverished people are more likely, not less, to reject the unfair offer, and that's very interesting because you think, "Jeez, they need the money." It's like, "Yeah, but maybe they need to signal the fact that they're not susceptible to manipulation even more than they need the money."

- 3.47** The proclivity of people across cultures is to settle on something approximating 50/50. Why? Well, you're not going to just trade with one person once in one situation in your life. You're going to trade with a whole bunch of people in many situations in your life. And so, even in this audience, you're all listening to the details of this trade, and now the person who makes the offer and the person who accepts or rejects have also established their reputation, and there's actually nothing that's more valuable than your reputation. There might be nothing you're driven to maintain and attend to more than your reputation because that's how people represent you in the broad social community. And so, if you signal that you will offer a fair deal, and you signal that you'll accept one, then everybody can note that you two people play fair and then could be played with in trade.
- 3.48** Now, the \$60 offer is a very interesting one because you might say, "If every time two people interact, one of the people puts themselves in an inferior situation"—they get less out of the deal—"that's not such a good strategy." But you could counter that by saying, "If you know that if you play a game with me, not only will I be fair, but I'll err a bit in your favor, then everyone who's listening might think, "There's someone we could definitely play with," and line up to do so. So, it could be that if you're generous, not to the point of deterioration, but if you're generous in your social interactions, there's a very high probability that that will be returned to you manifold, and this is very much worth thinking about.
- 3.49** It could be that the world is structured—you can think about this for yourself— that the more you give away, the more you get, and that's the order of getting. You start with giving away, and you're not giving away to get because then that's just manipulation. But you can think it through practically. People track your reputation, and assiduously. That's part of the reason that everyone wants attention. Attention is a fundamental currency, and if your reputation is you're exceptionally productive and generous, well then—and thousands of people know that—then maybe thousands of people line up to act reciprocally towards you in that manner. And so the notion that you should do everything you can to provide people with everything you can could easily be the most effective route to simultaneously getting what you need and want and also getting it in a manner that allows you to continue to give.
- 3.50** Now, I actually think this is true because one of the things I've also noted, and you can decide this for yourself, is it's rare for me to see that anyone is more satisfied and more rewarded than they are when someone tells them that some sacrifice they made on their behalf actually really helped them. Imagine you did something for someone, maybe a relatively small thing, or maybe not, and the person comes to you and says, "You know that action you undertook? It really set

me straight. It really helped me. I'd like to thank you for that." It isn't obvious to me at all that there is a more fundamental form of reward than that.

- 3.51** And that's worth thinking about because if you're adapted to the social situation—humans are highly social. We're adapted to the social environment—it might be that your reward systems are calibrated to tell you when what you're doing is the most productive thing you could be doing. And it could easily be that that is to be found in the unself-serving service to others. Not because you should do it, not because it's a duty, even though both of those things might be true, but literally because there's no other strategy you could possibly undertake that will be as beneficial to you, to the people around you, and to the interactions between you and the people around you. And so, that's all part, you might say, of "The Natural History of Morals."
- 3.52** "We Scholars." "Our Virtues." A word we don't use much anymore and much to our detriment—virtues. There's no difference between virtues and weapons. If you construe life in some manner as a battle, a mortal battle, what can you arm yourself with? And I don't mean arm for the slaughter. I mean, fortify yourself with. Well, virtues are what you fortify yourself with as the definition of virtue.
- 3.53** We're off-kilter in our implicit understanding of such things now because we tend to think of virtues as those traits that do-gooders insist you should manifest. It's like, "No, no. The virtues are your allies in the mortal battle that's life." And it's like, "What do you want to have on your side?" How about beauty? That'd be good. How about truth? How about justice? Like these eternal verities. If your character is in alignment with the eternal verities, then they're your allies. And so, that's very much worth thinking through.
- 3.54** One of the things I've learned—this is a very good thing to know—if you're ever in a real crisis, especially a social crisis, but it's also true if it's a biological crisis, the best possible defense you have in a truly complicated crisis is the unvarnished truth. That's what you've got. Now, that's complicated because if you're mobbed, let's say, your reputation is going to be on the line. People are going to question your reputation. And if you've done untoward things in the past that could be revealed, it's going to be very hard for you to be truthful. That's a real problem because when you're in a situation that's too complex to compute—like, what do you do when the mob comes for you? My sense is you tell the truth. You just lay out the story and let everyone decide the reality of the situation for themselves. But if you can't do that because you have snakes under the carpet or skeletons in the closet, a crisis will come for you, and you will be finished. And that's the truth.
- 3.55** And so, why is truth a virtue? Well, do you want reality on your side or not? Now you say—you might ask, "What do people do when they lie?" You lie to gain a short-term advantage, and maybe you delude yourself into thinking that the lie will be successful enough so that you can gain this short-term advantage without cost. Maybe now and then you can, although I can tell you I've never seen it work in my clinical practice. I've never seen anyone ever get away—it's a very frightening thing to actually understand. I don't think that people get away with anything. I don't think that you can ever bend the fabric of reality in your favor without that eventually

snapping back, not only to take its piece out of you in proportion to what you've gained but far more than that.

- 3.56 You might not see how it happens because you might have warped something 10 years ago and forgotten that you even did it conveniently for you. And then, something occurs that's not good, and you've lost the causal connection. A lot of what you do in psychotherapy with people, when you have them unfold their lives, sometimes using a free association technique, is they'll talk about their current problems, and then you let them talk without interference, and they weave a story that starts to include the past, and they lay out a causal train that says, "Oh, I see. I'm in this situation because 10 years ago, I made this decision, and I didn't know that that was the consequence. I didn't know that that's how it unfolded."
- 3.57 Then, often, they have to go back and reconcile or rectify that error in order perhaps to address the current problem, but also to stop it from propagating out into the future. And so you got to ask yourself—you're in a battle. You're facing the ultimate opponent as you progress through your existence. You're always bounded by your finite mortality, and your subjection to the whim of the social world. Those are always the existential realities that undergird your life.
- 3.58 You might ask yourself, "Given that you're in a battle of that intensity, what is it that you need to ally yourself with so that you can prevail?" I would say, "Foremost among those is the truth." And reality's behind you. Brutal as reality might be, it's better to have it behind you than ahead of you as something that's confronting you. "Our Virtues."
- 3.59 "Peoples and Fatherlands," extending the discussion out to the social community. "What Is Noble?" "High Mountains," and then "Aftersong." We'll start with On the Prejudices of Philosophers' investigation into this underlying **axiomatic structure**. What we'll do now is, I'm going to present you—and likely for the rest of the lecture series—with paragraphs from **Nietzsche**. We'll walk through them and elaborate on them, allow them to unfold to some degree, and investigate what it is that **Nietzsche** is pointing at.
- 3.60 I've taken sections from **Beyond Good and Evil**. I've read the book a number of times at different periods of my life. I think I read it first when I was about 17, and it had a very potent effect on me, and then again in graduate school. Then, when I was teaching at the university at Harvard and at the University of Toronto. Then again, more recently. A lot of these paragraphs—I used a lot of them in my book, **Maps of Meaning**, as starting places for an elaborated discussion. They really burned themselves into my memory. I really remember the paragraphs themselves, what they meant to me, and how they shaped my thought. And so, when I went through the first part of **Beyond Good and Evil** this time, I was picking out paragraphs like mad that had shaped hundreds of hours of writing for me in some circumstances. There are paragraphs that popped out for me.
- 3.61 That's an interesting phenomenon, too. This is worth knowing. So, if you go through **Beyond Good and Evil**, for example, you might find that a lot of it you don't understand, and some of it you can hardly read. It doesn't grip your interest, maybe because you don't understand it. But

there'll be some paragraphs that pop out, and you think, "Oh, I get that. There's something there. There's something that's glimmering." That glimmering phenomenon is very much worth paying attention to developmentally.

- 3.62 Let's say something captures your interest while you're reading *Beyond Good and Evil*. Why does that capture your interest? Because it's something in the text? That would be part of the objective world insofar as the text is part of the objective world. Something's, what—calling to you? It's capturing your attention.
- 3.63 "Mercury is the winged messenger of the gods." Okay, so what does that mean? Well, mercury, the metal—if you mix mercury with ore that contains gold, mercury will pick up all the gold, and then you can heat up the mercury and drive it off, and you're left with the gold. So, mercury gathers gold, literally. And it's not a fluke that the metal is named after the god. There's a trail of meaning there. So, Mercury is the winged messenger. So, imagine Mercury as something that flits in front of you and captures your interest. It's like, "I find that compelling. I find that compelling." And then, you follow that compulsion. It's like a doorway that opens to a pathway. That's what that compulsion is. You follow that compulsion. That takes you to the realm of the gods, the forces that are operating behind the scenes because something is unconsciously compelling your interest.
- 3.64 You know that. You can't force yourself to be interested in something. And that's very strange. Interest is something that has to call to you. So then, you might ask, "What is it that's calling?" If it's not under your voluntary control, what is it that's beckoning to you? In the story of Exodus, Moses encounters the burning bush, and it glimmers in the distance, so he decides to go investigate it. And he investigates it deeply. He attends to it. And God himself announces himself in the midst of the burning bush.
- 3.65 So, the idea there would be something like, "As you're moving through life, you'll find there'll be portals that call to you, and that if you attended to them, you'd find your destiny, and that would take you into the depths." That's literally what happens. That's how life works. And it often—it's paradoxical because often what compels you calls to you in the form of a problem. So, you might say to yourself, "This really bothers me." And there's something arbitrary about that. You might even wish, "I wish it didn't bother me so much." And that shows the involuntary nature of it.
- 3.66 But I would say it's certainly possible that if a problem presents itself to you as your problem—it bugs you, it bothers you—that's your destiny. For whatever reason, that's your problem. You might say, "I don't want any problems." And you think, "Are you so sure about that—that you don't want any problems?" Maybe you want the problem that's exactly matched for you. Maybe the meaning of your life would be found in the attempt to solve that problem. Often, what people do if something bugs them is carp and complain about it, then they get bitter and resentful. There's nothing particularly productive about that, although it might be a step on the way to something productive. But if you understand that there's a million things that could bother you, but only a subset of them do, and that that's actually tailored to you in some

fundamental manner, then you can also understand that that's marking out a pathway for your destiny.

- 3.67 "The **will to truth**, which will still tempt us to many a venture, that famous truthfulness of which all philosophers have so far spoken with respect—what questions has this **will to truth** not laid before us?"
- 3.68 I suggested that a virtue that you might put in your armament would be truth. And you might accept that axiomatically, that truth is a good thing. Well, **Nietzsche** is starting to ask a fundamental question here, "What do you mean when you say truth? And if you also assume that truth is redemptive, what is it that you're assuming so that that seems self-evident?" That's the question he's starting to ask. This is a very deep question. So, the whole philosophical enterprise is predicated on the idea that whatever the truth is, is redemptive and valuable axiomatically, and so **Nietzsche** is subjecting that proposition itself, the starting point for the philosophical endeavor itself, to question.
- 3.69 "What questions has this **will to truth** not laid before us? What strange, wicked, questionable questions? It is a long story even now"—the philosophical story—"and yet it seems as if it had scarcely begun. Is it any wonder that we should finally become suspicious, lose patience, and turn away impatiently?" Well, that's happening in the modern world because we're surrounded by the suggestions now that, well, there's no truth but power, or that all truth is relative, or that there's no such thing as objective truth. There's no such thing as transcendent truth on the religious side. All truth is self-serving.
- 3.70 And there is, as I pointed out previously, an indefinite number of facts relevant to any given matter, and so that does pose the thorny problem of "Why did you pick the facts that you picked?" And that's an unbelievably intractable problem. It's the problem because you might say, "The facts can't reveal themselves to you as guideposts to the truth unless the ethos that guides your selection of the facts is aligned with the truth." The facts can't contain the truth independent of the truthful ethos that you bring to the interpretive situation.
- 3.71 So, for example, and I believe this to be the case, it's virtually impossible to be a scientist unless you're actually dedicated to the pursuit of scientific truth. If your career is paramount—and it shouldn't be irrelevant, by the way, because if you don't have a scientific career, you can't communicate, you generally can't do research—but if your career is paramount, there's no way you can be a scientist. It's because every time you're confronted with an array of ambivalent facts, you will pick the interpretation that serves your career. And so, science is full of careerist research. In fact, probably 90% of research is fundamentally careerist.
- 3.72 You can see the **Postmodern** objection lurking in that. "It's all about power." Well, if it's a corrupt—this is how it looks to me. It's all about power to the degree that the enterprise is corrupted. And that's something to ask yourself. It's like, "Are you sufficiently oriented towards the truth, whatever that is, so that even the facts can reveal truth to you? Or are you using the

facts to support your instrumental manipulation?" Even with regard to yourself, because you can certainly manipulate yourself into a form of tyrant-slave relationship. That's for sure.

- 3.73 "That we should finally learn from this Sphinx to ask questions, too?" A Sphinx is a monstrous assemblage of multiple parts, and the Sphinx poses the fundamental question of life. What is it? "What goes on four legs in the morning, two legs in the afternoon, and three legs in the evening?" And the answer to that is man. That's the problem the Sphinx poses, this monstrous assemblage of unintegrated parts. "That we should finally learn from this Sphinx to ask questions, too? Who is it really that puts questions to us here? What in us really wants truth?"
- 3.74 And that's an interesting way of phrasing the question, "What in us really wants truth?" While Nietzsche is insinuating that there's something that operates within you that has a certain degree of autonomy and that one of the aims of that semi-autonomous actor within is something like motivation to pursue the truth. You might say, "Why is that not you?" And the answer is, "Maybe you're motivated to some degree to pursue the truth, but so are you, and so you, and so are you. So how is it you? If it's shared by everyone, it's not you." And that will to the truth would still exist even if you disappeared. And so, that's a god in some sense. It's transcendent and universal, and it extends across time. And it's a spirit, the spirit of truth-seeking.
- 3.75 One of the things you try to do if you're a good professor, especially in the humanities, is you try to imbue your students with the philosophical spirit. You could say that that spirit is the spirit that's animated all philosophers, which is why we can identify them as philosophers. Then, you can imagine that there would be philosophers who were more emblematic of the philosophical spirit than others, more canonically pure philosophers. Then, you might say that the better you are as a student, the more you become the vessel that that spirit inhabits.
- 3.76 The Socratic method is part of making that corporeal. So, if you teach using the Socratic method, you question people, but you question them in the spirit of investigation of the truth. So, I could question you. This often happens if I lecture, and people are allowed to use the microphone afterwards to ask questions. You get a whole variety of questions. Sometimes, for me, there are questions from Christians, so-called, who just want to convert me to Christianity right there on the spot and are using the opportunity to question me to corner me into some admission that would allow them to put me in a box. I suppose that's a question, but it's not. It's an act of instrumentality using a question as a pretext.
- 3.77 Then, you have other people who will grab the mic, and they'll use the opportunity to ask a question just to declaim a particular political position. Then, they'll throw a question in there just at the end to pretend that they're playing the game. Now, audiences don't respond well to either of those approaches. They start rustling around. They don't listen, they're annoyed, and the reason they're annoyed is because they know the people—even if they might not be able to say why—they know the people are breaking the axiomatic rules.

- 3.78 And what are the rules? Well, the rules are really the rules of free philosophical inquiry. So, if I'm listening to you, and you lay out an argument, if I ask you a genuine question, I'm asking that because I actually didn't understand something you said or because maybe I see a contradiction between two things you said, or maybe I'm also trying to facilitate your exploration as it moves forward, or our joint exploration. If you're listening to people in psychotherapy, insofar as you don't just shut up and listen, the valid questions are ones that have this—the aim of the question is the facilitation of the search for truth, and that would mean that the question is asked in the philosophical spirit. And then, as a psychotherapist, if you embody that philosophical spirit of genuine inquiry, that's the **logos**. The hypothesis is that that's actually redemptive and healing, and that's really worth thinking about, too.
- 3.79 What **Freud** rediscovered in a secular manner was that there are certain modes of communication that have a healing property. And you might ask, "What does healing mean?" It can mean physiological healing. If you help someone straighten out the manner in which they construe the world, you can lower their stress experiences substantially, and that has a walloping effect on their psycho-physiological health. So, it can convert into a material reality.
- 3.80 People thought that was miraculous when **Freud** first posed it, but we'd already known that in the religious realm because we'd made the presumption before that, that if you, at least many people had, if you attended assiduously to your shortcomings—that would be to confess your sins—and then you made an account of them publicly, and then you attempted to formulate your intent to rectify that, that that would be redemptive. And then, you have to ask, "Do you believe that?" And then, you could ask a different question, which would be, "If you believe that, are you believing something religious?" And then, you can ask another question, which is, "If you believe that, and it is something religious, what does that mean about **what is religious**?"
- 3.81 And so, what is it within us that wants truth? Well, that's the philosophical spirit. That's one answer to that. And then, what's it aiming at? And you could say, if you're more scientifically oriented, that it's aiming at a comprehensive description of the patterns of objective reality, but that's an insufficient answer because there's an infinite number of patterns. And so, the problem for the scientist is, "How do you not get lost in the details?" Now, most scientists, perhaps all who are genuine scientists, operate within an unconscious ethos, and the ethos is "Pursue that set of facts that has practical moral utility."
- 3.82 So, for example, if you're a medical researcher, you want to be looking at the subset of patterns in the world to which you might pay attention if your goal was to help people become healthier. And so, there's an invisible "if" at the beginning of the enterprise. "If" what we're trying to do is make healthier people, then here are the relevant facts. Now, generally, if you're a practicing scientist, you don't bother too much with the "if" statement because everyone just accepts it axiomatically. We assume that the scientific endeavor is embedded in an underlying ethical endeavor.
- 3.83 We also make other assumptions, too, which are not obviously true on the face of it. So you could ask yourself, "Is investigation into the structure of the material world redemptive in the

final analysis?" You might say, "Obviously." It's like, "What about the Frankenstein story? What about the invention of the atom bomb? And how do we know that that's not just going to take us out completely? How can we be so sure that our attempt to investigate and manipulate the material world won't end in cataclysmic catastrophe?" The answer is something like, "We've decided to operate on the assumption that reality has an intelligible structure, a **logos**, implicit in it, and that investigation of that is, by definition, redemptive."

- 3.84** The entire scientific enterprise is staked on that a priori proposition, and it's questionable. Now, I happen to believe it's true, but only if the scientists and the technologists who are investigating the material world are guided by an ethos that allows them to select the facts of investigation in relationship to what you might describe as the proper goal. And then, that begs another question, "What's the proper goal?" That's what **Nietzsche** is really trying to delve into here.
- 3.85** It's like, "If there is this **will to truth**, first of all, what is it? And why does it have this semi-autonomous nature? And then, what exactly do we mean by truth here?" **Nietzsche** already knew that merely presuming that truth is something like concordance with the objective facts was insufficient. First of all, it was an inaccurate description of what we do, but it also doesn't solve the problem and can't. Too many facts, too many facts. That's the fundamental issue.
- 3.86** "Who is it really that puts questions to us here? What in us really wants truth?" Two great questions. Why does something bother you? Why are those the mysteries that you're searching for answers to? And what accounts for the somewhat arbitrary nature of that? And then, why might you axiomatically assume that if you do have a problem that announces itself to you, that if you pursued the truth, that would be the manner in which you might find a solution because you can imagine alternative hypotheses.
- 3.87** If I want to establish a relationship with you, I could establish it on the basis of something approximating truth, or I could decide what the hell I want from you and target every single thing I say to only acquire from you what it is I want. And it isn't obvious a priori which of those categories is more appropriate, even from the perspective of truth, because I might say, "My truth above all." And if I have to make you an instrumental object of my truth, why shouldn't I do that?
- 3.88** "Indeed, we came to a long halt at the question about the cause of this will until we finally came to a complete stop before a still even more basic question. We asked about the value of the will. Suppose we want truth. Why not rather untruth?" So, in social psychology, 20 years ago, there was a big flurry of activity, which, personally, I found rather appalling, based on the proposition that the normal healthy person had to deceive themselves about the nature of the world—is that the world is so unpalatable in its fundamental essence, so rife with suffering, that if you didn't shield yourself with positive illusions, you were going to suffer from decrements in mental health.
- 3.89** That was **Shelley Taylor**, if I remember correctly. She tried to—and she was criticized—well, how do you tell the difference between a positive illusion and a pathological deception? The answer

to that is, "We don't know. It's a slippery slope." And she used data pertaining, for example, to so-called depressive realism. The people who pursued that line of reasoning purported to demonstrate that if you took a normal person who wasn't depressed, and then you took a person who was depressed, and you asked them a set of questions about a set of facts, the depressive people were more realistic in relationship to their unbiased representation of the facts. Their depression made them more realistic viewers of the world. Whereas the typical healthy person had like a rose-colored glasses filter on the world so that they were inhabiting a universe of Pollyanna delusion—and worse, that that was necessary for the maintenance of mental health.

- 3.90 Now, I believe—and still believe—that was an appalling set of doctrines and also based on science so unsophisticated in relationship to the profundity of that question that you don't even know where to start when you begin to criticize it. First of all, most of the people they looked at weren't depressed. They were depressed by mild behaviorist standards, so they were somewhat more depressed than the typical person. Maybe they scored—there's a measure, questionnaire measure, the Beck Depression Inventory. You can score anywhere from 9 to 60 on it, and 9 puts you in the moderately or mildly depressed range. It's like one-third of college students score higher than that in their first year consistently. They're not depressed. Sixty is depressed. You're just out.
- 3.91 So, most of the people—certainly that social psychologists study—who were depressed were mildly sad for a little bit of time. And it might be that you are enough of a Pollyanna so that when you're a little sad, you're actually more accurate. You give more accurate descriptions of yourself and the world. But that doesn't mean that depression makes you a realist. If you get really depressed, you fall into a very unidimensional view of the world, which is that your whole past was nothing but a blighted catastrophe. The present is even worse, and you might as well just forget about the future entirely. And so, depression is the collapse of your entire system of apprehension into a nihilistic nightmare, and the idea that that's more realistic is preposterous.
- 3.92 But in any case, it raised an interesting question, "Aren't you happier if you don't look at the terrors of life?" And you could certainly see that, in the short term, that could easily be the case. You could also see that, to some degree, you do that for your children because you don't expose a 4-year-old to everything horrible in the world at once. You do it in a measured manner. And so, well, how much do you have to be protected from reality in order to function? And is there a difference between the practical simplifications that you use to orient yourself in the world and the delusions that might protect you from emotional upset? And if there is a difference, what is the difference? These are very, very difficult questions to answer, even to formulate.
- 3.93 "Suppose we want truth. Why not rather untruth?" Well, that's what you assume every time you tell a lie. Untruth is preferable to truth because otherwise, why would you tell a lie? Every child experiments with lies, and intelligent children experiment earlier and more with lies. Why not generate plausible fiction and inhabit that, especially if you can get away with it? Why not happiness above all? Certainly, why not happiness above clarity of vision? And those are questions that plague everyone to some degree.

- 3.94 "Suppose we want truth. Why not rather untruth and uncertainty? Even ignorance?" Freud's criticism of religion is that religion was a defense against death anxiety. He regarded that with moral—he regarded that as insufficiently courageous and the whole religious enterprise as a form of cowardice in the face of the catastrophe of life. I don't think that's a particularly useful criticism because it begs—here's a question that begs: "If religion is nothing but a defense against death anxiety, then why is the central symbol of Christianity a crucifix?" You think it'd be, like, a happy face. I mean it.
- 3.95 The crucifix is the last thing you'd pick if that was your hypothesis because, at minimum, what it does is confront people with an image of agonized suffering. It doesn't seem that that's exactly commensurate with the notion that in some simple manner, religion is nothing but a defense mechanism against the fear of death. Now, that's a complicated problem, and there are defense mechanism-like elements of any axiomatic belief, but "Suppose we want truth. Why not rather untruth and uncertainty? Even ignorance?" Ignorance is bliss. There's an aphorism. "The problem of the value of truth." So that's one paragraph of the introduction of *Beyond Good and Evil*.
- 3.96 So, you can see what he's saying. Here's a bunch of things you take for granted. You don't even notice you take them for granted. Possibly, you shouldn't take them for granted. Certainly, you might become aware of the fact that those invisible propositions exist and that you take them for granted. Or perhaps you should if the pursuit of truth is worthwhile, and maybe you shouldn't because, well, ignorance is bliss.

4. Challenging Morality

AT A GLANCE

Continues with Nietzsche's attack on the metaphysicians' faith in opposite values and the possibility that the good is entangled with the wicked—illustrated with Jung's integration of the shadow, monstrous but admirable people, and the call to romantic adventure in Abraham's story. Examines the claim that most conscious thinking is instinctive, that a false judgment may be life-promoting, that synthetic judgments a priori are indispensable fictions, and that recognizing untruth as a condition of life places a philosophy beyond good and evil. Ends with every great philosophy as the personal confession of its author, grown from a moral seed.

- 4.1 "The fundamental faith of the metaphysicians is the faith in opposite values. It has not even occurred to the most cautious among them than one might have a doubt right here at the threshold where it was surely most necessary— even if they vowed to themselves 'de omnibus dubitandum.'" Unfortunately, I don't know what that means.
- 4.2 So, "for one may doubt"—he expands on it first—"whether there are any opposites at all" Well, that's a question I don't imagine you ever asked yourself because you axiomatically assume the validity of the notion of 'opposite.' Are love and hate opposites? Or are they integrally tied together? Are they subcategories of the same phenomena? Are the two things that are most different opposites? Well, love and hate are both emotions, so they're not maximally different. They fall into the same category of emotion, let's say. And are they truly opposites? So, that's one question that emerges from this, although he's asking a deeper question even than that.
- 4.3 "For one may doubt, first, whether there are any opposites at all, and secondly, whether these popular valuations and opposite values on which the metaphysicians put their seal, are not merely some foreground estimates, provisional perspectives, perhaps even from some nook, perhaps from below, frog perspectives, as it were, to borrow an expression painters use."
- 4.4 Well, here's a question about opposites that's rivening our current culture. Are there two genders? Because the proposition that there are is predicated on the underlying proposition that opposites exist and that the world can be reasonably and usefully categorized into those opposing categories, binary categories. The notion of non-binary is a challenge to the idea of the fundamental existence of opposites as a useful categorical scheme.
- 4.5 It is a complicated question because there are masculine women and feminine men, and so it's a perfectly reasonable question to ask yourself, "What does that mean about the categories?" Of course, we are asking ourselves those questions right now, constantly. The idea that that's a reflection in part, let's say, of this Nietzschean paragraph, that's almost a certainty because the people who posed those questions to begin with—that would mostly be the French Postmodernists—were absolutely 100% influenced by Nietzsche. That's certainly the case with Foucault.

- 4.6 "For all the value that the true, the truthful, the selfless may deserve, it would still be possible that a higher and more fundamental value for life might have to be ascribed to deception, selfishness, and lust." That's an interesting theological problem, even, that Nietzsche is posing—well, let's say you're going to be good. No excess sexual desire, no aggression, no anger, no disgust. Do you dispense with all those so-called negatives? And is that the central nature of your virtue? Or is it the case that you might say, "Does true virtue require the capacity to utilize anger or to utilize sexual motivation?"
- 4.7 And then, how might those negatives—from one perspective, that would be the frog perspective. Here are good motivations and here are bad motivations viewed from beneath. We're going to conveniently categorize them into opposites. And now, if you're good, you don't indulge in any of the negative motivations. Simplistic moralizing does that, and young people often object to this when it is occurring, when older people are doing it. They say, "They're trying to regulate their motivations to regulate their sexual conduct, for example." The young people object to that, partly for hedonic reasons, let's say. But there's a deeper objection, which is their realization that it's not so obvious that the pathway to virtue is just separation—the separation from the darkness.
- 4.8 Jung, for example, who was a student of Nietzsche, developed the idea of the incorporation of both the anima, or the animus, and the shadow as part of psychosocial development. And what that would mean is that, as you progress towards the good, you don't dispense with that which is opposite—aggression, particularly, let's say, on the shadow side—but you incorporate that in a structure of higher unity. That does dispense in some way with the idea of opposite itself is that, well, they're only opposites.
- 4.9 And in contradiction, if they're not united in the appropriate higher-order unity—aggression might be your enemy if you're impulsive, but it could well be your friend if you could integrate the power that's in aggression, which is a kind of god, the god of war, Ares, for example. There's a power there that can make you unstoppable because you have that aggression at hand. And then, if it's integrated into something like the seeking of higher-order virtue, then it's no longer an opposite at all. All of that's crammed into that sentence.
- 4.10 Certainly, the psychoanalysts, particularly Freud, because he started down this route, not much. I think he published *The Interpretation of Dreams* in the year 1900 if I remember correctly. Freud is working a little later than Nietzsche but on the same set of problems. And certainly, Freud was sophisticated enough to know that the base motivations of the id were not in and of themselves immoral. And that the goal of higher-order moral striving wasn't the mere inhibition.
- 4.11 He regarded the inhibitory force, which was the superego, as rife with its own proclivity for pathology. So, the id can take you places that maybe you don't want to go if you're wise, but so can an untrammelled superego. And lurking in Freud is the notion that health isn't the proper regulation of the id by the superego, which is incorporated social being, let's say, but something like the balance, the optimized balance of natural impulse—the id, the ego, which is maybe the integrated center of your personality—and the social order. So, that unity starts to become a

balance. Well, that's all that pursuit that Freud embarked upon to understand the redeeming utility of the negative opposites; that's part of the question that Nietzsche is attempting to formulate in this paragraph.

- 4.12 "It might even be possible that what constitutes the value of these good and revered things is precisely that they are insidiously related, tied to, and involved with these wicked, seemingly opposite things—maybe even one with them in essence. Maybe!" That's another very radical idea, too, is that not only are the good and evil not opposites. Remember, the book is *Beyond Good and Evil*. But maybe many of the things that we claim to be good are good because they have a particular relationship with what we too rapidly might deem evil, and the good itself wouldn't be possible without the alliance between what we think of as good and what we're casually tempted to regard unthinkingly as evil.
- 4.13 Some of the best people I've ever met are monstrous people. They have an unbelievable capacity for mayhem, and without that, they'd have no force of personality. There are people that you meet and you think, "Okay, don't mess with them lightly." And without that capacity for mayhem, that integrated capacity for mayhem, that force of personality isn't there.
- 4.14 And you think, "Well, what are the preconditions for you respecting someone?" Almost no one respects someone like—what's her name in the Harry Potter movie? Dolores Umbridge. Exactly. She's got this persona morality that's all sweetness and light—a completely contemptible person. Her shadow isn't integrated. It's running the show. You meet people who have that supercilious morality. They're not admirable, and they're generally people who are not—they haven't integrated the dark parts of their psyche into something that's approximating higher-order good.
- 4.15 One of the questions Nietzsche is asking is, "To what degree do you need to aggregate together those parts of your psyche that you might too casually deem as negative to actually serve the higher-order unity that might be good?" The same question presents itself on the social front as well.
- 4.16 "Great men are seldom credited with their stupidity." I think that's a Nietzschean aphorism. And what does he mean by that? Well, it's good to think about that about people you love. Everybody generally has somewhat ambivalent relationships with their parents. As you get older, you see the limitations of your parents, and maybe they stand out for you quite blatantly because your relationship has been fractious and because you're upset that your parents don't represent the ideal. But then you might ask yourself, everyone you meet has their strengths and their weaknesses. It isn't obvious to me at all. You can think of the weaknesses as a limitation, but those limitations are often allied with the particulars of their strengths.
- 4.17 When you love someone, you're making a judgment about their limitations as much as their potentiality. Now, you make the judgment that their particular mode of being is worthwhile and valuable. That's what love means, regardless of the fact that they're constrained in these particular ways that make them who they are and not a generic person.

- 4.18 So then, you have to ask yourself, too, and this is definitely a question worth asking, "Are you so sure that you would rid the people you love of their idiosyncratic weaknesses?" Or are they actually a precondition for the fact that you've established the particular relationship you have established with them? That's a very hard—you can address the same questions to yourself. It's very hard, too, to have a virtue that doesn't come along with its corresponding vice. And the Nietzschean proposition here is, "How certain are you that that vice isn't a precondition for the virtue?" That doesn't mean—you're still faced with the problem of keeping the vice part under control, but you get the point.
- 4.19 In my clinical practice, maybe I'd have a client whose mother was extremely interventionist, phoning the person twice a day when they're in their 30s, haranguing them in one manner or another. And the person is very resentful about that and aggressive about it, but the aggression is unintegrated, and so they can't put up a wall. Well, the problem isn't the resentment or the irritation or the anger or the rage that might emerge as a consequence of being interfered with constantly. The problem is that it's not integrated.
- 4.20 One of the things you do in a situation like that is help the person walk through their dark fantasies. This is a useful thing to do in your own life. If someone annoys you, seriously, you'll see, if you allow it to happen, that you have fantasies about what you might want to do. Now, that doesn't mean you should run off and do those things, but you're being informed about a potential course of actions by the rage system, essentially, if you want to think about it biologically, and you should let that thing have its voice because you'll discover something about yourself.
- 4.21 One of those things might be that maybe you shouldn't be messed with lightly. And unless you know that, you're not going to broadcast that to other people. And if you don't broadcast that to other people, especially if they don't have their own boundaries, they're going to tread on you. And that's not good for you, obviously, but it's also not good for them. If you're dealing with someone who doesn't know how to keep their hands off, let's say, you need to know how to stop them, and you can find the pathway there by consulting your rage.
- 4.22 "But who has the will to concern himself with such dangerous maybes? For that, one really has to wait for the advent of a new species of philosopher, such as we have somehow another and converse taste and propensity from those we have known so far—philosophers of dangerousness, of the dangerous 'maybe' in every sense. And in all seriousness: I see such new philosophers coming up."
- 4.23 It's a lovely paragraph, partly because Nietzsche here puts philosophy forward as a call to romantic adventure. We talked about the fact that he consorted with people like Franz Liszt and Richard Wagner, the adventurous creative types, and Nietzsche is trying to make the point that the philosophical endeavor is an embodied endeavor, that there's a romantic element to it, that it's part of the pursuit of truth in a spirit of adventure. You could say, and it's a question worth posing, "Is there such a thing as the pursuit of truth that isn't accompanied by the spirit of

adventure?" Maybe the spirit of adventure is a marker to the proper pursuit of truth. I think that's true.

- 4.24 In the podcast I do, I interview people who've been radically successful, generally at some enterprise or maybe a set of enterprises. I spend half an hour afterwards talking to them about the details of their biography. Most of them, by the way, have very supportive parents. It's overwhelmingly likely that one of the things they'll talk about when we start going back into their past is how much support they had for the manifestation of their particular interests from both their mother and their father. So, it's very hard on people when they haven't had that early on in their life to bolster their commitment to their interest.
- 4.25 But you see that part of the dynamism that leads to success is the fact that they've been gripped, often at a very early age, by some flickering of their destiny. They're compelled by something, and then they pursue that, and that pursuit has excitement and enthusiasm about it. Enthusiasm means to be imbued with the spirit of God; 'entheos' is the root. And that's in relationship to some valid goal. And that goal is the thing that beckons to them. If you're interested in something, there's a goal there that you might not even understand. The goal is lurking inside the thing that's compelled your interest, and successful people often pursue that in this spirit of adventurous inquiry.
- 4.26 The scientists I've worked with, and the graduate students, for that matter, who've been the most rewarding to work with and with whom the collaboration has been most successful, are people who are on an adventure. You might say, "Was that aligned with this deepest spirit of philosophical inquiry?" I think it's actually deeper than that. I think it's aligned with a theological spirit. In the Old Testament, for example, in the story of Abraham—that's a fundamental story given that Abraham founded the Abrahamic faiths—God makes himself manifest as the call to adventure.
- 4.27 Modern people are very clueless, especially the reductive, atheist, materialist types. They don't ask the questions properly, like the question of what it means to believe. "Do you believe in God?" There's some cynical, straw-manning representation of what constitutes God, followed by the presumption that only a fool would believe in something so preposterous. It's an argument that gets nowhere near the heart of the matter.
- 4.28 In the story of Abraham, you see this situation set up in a very interesting way. Abraham is an 80-year-old man. It's back when people, according to the story, lived much longer. But still, he's eighty. He's a late starter. He's in his tent, and he has a rich father. And he really doesn't have to do anything except lie on his back and eat peeled grapes. There's no necessity. And God comes to him and says, "Leave. Leave your tent, leave your parents, leave your family, leave your tribe, leave your country. Go."
- 4.29 And you think, "What is that?" What is that? Well, it's God. What is that in the story? It's the call to adventure. And then, you say, "Do you believe in that?" Well, the first thing we should note is there's no choice here about not to believe. You're either going to respond to the call to

adventure, in which case you believe in it, or you're going to reject it, in which case you believe in the higher utility of mindless security. They're both beliefs. There's no way out of that conundrum, or maybe you could oscillate between the two, stupidly. But it's a stark choice, and it's a belief on both sides.

- 4.30 And then, you might say, "What would it mean to believe in the spirit of God manifested to Abraham?" And the answer would be, "You leave your damn tent." That's the belief. It's the acting out of the call. And what happens to Abraham, it's pretty dreadful. He encounters tyranny and starvation and war and infidelity, and he enters into the whole catastrophe of his life. But the moral of that story is that voluntary confrontation with the catastrophe of your life is to be much preferred to mindless infantile security.
- 4.31 That's worth thinking about, too. Really worth thinking about because you could say, "I just want to be happy." People say, "I just want to be happy." It's such a preposterous phrase. First of all, what do you mean 'just?' That's all you need? That's what you're saying. "All I want. I don't want much. I just want to be happy all the time. That's all I want, just." So, take 'just' out of that sentence right off the bat.
- 4.32 And then, is it so obvious that what you want is to be happy? First of all, no, because if you inquire into this rigorously, you find that what people mean when they say that isn't that they want to be happy. What they mean is they do not want to be in pain and be anxious. They're way more interested in not suffering than in being happy, and you can understand that because there's only so much happiness, but there's a bottomless world of pain, and so people don't even mean happy when they say happy. They mean not suffering unduly.
- 4.33 And then, the next question is, "What's happiness?" Is that how you feel after a successful Thanksgiving dinner? Is it satiation? Well, then, there's no drive; there's no compulsion. You fall asleep under those conditions. There's no need for consciousness itself. Is that what you want? You want the mindless sleep of a secure infant? Is that the happiness? Or do you want an engaged excitement? And actually, when people mean happiness, and they actually mean happiness, what they mean is something more like engaged excitement. But if you want that, then you have to be pursuing a goal.
- 4.34 And then, the question is, "What goal do you need to be pursuing?" And the answer might be something like, "An adventurous goal." Then, if you really think about it, do you want to be happy, or do you want to have a worthwhile adventure? Let's say right now you have to make a stark choice. Those are your two choices. You could be happy for the rest of your life, or you could have a remarkable adventure. You know that would involve difficulty and obstacles and the overcoming of those obstacles. It would involve a fair amount of suffering. But if it was a worthwhile adventure, the idea would be, well, somehow, despite the difficulty, or maybe even because of the difficulty, it would be worthwhile.
- 4.35 When you look back in your life, you think, "When did things go the best for you?" I wouldn't say that's when you're mindlessly happy, but when you think, "Well, that was really difficult, but I

did it. I did it, and it was worthwhile." And then, you have the question Nietzsche posed in the previous paragraph, which is, "Maybe the difficulty is actually a precondition for the deepest form of satisfaction."

- 4.36 We talked about that a little bit in relationship to relationship. If you marry someone —the word Eve, the word for woman in Hebrew, means 'beneficial adversary.' You want to match yourself with someone who pushes you to a limit that's the limit of your expanded development. Well, that's not happiness exactly. It's something like optimized conflict. It's the optimized conflict that's generative, and the generativeness is aimed at the renewal of the individuals in the relationship and the renewal of the marriage on a continual basis. There's a real dynamism in that. It's not a static happiness.
- 4.37 Well, that's Nietzsche. "In all seriousness: I see such new philosophers coming up." Nietzsche is a pragmatic philosopher, an existential philosopher. He believed that philosophy is something that you do, is something that you act out. It's a stance towards life, not a mere semantic enterprise or a mere enterprise of reductive logic, and that makes him a romantic in the most positive sense.
- 4.38 "After having looked long enough between the philosopher's lines and fingers, I say to myself: by far the greater part of conscious thinking must still be included among instinctive activities." Well, there's a sentence for you. It's like all of psychoanalysis is in that sentence, and it's stated pretty explicitly.
- 4.39 We think of thinking; we have thought about thinking historically as a conscious activity. "I'm aware of my thoughts." Nietzsche flips that and says, "Yeah, there's actually no reason to assume that. It could easily be that most thinking is instinctive." What does he mean by that? Does he mean unconscious? Does he mean implicit? Does he mean biologically motivated? He means all of those things. That opens up the entire landscape of psychoanalytic speculation, the deep unconscious.
- 4.40 The idea that our thinking is characterized by implicit bias, which is part and parcel of the claims put forward in the current culture war, which is true in some sense, is also predicated on the idea that much of our so-called thinking is a reflection of deeply instinctive activity. You might say, "Why would you think that?" Well, most of the complex things you do, your body doesn't let you think about. You don't get to control your digestive processes because you're just not smart enough to do that. And if you start trying to do that, well, good luck to you. You're just going to mess them up. Anything that's important is already taken away from you. The really complex activities are run automatically in the background.
- 4.41 While thinking has this conscious element, there seems to be an element of that that's voluntary. But how much of that is involuntary and unconscious? Think about this—Freud and Jung thought about this forever. You pose yourself a question. This is what thinking is. I think thinking is a form of prayer, by the way. In this manner, you have a problem. First of all, you have to admit to that. That's the question that you want to think about. Well, who are you

posing the question to? It's a question. You don't have the answer to it. Who are you posing the question to? Yourself?

- 4.42 Well, if you can pose the question that you need an answer to yourself, why don't you already have the answer? And then, you might ask yourself, "Where does the answer come from?" And you say—Nietzsche is not very happy about this, by the way, as we'll see—"I thought it up." It's like, "What do you mean by that?" What exactly did you do? And the answer is, "You don't know."
- 4.43 Jung said something like—this was his characterization of typical thought. He said, "People come across thoughts the same way they come across a table in a kitchen." It's just there in your phenomenological field. You pose a question, an answer appears. You think, "I thought that up." It's like, "No, it just sprang out of the void." Then, you apprehend it, and maybe you'll take credit for it, but you probably shouldn't because, at minimum, you could say, if you came up with an answer to a complex question, the probability that the long-dead spirit of some philosopher operating within you generated that answer is certain.
- 4.44 You might say, "Why believe that?" Well, you didn't invent the words you used to formulate the thoughts. You probably didn't even come up with the phraseology, and the probability that you're going to come up with an answer that someone else hasn't already come up with that's implicit in what you already know is very, very low. Maybe you'll do something original, but hardly anyone ever does.
- 4.45 And thank god for that because how many original ideas do you need or want? Because we're naive. We think, "Creativity is an untrammelled good." That's an utterly clueless proposition. Most creative ideas are destructive. And of those that aren't creative, most are just simply wrong. It's a vanishingly small percentage of creative ideas that are actually going to be practically implementable in a positive sense. That's why most businesses fail. That doesn't mean they're not necessary. They're necessary, but they're not an untrammelled good.
- 4.46 "By far the greater part of conscious thinking must still be included among instinctive activities, and that goes even for philosophical thinking." That opens the question. The Postmodernists went mad with this, "What are the unconscious motivations for the putting forward of philosophical propositions?" And then, they leapt too quickly, again, to the answer, "It's all colonialism, it's all power, it's all domination." No, some of it is, and that's a way different claim than all of it is.
- 4.47 What other things motivate philosophical thinking? Well, the will to beauty, the will to truth, the will to affiliation, the will to play, the will to eat, the will to family, the will to security, the will to relationship with animals for that matter. There's all sorts of underlying motivations that are going to be driving our thinking, and to reduce all that to power is utterly foolish.
- 4.48 "We have to relearn here, as one has to relearn about heredity and what is 'innate.' As the act of birth deserves no consideration in the whole process and procedure of heredity, so 'being

conscious' is not in any decisive sense the opposite of what is instinctive—most of the conscious thinking of a philosopher is secretly guided and forced into certain channels by his instincts."

- 4.49 Now, Nietzsche does a variety of things there. Remember earlier, he objected to the idea of simple opposites, and now instantly he's applying that in a practical sense and saying, "Don't be so sure that conscious and unconscious are opposites." It could easily be that conscious is the surface manifestation of a set of unconscious processes. And then, the question emerges, "What are the unconscious processes that are guiding the corpus of philosophical inquiry?"
- 4.50 Out of that, again, emerges the whole tradition of psychoanalytically oriented literary criticism, the search for biological motivations, even in literary productions. We talked about the fact that the Freudians, the simple-minded Freudians, tended to reduce everything to sex and power. And then, the even more simple-minded Neo-Marxists took even sex out of the equation. You can't quit breaking things apart.
- 4.51 "The falseness of a judgment is for us not necessarily an objection to a judgment." So, that's a new proposition, especially in the wake of the Enlightenment, because we tended to make the assumption that if it's false, it's wrong. So, there's a moral issue that immediately emerges. Not only is it incorrect if it's false, it's also wrong if it's false. So, Nietzsche is questioning that. In this respect, he's doing it ironically because he's not really making a case for falsehood as such. He's beginning to make a case that —well, a case that expands out in multiple directions—that what constitutes the truth for us is not so obvious. It's not merely the objective; it's not merely the subjective. What we mean by truth when we use the word 'truth' is in itself a mystery.
- 4.52 One of the things that Nietzsche will point out, as we'll encounter very soon, is that he believes that truth should affirm life, and that's actually a precondition for truth. So, his claim—it's a Darwinian claim in a fundamental sense, even though he's not a Darwinian—if it doesn't affirm life, it's not true. It's a different definition of what constitutes truth. It might even be reflective of the distinction between Newtonian and Darwinian truth, or Newtonian, Baconian truth, and Darwinian truth.
- 4.53 If our goal is to survive and reproduce, if that's the necessary precondition for the maintenance of life, then what's true for us, given that we're alive, is it not integrally tied up with the enterprise of sustaining and propagating life? And by necessity. And then, if you had to rank-order truths so that there was an objective truth and a pragmatic truth that served life, wouldn't it be incumbent upon you to put the pragmatic truth that serves life on a higher pedestal than the merely objective truth?
- 4.54 Here's a question. The KGB, at one point in the Soviet Union, were experimenting with hybridizing Ebola and smallpox to produce a highly contagious pathogen that was 100% fatal. They wanted to aerosolize that. You could say, "There's an objective truth to going about that." Well, it's the same thing with gain-of-function research for viruses. You can go investigate that. Should you? If you decide to investigate that because you say, "It's just one fact among many,"

and all facts are the same because they're objective—there's no value ranking of the facts — then why not investigate gain-of-function research in viruses?

- 4.55 Now, the people who do that claim, "Maybe we can identify viral mutants that will be particularly harmful and learn how to control them." I think that's a specious argument. The alternative might be, "Don't do that." You're putting the cart before the horse there. You're forgetting that you're in an ethos that allows you to select the appropriate facts to investigate, assuming that the ethos that's guiding you is, well, what? Broadly pro-human, broadly life-affirming? I know that's very complicated and messy, but you get the point.
- 4.56 You could pursue facts. You could pursue the facts that led you to the eradication of the species. They're perfectly real and true facts, but I think it's not unreasonable, at least, to raise objections to doing that, and then, also, to note that in raising those objections, you are at the same time and inescapably asking yourself questions about what actually constitutes truth. That's what Nietzsche is doing here in his ironic manner. He's not making a case for falsehood. He's trying to break your frame and suggest that what you regard as self-evident about truth and its redemptive qualities is not so self-evident.
- 4.57 "The falseness of a judgment is for us not necessarily an objection to a judgment. In this respect, our new language may sound strangest. The question is, to what extent is it life-promoting, life-preserving, species-preserving, perhaps even species-cultivating." To add another twist to it, it's not merely a matter of preservation. The truth that's the highest doesn't just preserve the individual and the species, but also preserves it in a manner that simultaneously expands its—what would you say—its adaptive capacity, something like that, if you wanted to couch it in a biological language.
- 4.58 That goes back to the idea that we've been developing, that in a relationship, you don't want just stable security. You want a modicum of stable security plus an **optimized challenge** because you're not trying to merely preserve; you're trying to enhance and develop. So, the truth here—he's such a genius because he'll do something radical like this and then, just with a tiny sleight of hand, add something even more radical to it. You hardly even notice. He'll do that with a word, and then you move on to another sentence. "Perhaps even species cultivating." The truth would not only serve stability but the stability that renews itself and becomes more stable and productive across time. And that's a higher-order ethos. So brilliant.
- 4.59 "And we are fundamentally inclined to claim that the falsest judgments (which include the **synthetic judgments a priori**)"—we'll leave that to the side for now—"are the most indispensable for us. " That's a tough one, too. "And we are fundamentally inclined to claim that the falsest judgments are the most indispensable for us. "
- 4.60 What does he mean by that? It's ironic, again. Unquestioned axiomatic statements. We hold these truths to be self-evident, right? There's a set of propositions that are unspecified, that the American polity rests upon, derived from the English law tradition that grounds the entire body

of laws in a set of propositions. Well, those propositions are accepted a priori. They're not elements of inquiry.

- 4.61 So, he would regard them—this is ironic, I believe—as fundamental falsehoods. They're not even in the philosophical discussion. You just accept them. You accept them as valid so that you can proceed in the analysis and the argumentation. So, what he's saying is that some things have to be beyond question for there to be any questions at all. And that's a very interesting idea. I believe it's also true. "That without accepting the fictions of logic."
- 4.62 Jung, for example, concluded, like the Postmodernists concluded, I would say, that the whole scientific enterprise is nested inside a fiction, and for Jung, the fiction was the alchemical fiction. Science emerged out of alchemy. Alchemy was a process, an undertaking that existed for thousands of years before we formally became scientists. The alchemical dream was a fictional dream, and the dream was—if we investigated the transformations of the material world, we would find within that world a substance that would enable us to be healthy without end, to live forever, and to transmute ordinary material into gold, into that which is most valuable.
- 4.63 So, the dream lurking in the material world was a magical substance or process that eventually became an ethic of inquiry, by the way, rather than a substance or a process. It became an ethic of inquiry that would enable us to reveal this treasure that exists buried in the secrets of matter. That provided the emotional dynamism of science.
- 4.64 It's like, why do people do this? It's because they're possessed by a dream. Is the dream fictional? Yes, it's a narrative. Is it a falsehood? Well, that's a harder question. That's partly what Nietzsche is doing here is ironic. What's the difference between a fiction and a lie? A fiction never happened. Is a movie a lie? Well, we would say no. We know there's a distinction between fiction and lie, but the distinction isn't easy to draw.
- 4.65 Then, you might say, "Are there fictions that are more true than other fictions?" We certainly have a sense that that's the case because you go to a movie, and the movie is satisfying, deeply satisfying, to the degree that it's deep, but also to the degree that it's deep and true. Then, you think, "What do you mean both by deep and true, especially true, given that you know that the movie is a fiction?" There's nothing in it that ever really happened. All those questions are lurking behind the questions that Nietzsche is asking here.
- 4.66 "Without measuring reality against the purely invented world of the unconditional and self-identical, without a constant falsification of the world by means of numbers, man could not live." So, the other specter he's raising, we transform the world into useful simplifications. Like, is the floor white? Well, you'd say, "Yes, well, look at the floor." If you were painting that, first of all, you'd find that white with no tint did not capture the color. The second thing you'd find is there's an infinite variety of gradations of shadow. The thing that you can summarize as white is actually, there's all sorts of colors in it. There are reflections from the curtains, there are different colored shadows, but white somehow sums it up, and that's a fiction.

- 4.67 And then, is it a fiction that's a lie? The only way you can answer that question is by coming up with a formulation of the truth that somehow allows that fiction to stand as a truth. I would say, "For the point of casual conversation, the floor and the wall is white." It's good enough. That's **pragmatism**, by the way. It's the **pragmatists**, William James and his crew in the Eastern United States, the only genuine brand of American philosophy. The **pragmatists** who were Darwinians believe that all of our concepts were pragmatic simplifications, and that truth was to be detected in the utility of a proposition in relationship to a goal.
- 4.68 So, this isn't white if you want to be a photorealistic painter, but if you want to just point out when you go home, when you're talking to your partner, what the background of the lecture was for purposes of filming, you'll say it was white. And the reason for that is that is that that's good enough. It does the trick. It gets you where you want to go. That's a very interesting way of thinking about truth. Truth gets you where you want to go.
- 4.69 Now, it's more complicated than that because the question, "Where should you want to go?" lurks at the bottom of that. That makes the situation far more complex than a mere simple instrumentality. That a truth is what's ever convenient to use as a tool. It's like, yeah, but there's a hierarchy of moral striving, and there's a hierarchy of tools, and your conceptions have to fit within that. Nietzsche is pointing to all of that in one paragraph.
- 4.70 "Without a constant falsification of the world by means of concepts," he says numbers, "man could not live— that renouncing false judgments would mean renouncing life in a denial of life." So, he's saying that an insistence on too stringent a level of accuracy would force you into stasis. If you couldn't move forward with your fictions, you couldn't move forward at all. Well, that's definitely a conundrum.
- 4.71 "To recognize untruth as a condition of life—that certainly means resisting accustomed value feelings in a dangerous way; and a philosophy that risks this would be by that token alone place itself **beyond good and evil**." Well, and it begs the question, which he introduces here, what does he mean? What does the title mean, **Beyond Good and Evil**? It means, at minimum, the forswearing of these frog nooks. He said you can have a simple-minded way of apprehending the relationship between good and evil as simple and stark opposites, with all the good being on the good side and all the evil being on the evil side, but that's an impractical and counterproductive oversimplification. It isn't obvious at all that your initial stance about what constitutes good and evil is sufficient to orient you properly, morally, in the world.
- 4.72 We could talk about the therapeutic endeavor again. One of the things you do as a therapist is help people integrate within the many of the things that they would have cast out as useless and evil. So, for example, there's two things you do quite commonly as a therapist, and one is to help people deal with anxiety. You help them discover within themselves a propensity for creative confrontation with terror that can redeem them, that they have suppressed or failed to develop, and perhaps also cast into the domain of what is untenable morally.

- 4.73 Imagine you're a very nice person. You're going to do everything you can not to get in someone's way or harm them or to impose your will. What would you say in a selfish manner? It's like, to what degree does that make you weak in the face of adversity? Now, that's a more subtle question in the case of anxiety, but it's not a more subtle question in the case of—maybe you're being bullied, and maybe you don't stand up for yourself. You're too nice in that regard, and you believe that your niceness is a moral virtue because all that aggression, let's say, that capacity for anger, the capacity for physical violence even, is evil.
- 4.74 It's like, well, not so quick because it isn't obvious at all that the fact that you conduct yourself such that other people can take advantage of you isn't a moral failing. First of all, it's hard on you in manner that might be unsustainable. It stops you from being able to do what you need to do and want to do. It stops you from being able to let your light shine, let's say. But you also enable the people who are exploitative.
- 4.75 So, I don't understand how that's a moral good at all. So, part of what happens in psychotherapy is the **revaluation** of good and evil, that your narrow moral perspective might be precisely what's making you weak. And that means that your categories of good and evil are not canonical. They're oversimplified. They're not canonical. Things are much more complex than you might think, and even on the moral front.
- 4.76 You have to understand that, for Nietzsche, moving **beyond good and evil** isn't the claim that we live in a morally relative world. He's not making that claim at all. You know that good and evil in and of themselves are categories that we should dispense with, that there's no absolute good or no absolute evil. He's not making those arguments. At least he's making an argument that, "Don't be thinking you got the answer, that this problem solved so easily." So, that's one—what would you call—that's one objection. And the corollary of that would be, "Don't be so sure that you haven't thrown the baby out with the bathwater, especially with regards to what you might consider evil." In that waste dump, there may be things that you 100% need to reclaim in order to move yourself up the hill.
- 4.77 "Gradually, it has become clear to me what every great philosophy so far has been: namely, the personal confession of its author." So, a disguised autobiography, the unfolding of an implicit ethic, rather than the discovery of that as a consequence of the philosophical enterprise, an autobiographical self-disclosing. "The personal confession of its author, and a kind of involuntary and unconscious memoir; also that the moral (or immoral) intentions in every philosophy constituted the real germ of life from which the whole plant had grown."
- 4.78 What are you up to? Jung, taking a page from Nietzsche, believed that people acted out—you act out a story. In fact, a story is a description of the manner in which you prioritize your attention in the world and act. And the reason that we value stories is because you need to know how to prioritize your attention. What should you look at? There's a lot of things to look at. There's an infinite number of things to look at. Your attentional resources are valuable and scarce. They should be parceled out very carefully.

- 4.79 Why do we look at other people's eyes? Why are our eyes evolved so that they're very easy to see so that we can tell where other people are pointing their eyes? Because our eyes have evolved in that way. That's why they're dark against a white background, so we can see them. We're unbelievably good at detecting tiny deviations in the direction of someone's gaze. So, for example, we're a long ways away and I can tell if you're looking at my eyes. Can you tell I'm looking at your nose? Right. It's this tiniest shift.
- 4.80 And you might say, "Why do we look at people's eyes?" And the answer is, "Because we want to know what they're looking at." Then, you might say, "Why do we want to know what they're looking at?" The answer is, "So that we know what's worth looking at." If you tell a story, what you're doing is telling me what you think is worth looking at. Now, it's more complicated than that because you're also telling me how you sequence your actions, but your actions follow attention. They follow in the wake of attention. A story is actually a description of the structure that prioritizes attention.
- 4.81 That's really worth knowing. That's why we love stories so much. They help us solve the most fundamental—if you watch a hero on a movie screen, the hero has a hierarchy of attentional priority. He attends to some things, maxes that out, and not to others. And the consequence of that hierarchy of attention is his success in the venture. You want to see what stories provide you with a hierarchy of attention that provides you with success in a heroic adventure.
- 4.82 Now, Nietzsche—Jung pointed out that we all inhabit a story, but most of us unconsciously. You live out a myth. It's got you in its grip. You're embedded in a story. And then, the question arises, "What's the story?" Maybe it's a tragedy. Maybe it's an Oedipal tragedy. You end up suicidal. You're too close and dependent. You sleep with your mother, so to speak. You burn out your eyes as a consequence. Is that the story that's got you in its grip? That's the Freudian Oedipal drama. What are the range of stories? You're in a story. Or worse, you're in a set of fragmented stories with no coherence whatsoever. But there's no escape from the story.
- 4.83 And then, you might ask, "What's the story?" That's Nietzsche's question here. Every philosophy is the revelation of this implicit story, and the story itself is the seed from which the entire philosophy grew. It's so interesting. We talked about the relationship yesterday between Nietzsche and Dostoevsky. I would say, if you would like to study Nietzsche seriously—it's quite a lot of fun—you should read Dostoevsky at the same time because you see the story because Dostoevsky is telling the story that's the encapsulation of the Nietzschean philosophy, and so reading them both at once is extremely interesting because you get the explicit philosophy, you get the story at the same time. So, it's very compelling.
- 4.84 "Also that the moral or immoral attentions in every philosophy constituted the real germ of life from which the whole plant had grown," an idea very much related to Richard Dawkins's idea of meme. You know that a meme is an idea that has an independent existence. It can float from mind to mind. It can be transmitted. It's got a life. Well, for Nietzsche, if Dawkins would have continued to develop his thinking, he would have developed the idea of archetype because an archetype is a meta-meme. An archetype is a meme that spans millennia. It's a meme that is

permanent. It never goes away. It shapes whole cultures. It shapes entire psyches. It's spread everywhere. It's a god, for all intents and purposes.

- 4.85 And then, you might ask, "Is there a meta god behind all the partial gods of the archetypes?" Jung's answer to that was the self. That's his conception of the self, a meta-meme. And Jung believed that Christ was a symbol of the self. It's an extraordinarily sophisticated line of thinking; much of it was generated in response to Nietzsche's *Beyond Good and Evil* because Jung tried to answer this question.
- 4.86 "What is the moral or immoral intention in every philosophy that constitutes the real germ of life from which the whole plant had grown?" You might ask, there's a body of Western philosophy. There's a generative idea at the base of that. You could think of that as a spirit. That's the philosophical spirit. "What is it aiming at? What's its fundamental?" And then, you might say, "If it's an admirable spirit, noble spirit, truth-seeking spirit, spirit that strives after beauty, what's the nature of that spirit?"
- 4.87 It's at the bottom of the philosophical endeavor. And it's the mustard seed that's referred to in the Gospels. It's exactly the same idea. So, there's in you, there's an animating idea. Now, there might be a lot of them because you're confused. But to the degree that you're not confused, there's a central animating idea, and you could say that's you, but it's more accurate to say, "No, it's the spirit that possesses you." Or maybe it's the spirit that you have allowed to possess you. Or maybe it's the spirit that you've invited in and conspired with to possess you.
- 4.88 People who brood on very dark things are exactly in that situation. They invite something that's really not in their best interest and toy and play with it, often for months or years. You can see that if you're interested in that. You read the diaries of the high school shooters, and you'll find out exactly what that spirit is and what happens when you play with it for years in your brooding resentment.
- 4.89 "Indeed, if one would explain how the abstrusest metaphysical claims of a philosopher really came about, it is always well (and wise) to ask first: at what morality does all this (does he) aim?" What's the moral of the story? What's the point of the argument? The point specifies a destination. A destination is a place, in principle, that you want to go to. It's morally elevated because it's better than where you are because, otherwise, why go? So, there's an implicit ethic there.
- 4.90 What's the point of the philosophy? The point of the philosophy is the seed from which the entire philosophy grows. It's the elaboration of the point. When someone's talking to you, you might say, "Get to the point, or what's the point of the story?" It's the same as asking, "What's the moral of the story?" And that's the same as asking, "What direction is implicit in the discussion?" Where are we going here? And that's the question. That's the question that Nietzsche is trying to ask here as well.
- 4.91 "Accordingly, I do not believe that a 'drive to knowledge' is the father of philosophy; but rather that another drive has, here as elsewhere, employed understanding and misunderstanding as a

mere instrument. But anyone who considers the basic drives of man to see what extent they may have been at play, just here as inspiring spirits (or **demons** and kobolds) will find that all of them have done philosophy at some time—and that every single one of them would like only too well to represent just itself as the ultimate purpose of existence and the legitimate master of all the other drives, for every drive wants to be master—and it attempts to philosophize in that spirit."

- 4.92 He's so bloody brilliant because we don't think this—even psychologists, even. "Anger is a drive." It's like, "No, it's not." It's not a mechanistic apparatus. Anger is a personality. It has a viewpoint. It has an ethos. It has a set of perceptions. It has a set of goals. It has a compelling set of arguments at its disposal, and it can take you over. And you know this. You have an argument with someone you love, and you say things that you would say, "I can't believe I said that." It's like, "Yeah, the anger demon has occupied you and dominated you." What happens neurologically is when a motivational drive of that sort takes prominence, it inhibits everything else. You start to speak in the spirit of the anger.
- 4.93 You know how annoying someone is when you're angry. That's direct perception. It's not like you see them, think you're annoying—think they're annoying. You see them as annoying. That's part and parcel of the anger itself. It's even gripped your perception. It's not a secondary conclusion. And Nietzsche's point here. So brilliant. These motivational drives, these basic id-like impulses, have elaborated themselves up into entire philosophies. You could say, "A satanic spirit might be the intermingling of resentment, lust, and anger." The philosophy of all three of those drives intermingled into something like a coherent existential statement that shapes perception, shapes attention, and shapes action.
- 4.94 And so, well, then you think, "Do you fall prey to the possession by those fragmentary spirits, the fragmentary philosophies? Are they integrated? If they're not integrated, then you're disintegrated. If they're not integrated across a community, then everyone is fighting. What's the nature of the unity? And is there a motivation that's the unity of fundamental motivations that then philosophizes in the spirit of that overarching unity?" I say, well, that's the monotheistic question.
- 4.95 Really, that's the monotheistic question. All these fundamental systems. They're deities in some real sense. They have a philosophical outlook. There's a multitude of them. Is there a manner in which they're integrated into something that approximates a unity? Is that unity a transcendent reality? And is that the unity to which you properly owe fealty if you want to be united psychologically and socially? It's the entire monotheistic question.
- 4.96 And so, that's a good place to stop for today. Thank you very much.

5. The Will to Power

AT A GLANCE

Reads Nietzsche's claim that life is will to power rather than self-preservation—a living thing seeks to discharge its strength—and explores it through homeostasis, optimized transformation, and voluntary combat, alongside Jung's persona, shadow, and anima. Dismantles the immediate certainties of 'I think': the falsification in 'I,' the affordances that saturate perception, the pragmatism of William James, and thoughts that come when 'it' wishes, not when 'I' wish. Uses Piaget's account of how the child's fragmented states integrate into a self to argue that sanity is a dance with others, and asks what unifying spirit underlies will to power.

- 5.1 We're walking through Nietzsche's thought, paragraph by paragraph. I think we'll jump right in today.
- 5.2 "Physiologists should think before putting down the instinct of self-preservation as the cardinal instinct of an organic being." There's this idea among psychologists, for a long time, that's relevant to the problem that Nietzsche is pointing out, the notion that organisms are homeostasis seeking, that we seek some secure balance. The problem with that idea is that it presumes something approximating an optimal normality, that if you were optimized, you'd be normal and stable. That's not right. The reason for that is that it doesn't include any consideration of the necessity for transformation and growth.
- 5.3 You might ask yourself, "Do you want to settle into a homeostatic state where everything's in balance, or do you want to keep yourself on a developmental edge so that you're optimally transforming so that the probability that you could contend with the vagaries of the future would increase?" That would mean that the state that you're striving for isn't so much a balanced stability as an optimal transformation.
- 5.4 And then, you could say, even more deeply, and Nietzsche wouldn't have known this at his time, that that's actually where consciousness itself functions and intensifies because one of the things that consciousness does is note inadequacies in unconsciousness and rectify them.
- 5.5 So, for example, if you're playing a piece on the piano and you've automated it, so you play a lot of it unconsciously, you may find that you've automated an error, and so you stumble over a particular phrase. And then, what you do is you return to where that phrase is, and you rectify the erroneous element, and you re-automatize a new section, and then you slot that into the automated section that you've already—what would you call —mastered by habit, and then you move on.
- 5.6 So, you can think about consciousness as something that moves up and down a hierarchy of unconsciousness, and repairs and transforms. And then, you can't think of optimal function as a homeostasis because it involves a dynamic transformation. If you exclude that from

consideration, I would say you exclude from consideration a lot of what makes life both gripping, meaningful, and capable of constantly updating.

- 5.7 In Nietzsche's notion, instead, he says, "A living thing seeks above all to discharge its strength." It's that sort of opposite of the notion of conservation of energy. It's, in fact, a desire for an optimized expenditure of energy. "Life itself is **will to power**; **self-preservation** is"—instead of the primary goal or the primary driving factor—"one of the most indirect and most frequent results."
- 5.8 Well, and you might say, too, if you lived on the edge and attempted to optimize your transformations, that would be the best manner in which to ensure your **self-preservation** across time. But it's not a conserving function. It's a function that involves expenditure. Now, Nietzsche's **will to power** is more complex than that notion of optimized transformation, let's say. You see this emerging as the book progresses, as he fleshes out what **will to power** might be.
- 5.9 Here's an example we referred to yesterday in the last lecture. Imagine you find yourself embroiled in an argument and you become angry. What happens is the circuitry that mediates defensive aggression makes itself manifest. It's instantiated subcortically, and then it emerges as a potential personality for dealing with the situation. It emerges and dominates the cortex, and then that domination inhibits all competing **sub-personalities**. That's why it's hard to act reasonably, let's say, when you're angry.
- 5.10 It's also anger, by the way—aggression inhibits fear. It's one of its psychophysiological properties. That's why if you chase an animal into a corner—if it's a small animal with a broom, it'll run because it's afraid. But if you keep bothering it, and it's cornered, it'll eventually jump out and attack you, and that's because, well, it switches from the domination of fear, a **sub-personality**, to the domination of anger, and the anger inhibits the fear.
- 5.11 Any psychophysiological state that inhabits you—you can think about that as possession by a spirit—inhibits all others. Well, that capacity and desire to inhibit, that's the self-righteousness that goes along with anger, is that sense that something's got you and it wants to keep that. That's that **will to power**. And so, lurking in the idea of Nietzsche's **will to power** is this idea that the multiple drives, as he said, tend to philosophize in their own spirit, but they also tend to strive for dominance. They have to as well because if you get hungry, if the hunger doesn't dominate, you don't eat. If you get thirsty and then the thirst doesn't dominate, you don't drink. So, all these wills, sub-wills, **sub-personalities**, have to have both the capacity to dominate and the determination to dominate.
- 5.12 And then, Nietzsche posits something beyond that, which I think is extraordinarily interesting, which is that there's something that's common to all the wills that are **will to power**, that is this desire to unify and dominate as such. So, it might be the emergent will to unify and dominate; that's the **will to power**. Now, Nietzsche remains, especially in **Beyond Good and Evil**—he

remains vague as to what that is, and I think that's partly because he doesn't have that conceptualization fully fleshed out. And I actually think it's a weakness in his thought.

- 5.13 So, for example, as we'll see later, he identifies Christian morality with **slave morality**. And yet he also—but there's a will to union in Christianity, a monotheistic will to unity in Judeo-Christianity. That will to unity would be the monotheism, the notion that there's only one spirit. Now, **Nietzsche** identifies that spirit in Christianity with the slave spirit that wants to overthrow. He has reasons for doing that, but it sets up a tension in his thought because he posits a **will to power** that's a monotheism that's not Christian.
- 5.14 But what's the weakness exactly? It isn't obvious that what he's criticizing isn't the same thing that he's aiming at, and he doesn't flesh out the antithesis of, let's say, the Judeo-Christian monotheistic spirit. He doesn't flesh out how that's precisely antithetical to this drive towards unity that he posits as central to the **will to power**.
- 5.15 He's very ambiguous about this as a consequence. So, for example, as we'll see, he expresses admiration for certain elements of Jewish thought, especially the Old Testament narrative, which he regards as admirably heroic. He's very critical of the New Testament theology that's laid on top of that because he sees it serving this usurping **slave morality** that he's not a fan of. But then, he lapses into praise for gospel doctrine in some sense, as opposed to traditional and institutional Christianity.
- 5.16 So, you could say, I think with accuracy, that the spirit that **Nietzsche** regards as the unity that **will to power** pursues is not fully developed in his conceptual system, and it's partly because **Nietzsche** is trying to determine what might be an alternative pathway to something approximating a higher unity as a necessity, as a necessary antidote to the **death of God**. But he knows that God has died, but that doesn't mean he knows what's going to arise to replace it. He says, "We'll have to create our own values."
- 5.17 But do we create our own values, or do they emerge from this necessary competition between these basic forces that are parts of fragmentary instinctual will? And if they emerge from that competition, they're not exactly our own creations. There's real ambiguity about this unity towards which he believes that we should strive. He has to hint at it.
- 5.18 A lot of what **Beyond Good and Evil** is is actually a series of—they're almost like photographs or images of what this central spirit might be that should emerge among the philosophers of the future that might constitute a replacement for God. He doesn't want it to be a **slave morality**. He doesn't want it to be predicated on the notion of flattening egalitarianism or predicated on an emotion which he's not particularly fond of, like pity, and—what would you say—all-embracing feminine infantilization of the human spirit.
- 5.19 **Jung** contended with this to a great degree because one of the things **Jung** was trying to understand was how you might conceptualize the spirit that emerges within the psyche to unify the psyche. Imagine that your goal as you develop is to take the multiplicitous spirits that inhabit

you and integrate them into a single totality. The question might be, "What would that totality—what would that totality be and how would it be represented?"

- 5.20 Jung believed that you start with a persona, and that's the mask that you wear in society to convince other people that you're much better than you actually are, and that's a weak adaptation because it mostly means that you put yourself forward as inoffensive and easy to get along with. That's part of this Nietzschean slave morality that insists that to the degree that you're harmless, you're moral.
- 5.21 Nietzsche was not an admirer of that idea; neither was Jung. He thought that that was a bloodless way of living and that one of the ways forward past the mere persona, which would make you, by the way, easily exploitable by other people and perhaps also prone to exploit them as a consequence of your resentment, would be the integration of the shadow. And that's part of this moving beyond good and evil.
- 5.22 Jung knew that because he was a student of Nietzsche. That pushes you past the persona. You can play with this developmental process personally without much problem if you're honest. Jung also said that moral endeavor was a good substitute for psychotherapy. Imagine that you are soft and easily pushed around, agreeable, and likely to sacrifice yourself in the service of others, not because you're courageous and that you do that consciously, but because you're too weak to stand up for yourself.
- 5.23 And then, you find that you have that; you betray yourself constantly, and you get resentful as a consequence of it. And then, what will happen is the resentment will breed all sorts of dark fantasies, and you'll try to push those away because they're uncomfortable. They reveal something about you that's the opposite of what you think you should be, even though it's maybe the thing you really need the most. Those fantasies will be dark in precise proportion to the degree that you're weak. That's exactly how that works.
- 5.24 The people, for example, who shoot up high schools, who nurse the darkest fantasies you could possibly imagine for years, they're unbelievably weak and easily pushed around. They're way over here on the will not stand up for themselves and bow to the mob side, and what they get in response is this bubbling up of these unbelievably vicious fantasies.
- 5.25 And then, while they'll toy with them or toy with acting out the fantasies, other people will ignore them entirely. And what really needs to happen is that those have to be— you have to enter into a dialogue with them and see what they're pointing to and then determine how what they're aiming at might be integrated into how you live in a manner that's civilized. You don't want to fall prey to the self-sacrificing slave-like martyrdom, but you also don't want to fall prey to the resentful, violent fantasies that emerge in distinction to that.
- 5.26 The Jungian idea of integration of the shadow was to take that pathological domain of compensatory fantasy. And you think, "Wow, you know what? People can push me around, but there's part of me that's, like, vicious beyond belief and response." Like, "Yeah, well, that's exactly the part that you have to draw on so that you can't be pushed around." This is why Jung

believed that fantasies were compensatory, by the way, and that integration of the fantasy moves you towards this ideal.

- 5.27 Now, Jung also believed—it's quite relevant, I would say, in an era that's obsessed with transsexuality. A lot of transsexuals are men who decide to cross-dress when they're in their 40s. There's a real sexual element to that. You might ask, from a Jungian perspective, exactly what's going on. These are men, you could say, who have a very narrow concept of what constitutes masculinity. One of the consequences of that narrowness, for example, is they may have determined that anything that's creative and decorative is only associated with the feminine. That means they remove the entire domain of artistic endeavor from the—what would you say—the moral allowance for their personality. "You can't do that because it's a girly thing to do," and boys learn that very early.
- 5.28 I remember, for example, in grade 4, we had a teacher who would teach us all to sing; the girls would sing, and the boys hardly would sing at all. The reason for that was the boys were afraid of looking feminine by enjoying the music. You can see that that's a catastrophe for men, especially if they're creative. What happens later in life with some men is that the feminine starts to become attractive as an object of fantasy, and you might think about it as an attempt—it's an attempt by the personality to manifest a higher unity.
- 5.29 But it gets concretized. They acted out as if it's—well, it'll even grip them sexually, the fantasy. It should be played out as a process of integration, but they concretize it, say they start to dress like women, and there's a sexual kick in that. The sexual kick is partly there because the drive to do that is so intense that it even incorporates sexuality. You can think about it as a psychodrama. It doesn't mean that they're women. That's the big problem. Well, one of the big problems with that.
- 5.30 For Jung, that unity towards which the psyche was striving, which you could think about as the highest manifestation of the will to power in the Nietzschean sense, meant the continual inclusion of that which had been excluded by arbitrary moral fiat. For example, if you're masculine, you can never show kindness, you can never show pity, you can never do anything creative. You could reverse that for women and think, well, if you're female, you can't do anything that's intimidating. You can't be strong physically. You can't be competitive in sports.
- 5.31 The lines aren't quite as clearly drawn for women as they are for men now, because women are more allowed to be like men than men are allowed to be like women. But Jung's notion was all of that had to be incorporated into the psyche as it developed and flourished, and that the psyche was therefore aiming at some higher unity. Now, he called that higher unity the "self." And as I told you yesterday, Jung regarded the symbol of Christ as a symbol of the self.
- 5.32 That stands in real contradistinction to Nietzsche's formulation because Nietzsche tended to associate Christianity with the emergence of slave morality and didn't identify the figure of Christ symbolically with our culture's representation of the highest possible psychological unity, but that's where Jung went. And it's very interesting to see that because Jung was a very intense

student of Nietzsche. He understood Nietzsche extremely well and spent most of his career, I would say, trying to continue the work that Nietzsche had begun, even more so than the work that Freud had begun.

- 5.33 "A living thing seeks above all to discharge its strength—life itself is will to power; self-preservation is only one of the indirect and most frequent results." Now, you can see Nietzsche starting to work out. It's like, there's this will to power that characterizes all wills, all underlying motivations. That will to power aims at unity. What's the nature of that unity? Well, here he says, well, it's not some simple homeostatic self-preservation. It has more to do with the voluntary expenditure of energy.
- 5.34 So, that's more like life as voluntary combat. That's partly why there's an element of Nietzsche that's—he worships a pre-Christian heroism. He's an admirer of Roman and Greek military strength at the individual level. There's an element of stoicism in Nietzsche. He believes that the reincorporation of those more classically masculine and warlike virtues was a necessary antidote to the emerging psychological and sociological, political, economic weakness of Europe as it became more and more dominated by a pitying, overarching, infantilizing maternal embrace. Switch gears because Nietzsche switched gears frequently.
- 5.35 "There are still harmless self-observers who believe that there are immediate certainties." So, now we're back at the problem of axiomatic presuppositions. What do you take for granted? It's a very interesting thing. I'm trying to teach my students this all the time. If someone poses a question to you, the question begs the answer. There's a hint in the question about what it is that you're required to accept as a certainty before you move ahead with the discussion. One of the dangers of that is that, if you answer a question without questioning the question, you accept the frame of reference that the questioner places on your actions and your responses. So, often, you can lose the argument before it even gets off the ground. I'll give an example of this.
- 5.36 In Canada, in the last federal election, the federal politicians, from socialist to conservative, answered five questions, but all the questions were defined a priori by the Liberals. So, as far as I was concerned, the Conservatives lost before they even opened their mouths because they spent 40% of the debate debating Native Canadian reconciliation and climate change. Well, it was 40% of the debate. They allowed the terms to be set by the interlocutors. It didn't matter what they said at that point because they'd already agreed that those were the most important things to discuss.
- 5.37 And so, the question always arises in any dialogue or when you're encountering any philosophical system, "What are the invisible certainties that have to be accepted before you can partake in the discussion?" And if you're awake when you're discussing with people, especially if it's a conflictual discussion, the first thing you want to ask is, "Just what the hell are you presuming with your question?" It's impolite. Nietzsche talks later about the necessity of cruelty and the seeking of truth.

- 5.38 If you ask me a question and, instead of me answering it, I go after the question, there's an element of cruelty, so to speak, in that for me because I'm not letting you get away with your tricks. And you might not even know their tricks, and you probably don't, because you're just going to assume that the **axiomatic presuppositions** of your questions are, obviously, reality itself. That's your standpoint. You could easily be wrong about that in some completely fundamental way, and **Nietzsche** is trying to delve into that in this paragraph.
- 5.39 "There are still harmless self-observers who believe that there are 'immediate certainties'; for example, 'I think,' or as the superstition of **Schopenhauer** put it, 'I will'; as though knowledge here got hold of its object purely and nakedly as the thing in itself." Okay, so his first objection is, what makes you so sure that that thing that you think actually constitutes reality itself rather than a mediated representation of reality? Or rather than your mediated representation of reality? Or rather than your mediated representation of reality consequential to the goal you're pursuing consciously? Or rather than your mediated representation of reality as a consequence of the goals that you're pursuing unconsciously? So, that's one problem, and it's a very, very big problem.
- 5.40 And that's what he means by "knowledge got hold of its object purely and nakedly 'as the thing in itself.'" Because you might suspect as well that even the objects of your perception, the things you see, are the things in and of themselves, the actual object. It's like, that's not the case. First of all, perception of that sort is impossible. And second, even your object perceptions are laden with, well, **Nietzsche** would say, with the **will to power** because what you see are more like tools and obstacles rather than objects stripped of any moral value.
- 5.41 Again, that doesn't mean that you see the object and overlay the moral, the utility or lack thereof, the fact that something might move you forward and be an obstacle. You don't lay that on secondarily to your perception of the object. That's not how perception works. It's the will to the end is implicit in the perception. You couldn't even perceive without that, which is why when you look at the world, when you walk into this room, you see the chairs. There's lots of things you could see. There's endless numbers of patterns on the wall. There's a very finite set of things you perceive, and you perceive those things that afford you a certain action, and that action is always in relationship to a goal, conscious or unconscious.
- 5.42 You might also see those things that would stop you from moving forward. If there was a piece of furniture in the middle of this walkway forward, you'd see that when you walked in because you have to walk around it. So, it's an obstacle to your pathway forward. It's really the case. This is so much worth knowing that, when you look at the world, you see tools and obstacles, essentially. Everything you see is a tool and an obstacle.
- 5.43 When you're driving down the road, and someone cuts you off, and you're annoyed, the reason you're annoyed is because you now perceive them directly—they're people—as obstacles. And the fact that you perceive them as obstacles is why you get annoyed. They're reduced to obstacle just like that. And that's the basis for not only your perception—tools and obstacles—but for your emotions. This is so interesting that when you see a tool that will move you

forward, it makes you happy. Happiness emerges from that. And when you see an obstacle, negative emotion emerges from that.

- 5.44 So, if you're laying out a room that you live in, one of the things you can do is make sure the pathways to the important things that you need to do in that room are clear and open. Then, when you walk into the room, you're pleased because the navigation in the room, which is the primary problem of the room, how to navigate in it, all the navigation pathways are laid out clear and simple.
- 5.45 That's why we ordered all these chairs in rows with a certain spacing between them. It's so that they afford the possibility of easy sitting in a social group without conflict. Can you imagine the chairs were all randomly laid out? It would present you all with a problem of how you would arrange yourself in rows, and that would pose you with the problem of how you hierarchically orient yourself because who should sit where? And what you want is a room where all those problems are solved.
- 5.46 All right, so there's part of the problem with the notion of the thing you think being the thing. And that's what he means by "without any falsification on the part of either the subject or the object." It's like you're laying on or seeing through a perception, a structure of value, no matter what you look at. He's using irony here when he talks about falsification. You're not dealing with the tangible realities of the purely objective world. You've already transformed them into something approximating a navigation aid merely by casting your eyes on them or touching them. So, there's a subjective interpretation, even in the act of perception, and he is ironically referring to that as a falsification, a necessary fiction.
- 5.47 "Let the people suppose that knowledge means knowing things entirely." Well, we've already dispensed with that. "The philosopher must say to himself instead: When I analyze the process that is expressed in the sentence, 'I think,' I find a whole series of daring assertions that would be difficult, perhaps impossible, to prove; for example, that it is I who thinks."
- 5.48 Because you ask yourself, "What does that mean that you think something up?" What you? How do you do that? How do you think something out? You have no idea. No one has any idea. Phenomenologically, this is something Jung pointed out. It's more like thoughts appear in the theater of your imagination, which is also a series of metaphors—theater of your imagination. You pose a question, thoughts appear. You say, "I think. I thought that up."
- 5.49 How? Why do you even have to if you were capable of generating the idea? Was that effortful? Was it like an algorithmic calculation? Where did the new knowledge come from? Why wasn't it already there if you could have it at hand? And why are there things that you can't think of? Why are there problems that are beyond you? Why can you suddenly stumble on a revelation when you didn't have it before? What are the preconditions for opening yourself up to a redemptive thought, which is a thought that would move you farther down your pathway? You have no idea about any of that. So, you replace that with "I think." And everyone says, "I know

what that means." And Nietzsche says, "You have no idea what any of that means, the 'I' or the 'think.'"

- 5.50 "I find a whole series of daring assertions that would be difficult, perhaps impossible to prove; for example, that it is I who think that there must necessarily be something that thinks." I suppose that would be equivalent to assuming that because there's a world, there must necessarily be a creator. Atheists dispense with that notion. Why not equally dispense with the notion that there's an I who thinks? The thoughts merely make themselves manifest in an uncreated manner. That's one possibility.
- 5.51 "That thinking is an activity." It's like work. It's an effortful action that's akin to work. "An operation on the part of a being"—that's the I—"who is thought of as a cause." I cause my thoughts. "That there's an ego," that would be the centralized I, and finally, "That it is already determined what it is to be designated by thinking, that I know what thinking is," and you don't.
- 5.52 And so, well, that's a great example of **axiomatic presuppositions**. What do you think? "What" refers to something like a concrete object. "You" assumes that there's a being there. "Think" assumes that, first of all, the implicit reality of what is thought and the notion that thinking is an activity. We never question that. All of that's questionable, so it's uncertain and doubtful. That's a lot of uncertainty and doubt, and that's very anxiety-provoking, although it's rife with possibility. And instead of encountering that uncertainty and doubt, which is destabilizing, we pack all of that invisible complexity into an invisible certainty and proceed on the basis of the certainty.
- 5.53 We do that all the time. That ties us back to the notion we talked about yesterday of something like terror management. When you confront the world, you confront it with a series of unquestionable axiomatic certainties, which hide the complexity from you, and so that does shield you from existential anxiety and existential terror. There's not much of you, and there's a lot of the world. How do you deal with that? By assuming that you know far more than you know. That's just invisible.
- 5.54 Then, you might say, "What are the preconditions for the invisibility?" This is where the pragmatic philosophy leaps into its own. As long as your simplification works for the purpose of your current operation, it's sufficient. Is that a chair? Can you sit on it? Yes. Can you sit on it now? Yes, good enough. On to the next problem. Now, that'll be a problem if the leg happens to be loose, for example, and it collapses underneath you.
- 5.55 But the idea, the pragmatic idea—and this is the philosophy of the East Coast Americans, let's say, in the late 1800s, William James and his crowd—was that the way we determine whether or not something is true is that it works well enough for now or for some period of time. It's more a conception of human beings as engineers. It's like, is that a good enough bridge? Does it collapse when you drive a car over it? No. Good enough. What about a thousand cars? Maybe that's now your criteria. Yes, it stands up to a thousand cars. Good enough. Is the theory behind the bridge correct? Well, not in any infinite sense because it's bounded by ignorance.

- 5.56 So then, the question pragmatically is reduced to something far more practical. Does it serve the purpose intended for the appropriate period of time? That's the validation. That's the process by which knowledge is validated. It has very little to do with concordance with objective reality. Not nothing, because maybe you want to build the bridge out of steel. But this is a very different notion of truth from mere accuracy of representation of some external objective pattern.
- 5.57 It also ties the problem of motivation in. Is the theory behind that bridge true? It devolves into, does the bridge stand up to use over some period of time? If the answer to that is yes, that's true enough. The **pragmatist** would say, "It's always only true enough." There's no way out of that because you're ignorant. Your knowledge is bounded. The best you can ever have are fragmentary truths that have a bounded range of applicability. That makes you an engineer and not a scientist. I don't think there's any way out of that, actually. I think the **pragmatists** got that; I think they got that right.
- 5.58 Anyways, you could see why it'd be very annoying to talk to **Nietzsche** because you'd be presenting him with all sorts of **immediate certainties**, and he'd be thinking, "You think you know what you're talking about. You have no idea what you're saying, not from a philosophical perspective. You're so rife with unexamined presuppositions. " Then he might say, "Where did those presuppositions come from?"
- 5.59 It's like, you're the unconscious advocate of philosophers who lived before you. Your head's full of unifying conceptions that great people in the past have formulated. They occupy you. They generate thoughts in your mind, and you think you think. And you think those thoughts are yours, and they're not. Hardly any of your thoughts are yours. Thank god for that because most of those thoughts would be so off the mark that they'd be completely impractical and useless because most creative activity is not only wrong but dangerous. And so, it's a very good thing in some real way that most of what you think is thoughts that other people think, too, because otherwise, also, how in the world would you get along with other people?
- 5.60 But that does pose the problem of, "What do you do when the collective is wrong?" Because that happens from time to time, and it happens that the world has changed enough so that traditional wisdom is no longer sufficient. And then, the application of these axiomatic a priori certainties no longer does the trick, and you're there cast out on your own to try to deal with the fact that you don't know what the hell is going on in the world.
- 5.61 You don't want to have that happen accidentally. That's no fun at all, though it's quite the challenge and thrill to move into the place where that's happening voluntarily, to live on the edge of—what would you say—the encounter between what's certain and traditional, and what's novel and transforming. I would say that part of the **Nietzschean** call to heroism in the service of the **will to power** as part of it is that injunction to live on that edge, to do that voluntarily. Now, he thinks that Christian morality mitigates precisely against that, as we'll see as we move forward.

- 5.62 "With regard to the superstitions of logicians, I shall never tire of emphasizing a small terse fact, which these superstitious minds hate to concede—namely that a thought comes when it wishes." And that's an interesting thing to contemplate. You'll be struck by a thought, and you think, "How can you be struck by a thought, especially if it's your thought? Why would it come as a surprise?" It's only things that appear unexpectedly and that are outside of your control that come as a surprise. And you can certainly have thoughts. Thoughts can certainly appear in the theater of your imagination that will surprise you.
- 5.63 So, where do they come from? Well, that's part of the reason that classically religious people believe in revelation. It's because different elements of reality, conceptual elements of reality, reveal themselves to you. That's a perfectly reasonable way of thinking about thought. It's in distinction to the notion that you're thinking the thoughts up, but then that poses you with the problem of, "Why do they surprise you?" Because you can certainly be surprised by yourself.
- 5.64 And so, you can think of thought—I think of thought frequently as a form of, I think it's secularized prayer, fundamentally, thought because, basically, what you do when you think is you identify a problem that you have, which is a shortcoming, and generally a moral shortcoming, because you don't know how to act, so it's a moral shortcoming. You pose yourself a problem, or you pose a problem, which is, "Why am I like that? And what is the solution?" That's humility. You assume that your current state of knowledge is inadequate.
- 5.65 You open yourself up to a revelation. If you're fortunate, you get one, and then you can enter into a dialogue with the revelation to see how you might particularize it for your time and place, evaluate it, and slot it into the confines of your personality. That's the critical aspect of thought as a revelatory aspect and a critical aspect.
- 5.66 All of that is something like an admission of fault. It's humble opening up to the possibility of new revelation. It's divine grace because the revelation makes itself manifest. It's communication with the divine because you have to see how the revelation might be made practically applicable in your own life. That's what you do if you interpret a vision, a dream, or an intuition. Then, you might have to engage in dia-logos, a dialogue with other people, to see how the new idea might be integrated into the community. That's all part of how you advance.
- 5.67 I see no difference between that and genuine religious practice, except that the religious language is stripped away, and that's in some way what Nietzsche is objecting to. It's replaced by a whole new set of equally faith-based presuppositions. There's an 'I,' the 'I' thinks. That's a causal relationship. All you're doing in some fundamental sense is replacing the notion of a transcendent unity—god—with the notion of 'I.' And maybe that's right, and maybe it's not. It isn't like the evidence can tell you so clearly which of those is the case.
- 5.68 Although, I would also say that the more you open yourself up to revelation in a humble manner, the more cognizant you are of your inadequacy, the higher the probability that you will receive redemptive revelations because how the hell are you going to get anywhere if you don't admit that you're wrong and that you want an answer? You're not going to get anywhere. And

maybe the real answer is that the more you admit that you're wrong, and the more you want an answer, the more answers you're going to get.

- 5.69 I don't see any difference between that at all and opening yourself up to revelation. I think those are exactly the same thing. If you doubt that, I would say, "Fine, try the opposite and see what happens." Then, you're stuck in your preconceptions, and then you're reliant on yourself, whatever that is, to dig you out of the hole that you already dug yourself into. I can't see how that's going to work out at all.
- 5.70 "It thinks." In you. "But that this 'it' is precisely the famous old 'ego' is, to put it mildly, a supposition, an assertion, and assuredly not an **immediate certainty**." So, you see the same thing in this modern idiot insistence that identity is subjectively defined. It's like, "I am who I say I am." Well, that's what God says, by the way, when he makes himself manifest in the burning bush in Exodus. "I am that I am." It's a statement about the nature of being itself.
- 5.71 When you do that, when you take to yourself the right to define yourself subjectively, who is this I that's making the definition? Precisely. And why is it omnipresent and omniscient and omnipotent? Why is that ascribed to you? Well, it's an extension of this notion that it's the I who thinks, and it's utterly preposterous. Enter into a marriage with the presupposition that you're only who you say you are, and see how well that goes. Try to have a friendship based on that proposition.
- 5.72 If there's an I that's you at all, hopefully, it's something dynamic that updates itself in the process of dialogue. It's much more appropriate to be conceptualizing it as something that's striving for revelation with something that's higher and integration with the community simultaneously. In a marriage, you're negotiating your identity with your partner 100% of the time. If you get any backlog on that, woe to you because you're not caught up with each other. That's part of the excitement of a genuine relationship; it keeps you on that transforming edge. You don't just get to say, "I define myself subjectively, and you have no right to even object, let alone argue. You just have to accept it." It's so utterly preposterous that only intellectuals could possibly assume that it was reasonable.
- 5.73 The point here is you have to understand is that you're replacing one metaphysics, and so that would be the metaphysics of something like divine revelation in relationship to identity. You're just replacing it with another metaphysics, that there's an 'I' and that it's omnipotent. There's no movement beyond that religious metaphysics in the realm of subjective identity. Plus, it's so preposterously foolish.
- 5.74 **Piaget, Jean Piaget**, the great developmental psychologist, knew perfectly well that the only people who identify themselves subjectively are 2-year-olds. They can't play. They're egocentric. Before two, a child is like an assemblage of disunited motivational states. It's something quite wonderful about little kids, really, the purity of their will. They cry 100% when they're crying. They laugh 100% when they're laughing. They're really, really angry when they're enraged. The

2-year-old tantrum is something to behold. If they're hot, they can't—they're done. If they're tired, they're out. It's like they cycle through these motivational states one after another.

- 5.75** What happens to a child in the first two years is that all of those states are integrating themselves into something that you would then identify as the child's personality, the 'I' that we're talking about here. By two, they got themselves together as individuals, but they can't integrate themselves socially. They can't share toys. They can't establish a joint game where a 2-year-old and his playmate can occupy the same space of principle and subordinate their wills to that superordinate principle, which is what you do when you engage in pretend play. "You be the mommy, and I'll be the daddy, and we'll play house." A 3-year-old can do that, but a 2-year-old can't. The 2-year-old is just a manifestation of subjective will.
- 5.76** Now, it's not that simple, and there is some reciprocity that emerges before that. A child who's breastfeeding, for example, has to establish a relationship with the mother to have that happen. It's not just a mechanical act. There's some integration of the child into the community even before the age of two, but that emerges as they develop. By three, they can partake in these jointly constructed subjective identities. That's what a game is.
- 5.77** If they can't do that, then it's a developmental catastrophe. They have no friends. They're the kid who says, "What I say goes." Who the hell wants to play with a kid like that? And the answer is, "No one," not even the kid himself. So, he has no friends, can't get along with adults because no adults are going to put up with a 4-year-old who acts like a 2-year-old. You think, "I'm not having anything to do with that kid." And then, the kid exists in a world where no one wants to have anything to do with them.
- 5.78** And so, that's definitely the terrible existential situation of so many people who now are so fragmented and broken that they insist on self-identification. I think they're so broken that they never even got to the point of 2-year-old integration. That's the degree of distress. You believe that pure subjective identity is redemptive because you haven't even integrated your basic motivational drives. You can't see anything beyond that, which would be social negotiation of your identity, which is—that's what it means to be civilized and socially acceptable. And you cannot have any friends without that. It's really awful, and it's a real sign of how badly our society has degenerated.
- 5.79** I also think that this insistence on this multiplicity of identities is something like the re-emergence of fantasy play because fantasy play is part of the process by which the purely subjectively defined ego starts to ramify itself up into something that can be social, and you do that by adopting different roles. My little granddaughter was Pocahontas for a whole year. When she was—I think she was about two and a half—if you asked her what her name was, she said, "Pocahontas." And she watched Pocahontas a bunch, and she had a Pocahontas doll. And as far as she was concerned, she was Pocahontas. And a year at two is a long time. It's 33% of her life.

- 5.80 Then, one day she was done with that, and then she was back to being who she was. But she had to inhabit that fictional role. It's the role of a heroine. Obviously, that's what the Disney movies put forward with their endless array of princesses: different forms of female heroic roles. But she just cottoned on to that. It's like, "That's who I am." That's part of that fantasy play process that pulls the child towards something like integration across time.
- 5.81 "With regard to the superstitions of logicians, I shall never tire of emphasizing a small terse fact, which these superstitious minds"—it's no wonder his colleagues hated him. He's calling the logicians superstitious, which is extremely funny. He's so witty—"hate to concede—namely, that a thought comes when 'it' wishes." You see that with intrusive thoughts, and sometimes people get whole pathologies of intrusive thoughts. If you have obsessive-compulsive disorder, you have these thoughts that are obsessive. They won't go away.
- 5.82 What do you mean by that? Are you thinking them up? No? Well, you don't seem to be. Can you stop them? No. Well, who's the you then? Is it the you that's generating the thought? Or is it the you that's opposing the thoughts, or is it the you that's failing to control the thoughts, even though you want to oppose them? And if it isn't you that's thinking up the thoughts or who is thinking up the thoughts, then who is thinking up the thoughts?
- 5.83 And now there's a terrifying question. And so, if you take the psychoanalysts seriously, it should just scare you half to death because one of the things they point out, and this is in the aftermath of Nietzschean thinking, is there's a lot of things thinking in you, and it's very reasonable to conceptualize those things as alive. Not only is it reasonable to conceptualize them as alive, they have possession of you. And they don't just have possession of you. They have possession of a lot of people for a very long time over very long swaths of time.
- 5.84 And then, you think, "Those things that think within you, producing obsessive thoughts, let's say, that you can't control, they're not you." And that begs the question, "What the hell or who the hell are they?" And that's a question. And then, another question, which is, "If there are things that are thinking in you that are compelling you to think things that you don't want to think, how is it that you could best defend yourself against that or fortify yourself against that so that you don't fall prey to the machinations of whatever these things are?" Spirits or daemons or deities—however you might want it—or memes. I don't care how you want to conceptualize it. It boils down to the same thing.
- 5.85 It's like, what is it that you have within you that offers you some defense against possession by these sets of ideas? The same question arises when you try to determine how you might fortify yourself against something approximating ideological possession because people who are ideologically possessed will say, "Here's what I think," and I think, "You don't think that." "Well, why not?" "Well, she thinks it, too, and so does he. So how in the world would you possibly claim that this is you that's doing the thinking? Even if you weren't here, those thoughts would be here." So, what was Jung's notion? People don't have ideas. Ideas have people. Right, and then you think, "Okay, what ideas have me?" And that's definitely a question, horrible question, but definitely worth thinking.

- 5.86 "Namely, that a thought comes when 'it' wishes and not when 'I' wish, so that it is a falsification of the facts of the case to say that the subject 'I' is the condition of the predicate 'think.' It thinks." That's why the id means 'it,' by the way. So, the Freudian id is the 'it' within you. It's nature speaking within you. That's a reasonable way of thinking about it. "It thinks: but that this 'it' is precisely the famous old ego is, to put it mildly, only a supposition, an assertion, a superstition, and assuredly not an immediate certainty."
- 5.87 It's such a remarkable set of paragraphs; it's so revolutionary. All the thinking that's encapsulated in that paragraph demolishes whole swaths of thought in five or six sentences. Nietzsche is extraordinarily good at that. Beyond Good and Evil. It's nothing but that happening over and over. This is great. This is lovely. It was fun going through this book again because a lot of these paragraphs burned themselves into my imagination. When I re-encountered them—I told you I'd read this book four or five times—they're like old friends because so much of what I've thought over the decades has emerged out of these paragraphs. So, to re-encounter them is like encountering an old friend.
- 5.88 This is so great. This is relevant as well to this idea of will to power. Imagine that there's a central unifying will, and the will is precisely the will towards the unification of diverse and multiplicitous wills. So, those might be wills within you, all your different proclivities. But equally, it's a will that unites between people. Look, we're all sitting here doing the same thing. In some sense, our internal psychophysiological states mirror one another. We're all in the same state of mind. Now, you can tell that because our eyes are all pointed to the same thing. We're all contemplating the same thing insofar as we're participating in this process. We're all dominated by the same spirit.
- 5.89 That spirit is obviously a spirit of union. Why? Well, are we united at the moment or not? And the answer is, "Obviously," because we're all sitting the same way, doing the same thing, and we're not at each other's throats. So, whatever spirit dominates this room is a unifying spirit. It unifies you because you might be distracted now and then thinking of other things as different parts of your will make themselves manifest. But fundamentally, the spirit of the room is dominating you enough so that you can sit for two hours without being too unhappy about it. But it's the same thing uniting all of us, and so there's a unifying spirit there.
- 5.90 And you might say, "What's the nature of that unifying spirit?" That's really the question of the will to power, I think most accurately, to give Nietzsche as much credence and credibility as possible. That's the question, "What's the spirit that unifies psychologically and socially in the optimal manner?"
- 5.91 Now, Nietzsche is pointing to the existence of something like a logos here. So you might say—imagine that you could think of 10 different situations like this where people are gathered socially and concentrating on the same thing. Maybe that would be a church service, a sports event, a rock concert, and a public demonstration. Now, what's the same about those? Well, there's a lot of people there, and they're unified. They're all doing the same thing. They're all pursuing some end. And then, you might say, "What's common across all four of those?" And

that would be a move towards an analysis of the unifying spirit as such. So, Nietzsche's point in this paragraph is that there's a manifestation, like a bottom-up manifestation, of that drive towards unification in all cultures and that possibly there's a commonality of that unifying spirit across cultures.

- 5.92 The Postmodernists would agree with that, the Neo-Marxist Postmodernist types, even though they disavow any allegiance to a centralizing narrative. That's a lie because they always default to a Marxism that says it's axiomatically self-certain that the spirit that unifies us is the will to domination, power, and compulsion. Whereas the Nietzschean or the Jungians—again, this all emerges out of Nietzsche—the Jungians say, "No, the fundamental narrative that unites us is the hero story, the eternal story of the hero." That's a stable state, voluntary descent into chaos, like the descent into the desert in Exodus, and then the—what would you say—encounter with revelation in the midst of chaos and the reconstitution of a new stable state.
- 5.93 It isn't the new stable state that's the hero. It's the process of continual up-and-down-regeneration. It's the voluntary Sisyphean task. You roll the boulder up the hill; it rolls back down. That's a catastrophe unless you know that the boulder will roll back down, and that's the aim of rolling it up the hill to begin with, so then it's something you take on voluntarily.
- 5.94 From the Jungian perspective—Jung was comparing many moralities, many stories from many different times and places, trying to extract out commonality of theme, making the assumption that that was the central unifying structure, unifying narrative. That was all part and parcel of his attempt to answer this question of what might constitute the central, let's say, will to power. Nietzsche lays the groundwork for that in this paragraph. He says, "Observe."
- 5.95 "Individual philosophical concepts"—so not objective ideas, but philosophical concepts—"are not capricious"—they're not just extracted out of nothing—"or autonomously evolving"—in different cultures and different times and places—"but grow up in connection and relationship with one another." Okay, so that's an interesting proposition. Imagine the difference between a symphony and noise. One of the differences is every note in a symphony exists in a coherent relationship with every other note. And that's what gives it that harmony, and so it exists in relationship with every other note, but also with the direction of the notes and with the totality of the piece. So, there's a coherency to the particular, and the coherency is the relationship to the other particulars that make up the whole.
- 5.96 So, one of the things that Nietzsche is pointing out is that one of the reasons that philosophy is not merely capricious is because its elements, its propositions, stand in a coherent and melodic relationship to one another. I don't hesitate to use a musical analogy in relation to Nietzsche because he was a great admirer of music, and he knew that it was a unifying force. The metaphor is a very good one. And so this is a lovely thing to think, too.
- 5.97 We tend to think that sanity is something within us, where Protestant liberals have taken this subjective identity to its logical conclusion, but that's not right. Sanity is something more like what happens to you when you listen to music. The sanity is then the participation in the

ordered structuring of a hierarchical—of something that's hierarchical and aimed at unity. I would say, you might say, "You're sane because you're well-organized internally." That's even really the claim of most psychotherapists, Freud included, that sanity is somehow in your head, in your brain even. It's a reflection of brain health.

- 5.98 Obviously, to some degree, that has some truth. But I would say—I always did this with my clients. "Are you miserable?" "Yes." "Okay, let's look at your situation. Do you have an intimate relationship? Do you have any friends? Do you have a job or a career? Are you integrated in any way into a community? Do you do anything civically? How are you embedded in a system of hierarchy?" Then you might say, "If you were optimally embedded in a coherent system of hierarchy, you would be sane." The sanity is actually that optimal embeddedness.
- 5.99 You know that. It's like, how sane are you? If you're a mother and your child is sick. How sane are you? Not very. It's because a primary relationship has been distorted and hurt. You're not going to be free of depression and anxiety under those circumstances. In some sense, no matter how well-constituted you are intrapsychically. Maybe you're courageous and willing to take the problem on headlong, and good for you. But you're still going to suffer.
- 5.100 So, the idea that sanity is somehow in you—that's a major error. It's more like your ability to dance to music. That's a much better way of thinking about it. It's also why we dance to music, by the way, because we're acting out that proposition, that proper being. Proper playful being has to do with your ability to align yourself with the manifesting, with the patterns of reality, as they're making themselves spontaneously and harmoniously manifest.
- 5.101 If you go out on a date and you dance with someone, that's what you're trying to assess. It's like, well, here are the patterns of being. That's the music. Can we play within that structure? And then, can we play in a manner that's provocative, mutually sustaining, playful, graceful, and that isn't dominated too much by instantaneous lust and isn't characterized by frustration or too much self-conscious because there's some grace that goes along with it? You're checking all that out in the dance.

6. Courageous Trust

AT A GLANCE

Explores Nietzsche's biological image of philosophical concepts growing within a limited system, like the fauna of a continent, and connects it to archetypes, chess, game design, and the reciprocal altruism that makes a sovereign ethos stable. Considers the human soul as microcosm, bowerbirds and puffer fish, and science's religious presuppositions. Then reads the call for psychology to descend into the depths, illustrated by the Pareto distribution of creative achievement; the affects of hatred and envy as necessary; Raskolnikov and Cain on punishment; long wars, fear, and outcasts like Foucault and Derrida; and cynicism versus courageous trust.

- 6.1 "Individual philosophical concepts are not capricious or autonomously evolving, but grow up in connection and relationship with each other;"—that's a harmony of coherence— "that, however suddenly and arbitrarily they seem to appear in the history of thought, they nevertheless belong just as much to a system as all the members of the fauna of a continent."
- 6.2 That's so interesting. There's a museum in Washington, the Smithsonian, and part of the museum is a museum of skeletons. It's like a zoo of skeletons. Most of the skeletons are mammalian, but not all of them. But it's so interesting to see the skeletons because you can see right from amphibians on upward. It's all the same thing. It's the skeletal form—this bilateral symmetry. Forelimb, bilateral symmetry. Even a bat. A bat looks exactly like you look, except its hands are extremely long. All the parts are there; it's all a variation on a theme.
- 6.3 Nietzsche is using a biological metaphor here for a reason. His idea is there are some unchanging axiomatic suppositions implicit in all philosophical systems that they tend towards. And you might say—we were studying the Old Testament in this Exodus seminar that I'm running at the same time this is going on, and the Ten Commandments, you might think, are something like the attempt to codify the fauna, the skeletal structure necessary for minimal social organization.
- 6.4 So, let's say a group of people, chimpanzees, for that matter, manage to organize themselves in a way that's mutually productive and sustainable across time. Well, they have to act out a certain pattern. Frans de Waal has laid that out in quite a lot of detail in his analysis of chimpanzee behavior. The alpha chimps are reciprocal. They're reciprocal peacemakers. They're not dominant like tyrants, and if they are, they get torn apart and killed in pretty short order.
- 6.5 So, the stable, sovereign ethos is one of reciprocal —it's really one of reciprocal altruism. That's what makes for stable chimpanzee societies. Well, the same is true—you can get a long way for a short time by being a tyrant, but it's not a very iterable game. You have to force people to play it. So, it's inefficient. Plus, they're hostile and resentful. You think, "You can be successful as a tyrant." It's like, "If you rule hell, merely the fact that you're ruler doesn't mean that you have succeeded." It might be that you've failed worse than anyone else.

- 6.6 And so, if you're a successful tyrant, you might say, "Look, tyrants can be successful." It's like, "That's the success you want?" You've got no friends; you've got no allies. You can't trust your family members. Everyone around you lies to you all the time. You can indulge your hedonism but at the expense of your own self-respect. No one is going to ever be able to form a relationship with you on the basis of anything but fear and power. And maybe you're very good at that. It's like, "Yeah, great, you rule over hell." I think it's better to serve in hell than to rule in hell.
- 6.7 If you're looking at a hierarchy of success, none of that's particularly successful. But you get my point. And you can imagine—imagine all your friendships were based on power. First of all, they're not friendships, and they're certainly not going to sustain you, and definitely, if you ever become weak, your friends are not only going to leave you, they're going to take that opportunity to extract revenge on you for using power to begin with. So, as a medium- to long-term strategy, even in terms of self-development, it's counterproductive.
- 6.8 Now, it might be better than just laying in your bed and never doing anything. It might be better than an absolute collapsed nihilism, but that doesn't mean that it's anything approaching optimized. So, now Nietzsche is making a hypothesis here that human philosophical systems rotate around something approximating a central ethos. And I would say he would believe that it's the attempt of that centralizing ethos to manifest itself. That's the basis for what he describes as the will to power.
- 6.9 "They nevertheless belong just as much to a system as all the members of the fauna of a continent— is betrayed in the end also by the fact that the most diverse philosophers keep filling in a definite fundamental scheme of possible philosophies."
- 6.10 You can make a Hollywood movie, and people will watch it in India and vice versa. Why? Well, because there are certain narrative elements that are universal to human beings. Why? Well, we have the same set of basic emotions. We have the same set of basic motivations. So, the same narratives appeal to us cross-culturally. That similarity of an orienting narrative is akin to the similarity of orienting philosophy, especially if you think of philosophy as something you act out practically rather than it being a subset of the attempt to represent the objective world.
- 6.11 So, the idea that there's a limited corpus of orienting philosophies is very much similar to the idea that there's a limited corpus of interesting stories. You know this because how many action adventure movies are there? Hundreds. How many plots? One. Romance—the same thing. What's the central narrative of romance? It's Beauty and the Beast told over and over and over and over, in all sorts of different variants. And you might say, "Why are the variants interesting?" The answer is, "However you play out the narrative of Beauty and the Beast in your life will be particularized for you." There's the archetypal pattern, but it's generic. It has to be particularized.
- 6.12 The archetypal narrative diversifies itself into a multiplicity of forms to aid in its particularization. So then, you could sample these different stories, action adventure stories or romances, and you

can particularize the **archetype** so that you know how to make itself manifest in the specific situations that pertain to you because the unity has to be differentiated into a multiplicity because we're—we vary in our temperament in our situation. You can't just mindlessly act out the generic.

- 6.13 The generic is generally represented in something like symbols. So, if you think of Disney's *Beauty and the Beast*, for example, the Beast is obviously not real. He's a monster. Well, it's an animated movie, too, in case you didn't notice. So, none of it is real. And Gaston is a type—he's a type that makes himself manifest in all sorts of particular situations.
- 6.14 So, you get the generic pattern from religious education, but you still have to particularize it, and that's actually your destiny. It's a very good thing that you might learn, say, from studying **Jungian** psychology, that your destiny is the particularization of an **archetype**. And he would say, "It's your destiny two ways. You can either do it voluntarily and awake so that you know which **archetype** you're striving to make manifest, or you can let archetypes make themselves manifest within you unconsciously."
- 6.15 That's the option. There's no no-archetype option. So, you might say, "I don't believe in anything." It's like, "Yeah, yeah, that's just the **archetype** of narcissistic **nihilism**." Maybe then you're in love with your own reflection, or maybe it's Sisyphus. You're still caught in a story. And you might say, "What's the evidence for that?" It would be, "You're not the only **nihilist**." It's a manner of being. You could even think about it as a philosophy. And so, you're not a **nihilist**; it's that **nihilism** has got you. It's got you in its grip.
- 6.16 And then, you can ask yourself, "How's that working out for you?" You might say, "I can't see any alternative." Yeah, well, that's part of the **nihilism**. But generally, people would not want to have that. Now, it's tricky because the problem with—if you decide not to be **nihilistic**, Nietzsche would ask this question, "Are you **nihilistic**, or are you just useless?" Because your **nihilism** can easily be a mask for your absolute unwillingness to take any responsibility whatsoever, and then you could allow your **nihilism** to transform yourself into a victim, and then you could claim compensation on the part of others as a means of providing you with what you need, despite the fact that you're utterly useless.
- 6.17 So, your **nihilism** isn't even hopelessness. You're way more corrupt than that. Your **nihilism** is a way that you manipulate the world to give you what you need by using the status of victim to extract resources from people who have decided to adopt responsibility. That's one dark mess, that is. I think that's—I really believe that's the essential spirit of the Marxist doctrine. It's certainly something Nietzsche believed. That's all driven by parasitical envy and masquerading as compassion for the victimized. It's so awful. And you think, "Is it really that awful?" Stalin killed 30 million people, and Mao maybe 100 million. Yeah, it's really that awful. And Stalin was just gearing up for the deaths. He was just getting warmed up when maybe they killed him, and we're not done with any of that mess yet, that's for sure.

- 6.18 "Is betrayed in the end by the fact that the most diverse philosophers keep filling in a definite fundamental scheme of possible philosophies." There's a platonic idea lurking here, too. It's as if in the world of possibility—that's a world, too. It's actually the world you're conscious of, I would say, rather than the world of actuality. There's an a priori scheme of possible philosophies. It exists in potential as the space of possibility.
- 6.19 In the same way that there's a universe of possible chess games, and every chess game is a manifestation of one of those possibilities. Chess is played by principle. There's a universe of possible philosophies. It's a large universe, but it still circles, just like chess circles around a set of principles, the rules of the game. The philosophies do exactly the same thing.
- 6.20 You see this problem emerge in game design, online game design. Some games collapse into chaos as they're played. The reason for that is the principles, the rules, don't allow for an iterable game. Communism is a non-playable game. It sounds good. The rules look good. They're even attractive. They're a game that people will voluntarily undertake for all sorts of reasons. But if you start playing the game, you don't get the outcome that's predicted, and it degenerates into chaos very rapidly. And Nietzsche's notion would be: that's because the Marxist doctrine deviates importantly from the domain of—what would you say—applicable philosophical games.
- 6.21 You have a real sense of this, everyone. You have a sense of this even when you're a little kid. Some other kids are fun to play with. Those are your friends. That's what a friend is. The way a kid makes a friend is they try to play a game with another kid, and then they can, and then the game is enjoyable. And so, the kids think, "That was fun. Would you like to do it again?" If the answer is yes, then the friend is someone with whom you can play a set of games, fun games.
- 6.22 So, the friendship becomes a meta-game, and then society emerges out of that. Society is the emergence of—what would you say—a collective meta-game of friends if it's optimized and not a structure that's based on compulsion or power. It's tricky on the social front because when a child is playing a game, there usually isn't an obvious practical orientation, whereas adults have to contend with the fact that, well, you need to eat, and you need shelter, and it's not easy to gamify all of that. But you can do it to some degree.
- 6.23 If you set up a business with partners you enjoy working with, then you've introduced the spirit of the game into the realm of brute necessity. You could even say that that's actually an index of your mastery. If you could confront the harshest problems of life in the spirit of play, you'd be a master, and the act that that spirit of play emerges is actually an index of the mastery.
- 6.24 That's certainly—that's why Nietzsche wrote a book called *The Gay Science*. He knew that there was something about that voluntary, joyful undertaking of productive work that was a marker of the highest philosophical inclination. And so, that's a good thing to think about your relationships. When is the relationship working? When it's imbued with the spirit of voluntary play. That's the spirit you want to foster in your intimate relationship and your relationship with your children, too.

- 6.25 It's one of the things children really grant you as a gift because, number one, they want to have a good relationship with you. They're the only people you ever encounter in your life who are 100% motivated to have the best relationship with you they could possibly have. And that's a hell of a gift. The other thing they offer you is they want to play, so you can learn through your children how to have an optimized relationship that's almost entirely based in play, and that will make you a way better person.
- 6.26 People, modern people, pathetic people, are ambivalent about children. "I don't want the responsibility. I don't want them to sacrifice my freedom." Really? You're so great as you are that any constraint placed on you by, say, children is going to make you, what? Less of the romantic, like Byron-esque poet from the 19th century that you most truly are? You're a useless lump of clay in your bed covered with Cheeto dust, playing video games. "I don't want to give up my freedoms." Oh, my God.
- 6.27 "Under invisible spell, they always revolve once more in the same orbit." The implication there is that there's a sun at the center, the poetic metaphor of orbit, something at the center. That's the self in the Jungian language, let's say. "However independent of each other they may feel themselves with their critical or systematic wills, something within them leads them, something impels them in a definite order, one after the other."
- 6.28 That's what we would say if we said, "That thought makes sense." You think, you have a thought, and then you have another thought. You think, "Those go together. That makes sense." Well, in relationship to what? In relationship to some emerging, underlying, coherent order. And not just order in the homeostatic sense but order towards something approximating an elevated goal.
- 6.29 The sense of things making sense is an indication that those concepts fit together and serve that emergent purpose. That would be the manner in which emotion and motivation guide the sequencing of rational thoughts. That works. That story makes sense. Now we're getting somewhere. Now, I can start to see the point, the direction, the purpose.
- 6.30 "Impels them in a definite order, one after the other—to wit, the innate systematic structure and relationship of their concepts." Now, here's an interesting idea. I invited Richard Dawkins to have a conversation with me, which he eventually did. He was leery about it for a variety of reasons, and one of them—he's quite an ornery character, so, being British—he said, "I don't really understand what you're talking about. I don't know why you want to talk to me at all. I'm not sure it would be productive, and I'm not sure I could be polite." Those were his objections.
- 6.31 But he said, "Here's a paper. I think maybe this is why you want to talk to me." So, he sent me this paper he wrote about 25 years ago that I had read back then. I thought it was a great paper. I'd forgotten about it, but it was exactly why I wanted to talk to him. And in this paper, he said, "Every organism must be a microcosm of its environment." What did he mean by that? He meant, imagine you were an alien, and someone gave you a bird, and you didn't know anything

at all about the Earth. And the question would be, "What could you infer about the Earth?" Because now you have the bird.

- 6.32 Well, you could infer an atmosphere. You could infer the gravity. You could infer the presence of water. You could infer the basic chemical constituents of the Earth. The bird has to reflect the environment in order to be operating in the environment. That's the microcosmic idea. And if I remember correctly, he actually used the word **microcosm**.
- 6.33 It's very interesting because there's a Christian notion that the human soul is a **microcosm**. It's reflecting the structure of the cosmos as such. Religious notion—that the **logos** in you is reflective of the **logos** that's part and parcel of reality itself. The Greek idea of **logos** was really predicated on the notion that implicit in the structure of matter itself is something like an implicate order and something like an implicate moral order. So, there's a striving towards the moral, towards this higher unity, that **Nietzsche** describes, that's even implicit in the material world.
- 6.34 It's a tough argument to sort through. To what degree can you derive the notion of a moral order purely from the analysis of the objective facts? It's complicated to think through. It's actually the goal that **Sam Harris** has; for example, he would like to ground morality in the objective. He's making the presupposition that you can do that. And I think that that's a story that's only half-complete because I don't think you can do it merely as a consequence of the analysis of the objective. The subjective has to pull into it as well. But I understand his point.
- 6.35 There is a striving, even in animals, towards something like unity. You see that in social animals who have to aggregate themselves in some sustainable way. And you see that in the same striving, the strange striving manifested by animals towards more abstracted virtues. Butterflies, for example, can detect a part—a deviation in a potential mate of one part in a million from the ideal form. And you think, "Obviously." Have you looked at a butterfly? Those things are beautiful. And that's pretty damn weird, too. Those things are bugs, and they're beautiful. The reason they're beautiful is because of sexual selection. They chose that, and that's fine. They're butterflies. They could choose whatever they want. That's not the issue. The issue is that what they choose we also see as beautiful.
- 6.36 And then, there's these bowerbirds. They're cool. Bowerbirds are very much worth looking up. The males make these unbelievably elaborate—they're not nests; they're artistic constructions. It's the only way you can think about them. They weave them together, and then they decorate the front yards. They'll use blue petals on one side and red petals on the other. And then, they construct the entryway where the female will come and look at the nest. They'll go down there and adjust the perspective so the damn thing looks more impressive than it is from the perspective that she will adopt when she walks in to view it. So, that's wild.
- 6.37 And then, they make their little nest and decorate it quite nicely and very impressively, given that they're birds. And then, they do a dance, and it's a very sophisticated dance that's matched to the set. Now and then, a male bowerbird who uses power will go knock a younger bird out of

his nest. But his problem is, he doesn't know how to dance there. So then, the females will come and look at this impressive thing that the thief has taken, but the thief doesn't know how to dance there, and she can figure out that his dance doesn't go along with the project, and she'll leave. So, that's unbelievably sophisticated.

- 6.38 And there's these weird little fish, these puffer fish. They're only about this big, and they go down to the bottom of the ocean, where it's still sunny, on the coastal shelf. They make this like a 40-foot sculpture. It's round, and it's made out of waves of sand that are about this big. Remember, the fish is only this big. They spend like two weeks making this. They've got these little pathetic fins that come out of their body. It's like this, and they can use their mouth, and they go down and take every shell away. It's all clean. It's perfectly circular. It's undulating. They go up above it and look at it with one eye to see if it's going right. The females come along and check it out.
- 6.39 So, you see this striving even within the material world. It's a way of thinking about it. The material world is striving forward in accordance with an underlying **logos**, an underlying structure. It can diversify in a multitude of ways but around some central pattern of being. That's the **logos** in the—that's why we have logic because we also assume that we can extract out useful information from, say, objective sense data if we approach it properly, logically. We can extract out information that would orient us properly, morally, and that would be a reflection of the world itself. So, it's like an ethos that emerges from the material world.
- 6.40 You can think of the Judeo-Christian project as the overlaying of the **logos** idea that's Christian. That's the word that extracts habitable order from the beginning of time that's embodied in each of us. That's our dignity as human beings. That's overlaid on top of the Greek notion. And so, the idea is something like, "The desirable moral order emerges from the bottom up, from the material world up, and it descends from the top down at the same time, and that they meet in the middle.
- 6.41 So, Western culture would be something like the synthesis of the empirical and the material in relationship to this ethical striving and the descent of the personality, and the **logos** from the personality perspective would be the practice of encountering the world in a manner that reveals the intrinsic moral structure, which is what scientists do when they're practicing science properly. They're not randomly sampling the infinite domain of potential facts. They're guided by a redemptive ethos because scientists say, "It goes without saying that we're doing this for the benefit of people."
- 6.42 Then, you think, "What does that mean?" It means the investigation could, in principle, be for the benefit of people, which means that investigation could, in principle, be for the benefit of people. And then, also, it means that the information that you gather as a consequence of engaging in that investigation, which is revealed from the world, is good in and of itself because otherwise, it wouldn't serve human good.

- 6.43 So, that's another **axiomatic presupposition** that's basically religious in nature. None of that's necessary. It could easily be that we should stop mucking about with the material world because if we don't quit, it's going to destroy us. That's certainly within the realm of possibility. But what we do is assume instead that if we did it with the best spirit inhabiting us, the consequence of the investigation would be redemptive psychologically—the pursuit of truth—and also socially, it would lift us all up towards wherever it is we're going.
- 6.44 That's all religious. That's axiomatically religious. That's why Jung proposed that science—and the **Postmodernists** do this to some degree, too— science is necessarily embedded in a narrative structure. So, it's not science, and the narrative emerges out of it. It's the other way around. It's the narrative, and science emerges out of it. And that's a complicated problem.
- 6.45 Now, the **Postmodernists** say, "All science basically serves power," because that's their solution to the problem of the **will to power**. It's all about power and compulsion. I always think of that as a confession rather than an observation. It's like, "You think it's all about power, do you? Okay, now I know who you are." What makes you think that you're the person who stands outside that if that's your universal explanation? Why are you so sure that you're not developing that universal explanation precisely so that you have a justification for using nothing but power?
- 6.46 "Everyone else is doing it. There's no other game in town." It's like, "Okay, fair enough." You can give some credence to it because, obviously, any—even your relationship to yourself can be corrupted by power, the desire by part of you to dominate the other parts without their voluntary assent. You can set up any relationship like that. You can set up a relationship based on force. It's clearly the case that any social relationship can degenerate into a power game. It happens all the time. But there's a big difference between saying that it's all about power when it degenerates and saying no, power is the generating factor a priori. Those are very, very different statements.
- 6.47 I think it's something more like the proper generating principle; it's something more like the will to play than the **will to power**. And you think, "Who do you want to be around?" Do you want to be around the person who's all **will to power**, or do you want to be around the person who's all will to play? That's a pretty easy question unless you want to be a slave, and that's an option. But if you don't, play sounds—that sounds good. That sounds good.
- 6.48 You know perfectly well if you've ever had any, like, bone-breaking jobs, one of the ways those can be justified and sustained is that the people with whom you're engaged in the activity—this happens with soldiers all the time—they bind. They form a community, and the community is basically predicated on something like play. The harsh guys, the soldiers, the emergency—this happens with women, too—the emergency responders, it's harsh humor and play. That's partly how they sustain themselves in the face of all that catastrophe.
- 6.49 Even then, when they're faced with the grittiest realities of existence itself, dark humor can get you a long way. It bonds you with other people and spreads the burden and all of that. And so,

even in those dire situations, there's always the possibility that you can transmute that existential catastrophe into something approximating play.

- 6.50 Nietzsche's notion—he certainly elaborates this later in the book—is that that's the mark of the depth of your spirit, the willingness to do that because maybe you start by being willing. It's like, "I'm going to take even the worst possible catastrophe that could beset me and regard it as my moral obligation to transmute that into something approximating play." That's a hell of a will because you could say, "The world's pretty brutal. Why not be resentful and bitter?" Because the facts sure indicate that that's in the class of valid responses.
- 6.51 You meet people like that. They've had such brutal lives. You think, "Oh, my God, no wonder you're a monster. It's amazing you're not worse." But you also meet people who've had an equally brutal life who aren't brutal. And so, what do you conclude from that? It's that they decided that they're going to draw a different set of conclusions from the same set of facts.
- 6.52 "All psychology so far has got stuck in moral prejudices and fears; it has not dared to descend into the depths. To understand it as morphology and the doctrine of the development of the **will to power**, as I do—nobody has yet come close to doing this, even in thought."
- 6.53 It's a vague statement because we still don't really know what's meant by **will to power**. But we're starting to flesh that out, starting to develop an understanding of it. And Nietzsche is doing it, as I said, by—and in his own mind. It's not like he knows what it is. While he's writing, he's thinking it through. "Well, it looks like it's like this. It looks like it's like this." His use of metaphor. "It's kind of like this. It's kind of like this thing. It's a little bit like this thing." You build a picture in your mind of this chimerical monster that he's building up so you can apprehend it and verbalize it, and that's what he's doing in his writing rather than delivering you a foregone conclusion.
- 6.54 It's partly why his writing is exciting, too. It's got that narrative compulsion. It takes you along with him because he doesn't have the answer; he is delivering it. The book is the process of understanding the answer. That's what this lecture is, too. I didn't prepare what I'm telling you. I prepared the paragraphs that I'm talking about. I'm trying to figure out what they mean as we go along. We're all participating in that process, and that makes it engaging because—what would you say—it's not stilted and axiomatic. There's a dynamism about the process that's part and parcel of engagement and voluntary exploration and the unknown. Who knows if this is going to work? So far, it seems to be, and that's because, in principle, we're approaching it with goodwill, and we've got great source material.
- 6.55 "The power of moral prejudices has penetrated into the most spiritual world, which would seem to be the coldest and most devoid of presuppositions, and has obviously operated in an injurious, inhibiting, blinding, and distorting manner. A proper physio-psychology has to contend with unconscious resistance in the heart of the investigator. It has 'the heart' against it; even a doctrine of the reciprocal dependence of the 'good' and the 'wicked' drives causes (as refined

immorality) distress and aversion in a still hale and hearty conscience—still more so, a doctrine of the derivation of all good impulses from wicked ones."

- 6.56** So, what does he mean by that? I can tell you. I can give you a hint. When I was participating in formal research, one of the ways I knew that we had stumbled across something that was likely true was that I wasn't very happy about it because you got to be suspicious of any truth, especially that's revealed in psychological research that confirms your prejudices. That's a little too convenient because you're right. What's the chances of that, given how complex the world is? It's not very high. If the research just confirms your suspicions, you think, "Maybe I built the suspicions into the research." But now and then, something will pop up. It's like, "Oh, that isn't what we expected at all."
- 6.57** I'll tell you one example of that, a minor one, in some ways. So, I developed this questionnaire to assess lifetime creativity. We divided creative achievement, not creative thinking, into 13 domains. Here's domains you could be creative in: literary production, entrepreneurial production, industrial invention, architecture, culinary endeavor, dance—you get the idea.
- 6.58** Then, we developed a rank-ordering of levels of attainment from zero, which was, "I have no training or skill in this area," to eight, I think it was. Eight is, "I'm internationally recognized as an authority or as a creative producer in these areas." So, if you're a composer, "My compositions are regularly played by orchestras with international stature." That's the highest level of achievement.
- 6.59** And then, we administered it to a very wide variety of people. I assumed we'd get a normal distribution of scores, that most people would be in the middle, and that there'd be some people with very low scores and some people with very high scores, but that's not what happened. We didn't even notice this was a discovery for a while. We thought it was a problem for statistical analysis because most statistics in social science are predicated on the fact that you're going to analyze a data set that has a normal distribution. But our data set wasn't normal at all.
- 6.60** Seventy percent of people scored zero. Well, how many books have you written and published? It's like zero. How many portraits have you painted? Zero. Have you written any plays? No. Have you written a composition that's been played by any orchestra? No. And everyone says, "Everyone's creative." It's like, "Yeah, no." It's just not—it's not true at all. It's not true at all. Seventy percent of people scored zero.
- 6.61** And by far, the next most common score was one, which meant, generally, that the person had, at some point, taken a piano lesson, because that would give you one. That opened up a whole new world to me of statistical reality over the next 10 years in a variety of different ways. I didn't know that creative production was Pareto-distributed, not normally distributed. What that means is that in the domain of creative production—this includes criminality, by the way, which is a creative act in that it's norm-violating—a tiny percentage of people do all of it.

- 6.62 So, one percent of criminals account for 65% of all crimes because they specialize. Some people in prison just did one big stupid thing once. But the real criminals are the ones that—they arrested one guy in Toronto who had a bike theft ring, and bike thefts went down 40% because he was the guy. He was the specialist. Everything's like that. Almost everything that we benefit from is produced by a tiny minority of hyper-producers. Now, that's a general principle, it turns out.
- 6.63 So, here's an example. Very few planets have all the planetary mass. Jupiter is the example in our solar system. It's way bigger than all the other planets. The same with stars: a tiny number of stars have all the mass. It's the same with rivers: a very small proportion of rivers have all the water. It's the same with lakes. It's the same with blood vessels in your body. It's the same with cities.
- 6.64 It's the same with—a small number of people record records, like record songs. A small proportion of the people who record songs record the popular songs. A very tiny proportion of popular songs are hyper-popular. So, five classical composers composed all the music that consists—that makes up 95% of the classical— of the classical repertoire. Five people. Five percent of their music makes up 95% of what's played. You see this; it's everywhere, this fractal structure.
- 6.65 So, the truth we detected was the existence of this **Pareto distribution** underlying creative distribution and that forced me to revamp my—I was shocked by this because I had been taught as a social scientist. I was teaching at Harvard at this time. I had a reasonably good statistical education. "Well, everything's normally distributed." Well, everything random is normally distributed. Creative production isn't random. And then, it's not just creative production because that has nothing to do with the massive stars. There's this whole other domain of phenomena that are Pareto-distributed. This is so important.
- 6.66 For example, you see that with money. Some people are really good at gathering money, producing it, and gathering it. Really good at it. So, a tiny fraction of people have more wealth than the bottom four billion people. That's the famous 1%. It's a fractal structure. The 1% is pretty rich, but they're nowhere near as rich as the one 10th of 1%, and those guys hardly even rate, compared to the 1000th of 1%. So, you have this fractal structure of accumulation of capital.
- 6.67 Now, **Marx** pointed to this. He said, "Capital tends to accumulate in the hands of fewer and fewer people," which is true. Then he said, "That's capitalism." It's like, "No, that's wrong. That's not capitalism." The capitalism accounts for the massive stars? The differential distribution of the massive stars? I don't think so. It's a way deeper problem than mere capitalism.
- 6.68 You know this, too, because you set up a communist society—you don't solve the problem of the **Pareto distribution**. Still, a tiny proportion of people have all the resources. All you do is make sure there are hardly any resources. So now, in a communist society, there's just as much inequality or even more, but there's almost nothing to be divided up. So, even the rich people

are struggling, whereas the poor people, well, they die. You can usually help them along, too, with that effort. That's an example of how it's frequently the case that when you are moving towards discovering a truth, the truth requires that you recognize something that you'd rather not recognize.

- 6.69 I think that's also true in personal development. One of the propositions that Jung put forward is that for you to advance, you'll have to sacrifice something that you love. If you're stuck, you're clinging to something. You're clinging to it because you love it, you value it, you believe it's good, but in this situation, it's actually the biggest impediment that you have. You have to let it go and sacrifice it in order to move forward.
- 6.70 "Proper physio-psychology has to contend with unconscious resistance in the heart of the investigator, it has 'the heart' against it: even a doctrine of the reciprocal dependence of the 'good' and the 'wicked' drives, causes (as refined immorality) distress and aversion in a still hale and hearty conscience—still more so a doctrine of the derivation of all good impulses from wicked ones."
- 6.71 Well, we talked about Darwin the other day. He was driven by this will to truth, let's say. He discovered something that upset him terribly because he was a practicing Christian and he had no idea how to reconcile what he now knew to be true with what he had always presumed to be true. It's a testament to his integrity as a scientist that—and he did hesitate to publish for a while—but it's a testament to his integrity as a scientist that despite the distress that this new revelation of truth caused him, he went forward with the investigation.
- 6.72 That's a revaluation. Now, is it a revaluation of good and evil? Well, that's a more complicated question, but it's certainly—it was certainly a set of discoveries that had unknowable implications for the entire moral order. Because I think the biggest blow that's ever been brought forward from the scientific community to the classical Christian religious community is probably the doctrine of evolution.
- 6.73 You could argue that maybe the discovery that the Earth wasn't the center of the cosmos in a physical sense, or that that wasn't the simplest way of conceptualizing it, was also a blow, but not as much of a blow as the blow that Darwin delivered. Now, I think there are ways of mediating that contradiction, but Darwin certainly wasn't aware of them, and people barely are now.
- 6.74 "If, however, a person should regard even the affects of hatred"—the emotions—"of hatred, envy, covetousness, and the lust to rule as conditions of life, as factors, which fundamentally and essentially must be present in the general economy of life (and must, therefore, be further enhanced if life is to be further enhanced)—he will suffer from such a view of things as from seasickness."
- 6.75 Say you want your child to exist in a world of peace. So, imagine then you could teach them to be harmless because harmless people are not violent in principle. Or you could teach them to be extremely dangerous and control it. What's better for peace? Well, if you are careless and

destructive, I would say in your thinking, you might say, "Why would you possibly teach a child to develop the capacity for violence?" But if you were sensible, and men generally knew this, you teach your child to be dangerous and then to control it. So, maybe you teach a child how to fight. "You don't pick on kids smaller than you, and here's the conditions under which physical intervention is not only necessary but mandatory." If you're standing up for someone who's being bullied or overpowered, or if you're standing up for yourself.

- 6.76 That's a martial arts doctrine, most fundamentally, that you should develop your ability to defend and to attack, but then you should ensconce that within a moral view that puts that capacity in its proper place. And so, one reading of the Nietzschean emphasis on the development of these other drives, and some of them are dark: covetousness, he says, lust, hatred, envy—he's really going after the sins. Is there something like a place where they might be virtuous? They would serve life, and that would mean they would be manifestations of this unifying will to power that Nietzsche is striving towards conceptualizing.
- 6.77 And I would say, well, let's say you have a capacity for hatred. Should you dispense with that? This isn't a question I know the answer to because hatred is a tough one. Is it a virtue or a vice if it's properly targeted? What's the right attitude that you might have towards a serial sexual slayer of children? You might say, "That person could conceivably be penitent and be redeemed." But then, you might also say, "You've gone a long way out there into the darkness. It's not exactly clear that A, you could come back, or B, that you even have—you forfeited the right to even try." And then, you might say, "That's up to God to decide." It's like, "Yeah, fair enough, except you shouldn't be on the street."
- 6.78 And then, you might ask, "Can you do that without hatred?" It isn't obvious to me in any straightforward way that the answer to that is yes. What is it in you that enables the will to appropriately punish? Now, I know this is a very thorny moral problem, which is why I used a very exaggerated example. Very few people think the sexual slayer and torturer of children has any residual good within them.
- 6.79 Now, you could say, nonetheless, punishment is not the point. It's mere protection of society. You lock someone like that away, not even necessarily to punish them although you could ask yourself, "Maybe there's nothing better you could do for that person than to punish them" because it's not obvious that—in Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment*, Raskolnikov kills two people. He plans to kill one, but he ends up killing two. The first thing he discovers is that the Raskolnikov that existed prior to the killing and the Raskolnikov that now exists after the killing aren't the same creature at all. The whole world is now 100% different.
- 6.80 Raskolnikov actually gets away with the murder. Nothing links it to him, but he's so tortured by his conscience that he ends up—it's great. This prosecutor—Dostoevsky is so brilliant—this prosecutor notices him hanging around the investigation, and he develops this theory that maybe this is the kid who did it. And then, he starts to play with him like a cat plays with a mouse. There's like 100 pages in *Crime and Punishment* that's nothing but this prosecutor

setting up deep psychological traps for the person he now identifies as the perpetrator. It's so sophisticated.

- 6.81 Anyways, Raskolnikov is in such agony. He's like Cain. Cain says to God after he kills Abel that his punishment is more than he can bear. It's not exactly what he's referring to, but it might be the pangs of his own conscience. That's definitely the case with Raskolnikov. He's really crying out for punishment. It's the only way that he can see forward to something approximating redemption. He has to pay for what he's done; he knows that what he's done is unforgivable, really, terrible to the point of unforgivable.
- 6.82 And then, that begs the question, "Is the necessary punishment commensurate with the magnitude of the crime?" Even if the goal might be —a penitentiary means a place for people to be penitent; there's a Christian substructure to the idea of a penitentiary. You go there, you're separated from people, you reflect on your sins, and hopefully, you put yourself back together. You have that option, which is really quite amazing. In a tyranny, it's—you're dead. Maybe you committed a crime. Okay, you're dead. That's what, there's no—why bother fixing you, even on the off-chance that you might be innocent? You're not innocent of everything, so it's perfectly reasonable to take you out. And certainly, that's how totalitarian states work.
- 6.83 So, Nietzsche is begging this question, and I think it's a—there's this notion in Genesis, that Adam, who names things—that's part of his manifestation of the *logos* —subdues the world. 'Due' is an interesting—D-U-E is an interesting word because it means putting everything in its place: giving the devil its due. To give everything its due is to put it in a hierarchical order. And so, possibly what Nietzsche is incrementally revealing, struggling towards, this notion that these darker impulses are only pathological if they're not in the proper relationship to one another, and that if they were in the proper relationship to one another, they'd actually be virtues rather than vices.
- 6.84 I think that's a reasonable perspective because we could think about this biologically for a moment. The immense mass of your fundamental motivational systems, all of them that enable you to be capable of hatred, let's say, and of rage and of sexual jealousy, that sort of thing—everyone has those. They're very, very powerful. The probability that they're not useful is zero. That doesn't mean that if only that motivates you, that's okay or optimal. That's not the same claim.
- 6.85 I do believe this is the case. If you have a tough little kid and the tougher little kids tend to be boys. They're more—five percent of boys at the age of two spontaneously kick, hit, steal, bite, and punch. Yeah, yeah. That's the definition of childhood antisocial behavior at the age of two. Most kids aren't like that. Almost no girls are like that. Five percent of boys are like that.
- 6.86 And it's out of that pool of boys, aggressive by temperament, that the criminals are drawn. Now, it's not deterministic because most aggressive boys are socialized by the age of four if their parents can contend with the ornery little rat that they've got. They've got a guard dog instead of a lapdog for a kid. Fundamentally, the temperament is quite different.

- 6.87 The kid's not agreeable. He's tough and ornery, and that doesn't mean he's destined for a life of criminality. He might make a great soldier, for example, or a great jet pilot or someone adventurous and daring. Harder to socialize, but maybe even more useful because of it. But that would also mean that all those impulses are put in their proper place.
- 6.88 My son was like that. He was a very ornery little kid. He was really quite comical because he had such a strong will, such an ornery kid. It was so funny to watch him, and I really taught him how to regulate that. And he's unbelievably diplomatic, but he's unbelievably set on making his pathway forward. Diplomatic. The fundamental temperament hasn't changed. If you try to get him to do something he doesn't want to do, he'll be very polite about it, but there isn't a chance that he's going to do something he doesn't want to do.
- 6.89 Lots of men are like that. That's partly why men are bailing out so much because they're being compelled by educational systems to do things they don't want to do. They're not on board with it. And the men say, "Screw you. I won't do this. I'll go play video games with my friends or whatever. I'm not going to play this game at all." And that's not so good because it knocks them out of the socialization system, although some of them still become hyper-successful as a consequence. But it's by no means not emblematic of a certain kind of virtue.
- 6.90 Most of my friends dropped out of school by grade 10. They went and worked on oil rigs. My observation was that most of the boys who remained—not all of them—were—a higher proportion of contemptible boys remained in school. The kids who were done raising their hands to go to the bathroom at age 14 were out of there. It's like, "I'm not doing this anymore. I'll go work on the rigs and make \$150,000 a year back in 1970."
- 6.91 It was very strange to me because it was the friends that I had that were most admirable, oddly enough, who tended to drop out of school, and I didn't really know what to make of that. I had friends who were very bright and who were academically oriented. They stayed in school. They weren't cowards. I don't mean the ones who left were cowards. Some of the boys who stayed in school had noble motivations for doing so but by no means all of them. A lot of them stayed because they were pathologically obedient.
- 6.92 And so, this is a warning. Nietzsche is a philosopher but also a psychologist. I think this is also the thing that made him unpalatable to his academic peers, about whom he has words to say later. Nietzsche. There's an element of him that's—he's like a motivational speaker, and he's practical in a way that philosophers seldom are. Nietzsche, in philosophy, is a call to arms. It's not an abstracted description of the world. It's a dynamic call to arms, and it comes with warnings, and this is an interesting warning.
- 6.93 "How poisonous, how crafty, how bad, does every long war make one, that cannot be waged openly by means of force!" That's an interesting sentence, too, because he makes this—just as an aside, he says it's possible that a war waged openly by force is more moral than a war that has to rage underground. And we wouldn't think that, but this is one advantage that men have over women, I would say, in their battles.

- 6.94 If two men have a moral dispute, they can fight physically. That usually ends it. And it's also the case that among men, the fact that a moral dispute, a status dispute, can end in physical violence really regulates the moral disputes. Women don't have that, and that's really not so good because what do you do?
- 6.95 If you're ganged up on by a gang of mean girls, what are you going to do? And it means that there's a form of female antisocial behavior. It's linked with psychopathy, Machiavellianism, narcissism, and sadism, just like antisocial behavior is linked in men. In women, it takes the form of social exclusion and reputation denigration. If men do that to each other, they have a fight, and that usually settles it, and it stops. But women— that can't happen with women. It can go on forever, and it does go on forever, and it scales brilliantly on social media, and that's a real problem. So, Nietzsche's pointing to all that in the first sentence.
- 6.96 "How personal does a long fear make one, a long watching of enemies, of possible enemies!" He's warning here about—there's a call to battle in the Nietzschean philosophy, but he's also warning about what that can do to you if you don't handle the fact of the battle, if you're battling for the introduction and integration of new and revelatory ideas. You're engaged in a battle. He's concerned about how that might warp you if the battle is undertaken over a long period of time.
- 6.97 "These outcasts of society, these long-pursued, wickedly persecuted ones —also the compulsory recluses, the Spinozas or Giordano Brunos—always become in the end, even under the most spiritual masquerade, and perhaps without being themselves aware of it, sophisticated vengeance seekers and poison-brewers (let someone lay bare the foundation of Spinoza's ethics and theology!)—not to speak of the stupidity of moral indignation, which is the unfailing sign in a philosopher that his philosophical sense of humor has left him."
- 6.98 Foucault was an outcast because of his sexuality. Derrida was an Algerian Jew who was an outcast from French society. And I do believe this to be the case: there's a tremendous resentment in Foucault and Derrida that makes itself expressed in their philosophy. It's partly the reason that they allied themselves with the Marxism that calls for a revolutionary overthrow of the entire moral order.
- 6.99 It's like, "You don't fit." Well, you can understand that if you don't fit, you can understand that that could embitter you. Especially—and both Foucault and Derrida were brilliant. Foucault was unbelievably brilliant, and he actually had a pretty stellar academic career. But Derrida was also always a cultural outsider. And so, that can breed a certain resentment. That's what Nietzsche is warning about here, and for good reason.
- 6.100 I like this one: "Cynicism is the only form in which base souls approach honesty." It's such a brilliant aphorism. It's such a brilliant line because we think of cynicism as a moral evil, but I observed this in my clinical practice constantly. Naive people become cynical when they encounter malevolence. That's what happens. So, naive people are good. They're like children.

"Everyone's good. Everyone's good. Everyone really has your best interests in mind. Even the people who are doing terrible things really think they're doing good."

- 6.101** It's like, "Yeah, you wait till you run into someone who's malevolent." You're just a ripe fruit waiting to be plucked. And maybe you haven't run into anyone like that yet, but that's just the grace of God. If you're naive and you encounter malevolence, you are traumatized. That's what happens. So then, what happens to someone who's traumatized by malevolence if they're naive? The answer is, "They become cynical."
- 6.102** And then, you might say, "Is that better or worse?" In some ways, it seems worse because now they don't trust. And certainly, the world's not a positive place, and they're skeptical of people, but they're not naive. It could easily be that cynicism is actually an improvement over naivety, and I actually think that's the case.
- 6.103** The problem with cynicism is that cynics aren't cynical enough about their cynicism. They think that's the end state. "Well, now I've woken up. I know what the world's really like, and a lot of people are snakes. And even those people who are acting good, there's a snake in them somewhere. You got to always have the snake in mind when you're dealing with someone. You really shouldn't trust because you're a fool if you trust." It's like, "No, you're a fool if you trust naively."
- 6.104** So then, you might ask, "What's beyond cynicism?" Nietzsche is pointing this out here. He says it's "the form in which base souls approach honesty." He's such a lovely thinker because he always gives the devil his due. It's like, "Is cynicism a virtue or a vice?" It depends on what you compare it to. Base souls approach honesty through cynicism.
- 6.105** There is an admirability to cynics. A lot of comedians have that cynical edge, and it can make them extremely comical. He could be a pretty sophisticated cynic. And sometimes, that can be a bit of a game. The comedian who's cynical is already halfway to not being cynical because he's transmuted the cynicism into humor. The thing about humor is that even if you laugh at yourself as a comedian, which is the best form of comedy, you debase yourself because now you're the target of your laughter, but you elevate yourself at the same time by pointing out that you're the thing that can transcend your stupidity and point it out. So, when you make a joke about yourself, you're identifying with the part of yourself that transcends your stupidity. And so, cynical humor transmutes cynicism.
- 6.106** What's past cynicism? Courageous trust. That's way better. It's way better than naivety. It's like, "I know you're full of snakes. Me too, just so you know, by the way, so that we've got that out of the way. But let's see. We'll see if we can enter into an arrangement here where you try to call the best out of me, and I'll do the same to you, and we'll do that assuming goodwill on each other's part." That's trust. That's courageous trust.
- 6.107** That's a great basis for a relationship because it makes allowance for error, even to the point of malevolence. Like, "I know that you can go off to the left, let's say, pretty badly, but I'll take that into account, and I'll assume you'll do the same for me. And we'll presume that, with goodwill,

we can move forward in a positive direction." That's way better because then you're awake to the malevolence so you can't be traumatized, depending on the level of malevolence you run into. But you open up the door again to all the utility of trust. You can't get anywhere with someone without trust.

- 6.108** So, cynicism is the transition point between naivety and wisdom. And so, you trust, and then, that allies—it's so interesting because now it allies trust with courage instead of naivety. You don't trust because you're naive; you trust because you've decided to bear the risk. That's a great gift to offer someone, to say, "I'll bear the risk of your and my inadequacy and ignorance and potential malevolence, and we'll move forward nonetheless." And then, you can think about it as a moral requirement to have that kind of trust and to do that courageously. That's way better. It makes trust now something that's emblematic of strength rather than weakness and faith rather than naivety. It's a lovely move.
- 6.109** "Cynicism is the only form in which base souls approach honesty; and a higher man must listen closely to every coarse or subtle cynicism." That's why it's useful to read conspiracy theorists because they're all cynical. But what's Nietzsche's injunction? "Listen closely to every coarse or subtle cynicism, and congratulate yourself when a clown without shame or a scientific satyr speaks out precisely in front of him."
- 6.110** That's another thing that cynics are good for. They alert you to the canaries in the coal mine. Now, they see them everywhere. It's like, "Doom is coming here and there and there and there and there, and there's malevolence and corruption everywhere." It's like, "Maybe not everywhere, and maybe not as systematically as you presume, but you're a good counterpoint to the naive people."
- 6.111** And so, you want to—this is another reason why free speech is so necessary. It's like, "Free speech produces conspiracy theorists." It's like, "Fair enough." Those are false positives. They're people who are diagnosing a problem, and they do it incorrectly, but if you're going to allow people to diagnose a problem, to get an accurate diagnosis, you're probably going to have to stumble through—what—20 inaccurate diagnoses? Unless you assume people are going to hit the bloody target first thing 100% of the time.
- 6.112** A lot of it's going to be noise like it is in the scientific literature. Most scientific studies are wrong. Some of them are stupidly wrong, but some of them are right; maybe it's 5%. That's a **Pareto distribution** issue again. But if it's 5% year after year, and that compounds, you're moving forward so fast you can hardly believe it. Now, the problem might be: how do you stop from getting swamped in the inaccurate science? But generally, what happens is it doesn't get cited, and people forget about it.
- 6.113** So, it moves into the realm of bad art. I collected art on eBay for years. I've looked at—I've literally looked at millions of paintings because I probably looked at somewhere between 1 and 2,000 paintings a night for three years. And paintings on eBay are so bad. You can't believe it. Everything you could possibly imagine that could be wrong with a painting is wrong with almost

all paintings, but not all. Most of the art produced isn't art, and it's tasteless and awful. But God only knows how much of that has to be produced so that there are some people who do it right.

- 6.114 Nietzsche makes a comment about that. We'll talk about that tomorrow, about the sort of profligacy of nature, the manic overproduction. There's a reference to that in the Gospels where Christ talks about seed being distributed on soil that's both fertile and barren. Seed goes everywhere. There's the possibility for growth everywhere. Most seed falls on barren ground. Most things die pointlessly. That's another way of thinking about it. But most is not all. And God only knows how much overproduction there has to be for there to be progress.
- 6.115 This is a really good thing to know if you're writing, by the way. Do not edit when you're producing. Say you're trying to address a problem when you're writing. Write down everything you think. If you've got nothing to think, pick a different problem, one that actually bothers you, and if you still don't have anything to think, read some more. And then, write down everything you think about the problem. Don't think about what you're thinking. Just get it all down: stupid ideas, half-baked ideas, crazy ideas, no problem. Get it down, and then take a break, go back, and then sift. Separate the wheat from the chaff.
- 6.116 You'll probably have to throw away 80%, but—and you think, "Oh my God, I can't stand that. I spent all that work writing down those words." You're probably doing too much editing if it was that much work. It's actually less work to take the restraints off your production, to let yourself say what you have to say, stupidity and all, and then go back and separate the wheat from the chaff. It's also way more fun.
- 6.117 It works neurophysiologically because, actually, the part of your brain that produces thoughts and the part that inhibits and edits are separate parts. And if you play one off against the other because you want to only write the correct sentences, you want a first draft that you can hand in—it's like God, it's a lot of constraints. Not only do you have to think something up, it has to be the right thing said the right way. Maybe if you're a genius and you've written for 30 years, you can do that now and then, but if you're not an expert, nobody can do all that at once.
- 6.118 Separate it out. Separate it out. Take the constraints off and allow yourself to overflow stupidly. Most of what you write, put it in a cull collection. Maybe it'll be good for something else at some other time. You want that overproduction and then the post hoc selection.
- 6.119 That's the same thing on the free speech front. You listen to the cynics because you need a lot of production before you get to the truth. You need a lot of approximation of the target before you hit it. You have to let people wander around stupidly, including yourself. It's a good thing to let yourself off the hook morally, too. It's like, "I want to do something good." Okay, that's hard. "I want to do something good perfectly." You're pushing your luck there. "I want to do something good, stupidly and badly, and learn slowly while doing it." Yeah, you could probably do that. It's still pretty good. You're stumbling in the right direction, and you'll get better as you move forward. It's not too arrogant a goal because it takes into account the fact that you're useless

and ignorant, and despite that, you let off the constraints a bit, so someone as useless and ignorant as you could actually manage to move forward.

- 6.120** And that's a good thing to do with your partners, too. I'll tell you something about your marriage that you might find useful. So, patterns of interactions with your spouse, because you live with them—there'll be things you do habitually: how you greet each other when you come home from work, for example, or how you sit down to the table. And you might want to think about those things you repeat because those are your life. You might want to think, "How could this be done if it was done optimally?" If your whole family sat down together for dinner, how would you do that?
- 6.121** If you could have what you wanted, you could develop a little vision of it. And then, you think, "If it went like this, that'd be real good." And then, you could talk over that with your partner. And then, you could say, "Look, why don't we try to do this? We'll practice doing this, and let's let each other do it stupidly and badly, like 30 times." You can do this. This works very well if you want to arrange dates with your partner. Once you have a settled relationship, people stop doing that. It's a big mistake. Say, we start up that romantic adventure again. People are very resistant to doing that generally.
- 6.122** I used to counsel people who came to me to do this, and they'd come back, both of them often, because sometimes I saw people together, and they'd say, "We went out and had one of those dates that you suggested, and it went as miserably as we thought it would." They were generally very satisfied about that, oddly. And my response generally was, "Do it stupidly 50 times. You'll get better at it."
- 6.123** If you had a date twice a week, it's 100 times a year. You're married for 30 years. That's 3,000 times. If you have to do it badly 50 times, you get to do it well 2,950 times. It's not much of an investment. So, go, do it stupidly. You're not a romantic genius. Of course, you're going to be a fool at it, but if you allow your partner to incrementally move towards the ideal that you've both formulated. You don't get too punitive about that, and you encourage progress where you see it, you can help you both move to mastery of those repetitive interactions.
- 6.124** It's really worth thinking about your life in that regard. Think about what you do every day. "Well, that's dull and mundane and boring." It's like, "Fair enough. That's your life." You repeat 80% of what you do. That's your life. Get it right. If you put some allowance for error around your interactions—you can even do that when you're fighting. Lay down ground rules for how you fight, and you're going to break them, but slowly, you can incrementally move to something approximating civilized negotiation as an alternative to counterproductive bickering. But there has to be a wide margin of error there for that to be made possible.
- 6.125** Okay, I guess that's that for today. Tomorrow, we'll close this off. We've only got two-thirds of the book to finish. Thank you very much again for coming today. I appreciate your time.

7. Embracing Struggle

AT A GLANCE

Finishes the Free Spirit section with Nietzsche's critique of the levelers who blame all misery on the old social order and seek the green-pasture happiness of the herd. Argues, with Hobbes and Solzhenitsyn, that ideas are sub-personalities with their own will, and that ingratitude toward the past is arrogance. Explores the necessity of struggle: optimized challenge, the mother who must let her child be broken by the world, Dostoevsky's critique of utopia, the judgment implicit in every ideal, and the danger of a compassion that would abolish suffering by abolishing the sufferer.

- 7.1 All right. Today, we're finishing off this section entitled **The Free Spirit**, and moving as far beyond that as we can into the rest of the text. We'll start with this paragraph.
- 7.2 "They belong"—modern commentators, let's say, modern philosophers or the modern mass —"they belong, briefly and sadly, among the **levelers**, those falsely so-called 'free spirits—being eloquent and prolifically scribbling slaves of the democratic taste and its 'modern ideas.'"
- 7.3 See, **Nietzsche** was no real admirer of the mob. I think you can think about this, maybe at least in part, in a Tower of Babel sort of way, that when society degenerates, it loses all its intermediary structures, and it turns into something like a tyranny in a mob. And the mob is — what would you say—what's only common to all. And what's only common to all is common. There's no nobility in it.
- 7.4 I think part of the reason, for example, that the left, the political left, is often terrified of populism—despite, in principle, at least the moderate left's willingness to uphold democracy—is that there's a fear of the rabble, which is not exactly the same as democracy. And democracy, not that **Nietzsche** was necessarily an admirer of democracy, but democracy requires intermediary structures of responsibility in order to function properly. It's easy for it to degenerate into the common mob and then claim that only what the common mob wants is what should be wanted. That's what **Nietzsche** is, at least in part, what **Nietzsche** is trying to point out here.
- 7.5 "They're all human beings without solitude"—so they've disappeared into the mob—"without their own solitude, clumsy good fellows whom one should not deny either courage or respectable decency, only they are unfree and ridiculously superficial, above all"—and this is very interesting, I would say, given that this was written so long ago —"above all in their basic inclination to find in the forms of the old society as it has existed so far just about the cause of all human misery and failure."
- 7.6 So, you hear the clamoring that's constant, that we live in something approximating the ruins of an oppressive patriarchy and that all human misery is a consequence of the inadequacy of the social structures that we inhabited up to now, which were based on nothing but the desire to exert power, to compel, and to exploit. **Nietzsche** says, "Above all, in their basic inclination to

find in the forms of the old society as it has existed so far just about the cause of all human misery and failure."

- 7.7 Well, I suppose it depends to some degree on where you stand with regards to how you conceptualize the basic condition of humanity. The **Rousseauian** types tend to presume that human misery and human malevolence, even for that matter, is nothing but a consequence of the inadequacy of social organization. That your lack of moral character, insofar as that might characterize you, is a consequence of the fact that you were badly socialized by pathological socialization agents and that you, in your pristine form, would be naturally good.
- 7.8 There's an insistence there as well that's very much characteristic of our age, that the natural order of the human being, absent the tyranny of social structure, would be something like the benevolent existence in the garden of paradise that might have characterized the **noble savage**. It's a completely preposterous view if you are more of a **Hobbesian**, let's say, the philosopher **Thomas Hobbes**, and you think, no, the natural condition of mankind is privation, want, and misery, and that in the absence of a benevolent social order, what you have is a life that's nasty, brutish, and short. I'm much more favorable, in a fundamental sense, to the **Hobbesian** view because I think that it's way easier to starve than to eat.
- 7.9 And so, the natural condition of human beings is a condition of want and need. That's not the only condition. And then, social order, to the degree that it's productive, lifts you out of that. I also don't believe that human beings are implicitly good in a manner that would manifest itself without the careful mediation of the social order to reward that, the flourishing of that good, and to integrate or even inhibit the proclivity towards the bad.
- 7.10 I don't think children are innately good. They're characterized by a wide propensity of possibility, and if that propensity is nurtured and encouraged properly, then the good can flourish. The alternative is to assume that everything evil stems from all society, and that's a pretty dangerous presumption if you believe that the natural condition of humanity is privation and that the social order is one of the miracles that has enabled us to rise out of utter catastrophe.
- 7.11 Before about 1860, everyone in the Western world, 95% of people, lived on about \$1.50 a day in today's money. It's not like we've degenerated from some position of, as I said, Edenic luxury into the dismal state that we inhabit today. That's Nietzsche's point at the end of this paragraph. "It's a way of standing truth happily upon her head." He's saying that not only is this a misapprehension about the nature of the human being in relationship to the social order—because he's an admirer of the nobility of the past—but it's the anti-truth; it's the opposite of the truth.
- 7.12 **Nietzsche** said—it's not in **Beyond Good and Evil**, I don't believe—that one of the most intolerable characteristics of an intolerable human being is lack of gratitude. And it's certainly the case, as far as I can tell, that one of the pathologies that besets the modern age is our utter inability to be grateful for what we've been given by the past.

- 7.13 Now, people do have some qualms about the fact that everybody walks on soil that's soaked with blood. It's definitely the case that human history is a nightmare in many, many ways and that a lot of what we all have before us that we should be grateful for was purchased often with misery at the expense of other people who were sometimes innocent. So, we have to contend with that.
- 7.14 But blanket ingratitude about the past and blanket condemnation of everything that went before us is ungrateful in the extreme, but it's also—there's an arrogance in it that's almost incalculable because the people who make those claims also make the assumption, simultaneously, that somehow, merely by standing as critics, they're morally superior to everyone who went before them in the past. That's actually the germ out of which that opposition grows.
- 7.15 I can hardly stand going into art museums anymore because what you invariably see is a brilliant work of art done by some stunning genius. And then, you have this little description of it, beside it, written by some half-wit pathological narcissist that is doing nothing but trying to elevate themselves morally in relationship to the art by pointing out what power structure this artist served when they were investigating this domain of visual perception and trying to put forward something original and beautiful and new and heroic, often. It's so pathological. It just about cancels out the utility of going to the museum, and that's spreading like mad.
- 7.16 So, this anti-truth—Nietzsche, again, not in *Beyond Good and Evil*—talks about the philosophy of *ressentiment*. He was a real master of the analysis of *ressentiment* and all of that attempt to tear down. You see this, too—the same thing's happening with these protesters who are gluing themselves to great works of art. They're making the claim that, in some manner, they're acting as moral—they're acting so morally that that even gives them the right to endanger great works of art. It's like, "Yeah, I don't think you're that moral. The probability that you're more moral than that painting is great is zero, man."
- 7.17 And so, it's so pretentious to presume that a priori, that merely because you've adopted this axiomatic ideology, the cause of all human misery were the forms of the old society as it has existed so far, and now that elevates you morally so that you have the right, again, to do virtually anything in the name of your morality. It indicates to me that what you're aiming at is the ability to do anything. That's what you want, and the justification is the name of your morality.
- 7.18 That's all part of this idea of standing truth happily upon her head, not only deceiving yourself and other people about the nature of the world but really construing the world and your relationship in a way that's the opposite of what it should be, the very opposite. Anti-truth.
- 7.19 "What they would like to strive for with all their powers." I would think the "they"—there's a religious idea that the world is a battle between good and evil, say, but also between principalities. They're like domains of power. They're not exactly human; they're part of the spiritual world. That might be a way of thinking about it.

- 7.20 There's real utility in that because one of the things I've noticed because I've dealt with no shortage, let's say, of student protesters—the typical student protester, let's say, 19 years old—first, they're 19. What the hell do they know? Seven years ago, they were 12. They don't know anything, and they haven't been independent. They haven't started a family; they haven't started a business. Many of them have never had a job. They can't support themselves economically. They're clueless, and they're possessed by these ideas.
- 7.21 It's not useful to take it personally or even to ascribe what's happening to that person, that protester. If I had met the person, let's say, in a different circumstance, maybe at a dinner at their parents' house, what I would have seen was a kid who was more or less normal, like 80% normal, or as normal as any kid ever is, or 90% even, and then 10% possessed by some idiot idea that their idiot teachers had helped them inculcate and that they welcomed in because it served the kids their own dark and irresponsible purposes. But 90% of the kids would still be a normal person.
- 7.22 But even if it's 10% that's being demented by the possession by these ideas, if you get 200 people like that in a room, you got the whole damn pathological idea set there. And then, it's a spirit that unites that group, and each of the people in the group is a partial representation of that spirit. That's all, and maybe mostly not that at all. But when they're all together, the whole spirit is there, and that spirit is really the—you might think about it as the— manifestation of the **axiomatic structure** of the idea set. It has its own will. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 7.23 When Solzhenitsyn wrote **The Gulag Archipelago**, he did a variety of things. One was to expose the absolute catastrophe of the crimes of the Leninist and Stalinist operation in a manner that no one had ever done by melding personal stories with sociological analysis and putting forward a work that was a melding of the best of literature in the Russian tradition and something like investigative journalism and political philosophy.
- 7.24 But the other thing he did that was so utterly brilliant, and he did a lot of this implicitly, was to show that the catastrophic consequences of the Marxist/Leninist ideas were not an aberration of a system that, in principle, could have worked in a utopian manner, which is the constant claim of leftist apologists. It's like, "That's not real socialism," or "That's not real communism." It was a great set of ideas, but the people who instantiated it were somehow corrupt.
- 7.25 Hidden under that is the claim, "If it was me that had instantiated the Leninist/Marxist ideas, the utopia would have obviously arisen. But given that we had these inadequate people like **Lenin** and **Stalin** in control, or **Mao** or **Pol Pot**"—the litany is endless —"it deviated from the peer course that someone like me could obviously not only see but also implement." It's an extraordinarily pathological perspective; there's an arrogance there that's almost beyond comprehension.
- 7.26 Now, to presume that even though these ideas went so badly in so many places when they were implemented by so many people, that A, there's a way that might not happen, and B, if you just thought like me, then it would work out fine. It's so dangerous.

- 7.27 What Solzhenitsyn did instead—it was so brilliantly and implicitly, through the power of biographical narrative, essentially—was to show that this wasn't an aberration of an otherwise utopian system generated by people who only had the goodwill of the entire human race in mind, but the absolutely logical conclusion of the unfolding of a certain kind of doctrine.
- 7.28 You can think of that doctrine as something that has a will, and this is what Nietzsche is pointing to, the ideas —ideas are sub-personalities. They're not some abstraction. They're not some abstract representation of the objective world, independent of implication for action or of motivation or emotion. Ideas are sub-personalities. You get enough ideas; you have a whole personality. If you get enough people who share those ideas, say, even if they're widely distributed, you get the whole damn dark spirit there, and then, well, what's it up to?
- 7.29 One of the things I wonder a lot, "What's the WEF up to?" The World Economic Forum. I'm not trying to be conspiratorial about that; I'm trying to think, "This group has met for 50 years,"—something like that, since the 1970s—"What's the ethos?"
- 7.30 So, here's a question, "How many people do you"—I'm not asking you this question; it's rhetorical—"How many people do you think the planet can sustain?" Lots of people think, especially biologists—though they're not biologists, they're anti-humanists— it could sustain 500 million people, or maybe a billion at a moderate standard of living, or maybe two billion if they didn't have much. I think, "Okay, well, I don't know what you're planning to do with the excess 8.5 billion." That's a real question. Two billion's okay as far as you're concerned—that's so nice of you—as long as they're poor because they can't have a high standard of living.
- 7.31 Who decides that? And how? Like, exactly. Not hand-waving in some 'we'll figure that out when we get there' sort of manner, but no, actually. Really. Poor, eh? How poor exactly? Does that mean they burn dung in their huts? Because really, that's what it means. Does that mean their children have no economic opportunities? Does that mean that they only have enough food so they can grow to be 5'2", so they don't put out too much carbon?
- 7.32 All these ideas lurk behind that ethos. And so, is that the core idea that we need five Earths to maintain everybody at the North American standard of living, and obviously, we can't get there? Is that the driving notion? I have a suspicion that it might be because people like Paul Ehrlich, from whose ideas this whole mess grew—this whole insane, critical-of-the-past environmentalist catastrophe delusion—is predicated on the idea that there are too many people on the planet.
- 7.33 Is that a genocidal idea? Well, "No, we're saving the planet." It's like, "Yeah, maybe you're the Messiah, but probably not." That turns out to be very difficult. You might think that you're only motivated by those ideas that are the highest, but I'm still not so sure what you want to do with the eight billion excess people.
- 7.34 And so, God only knows what the—because I've heard people say this. You know, "The planet has too many people on it." It's like, "What is speaking in you?" Exactly. You think that's your idea, which it isn't. It's like, "What have you allowed yourself to be taken over by?" And what's it

aiming at, using moral pretension as its shield? "Well, I only care about the planet." It's like, "Yeah, but you got this pesky problem of those excess people, and there's a lot of them."

- 7.35 The second question might be something like, "How rich should we allow the people in the developing world to become?" "Well, it's clear they can't have a standard of living that's anything like the Western standard of living because that would require five planets." It's like, "Okay, how poor then?" Exactly. That's when you get the defense of hand-waving. "You know, I'm just, I'm just trying to, I'm just trying to save the planet." So, that's all you're trying to do, eh? Like I said, that's a hell of a lot more difficult than you might think.
- 7.36 I was reading Kerry yesterday, John Kerry, climate envoy, and he said, "We're all going to have to make sacrifices to keep the planet from warming less than 1.5 degrees in the next 100 years." And I think, "Mr. Kerry, multimillionaire, with your 20-million-dollar mansion on acres of land right by the ocean"—which he doesn't seem to be too worried about—"it doesn't really appear to me that you're going to be making a hell of a lot of sacrifices as we move forward to a non-industrial future."
- 7.37 So, Nietzsche, like Freud, is always looking underneath ideas to try to —it's an unmasking. It's part of the unmasking process that Freud also engaged in, and it can be taken too far because the danger in that is that there's always a reduction of the story to some underlying motivation inferred by the interpreter. "It's all about power." That's where it went wrong with the Postmodernists. But by the same token, in any system of ideas, there is an ethos that unites the system of ideas and makes it coherent, and there's an aim, and it's perfectly reasonable, when you look at a system of ideas, to try to infer what the aim is.
- 7.38 It's technically possible to do this, too. I was talking to one of my former students last night, who's a computational linguist, and he was talking about ChatGPT and the fact that it can produce legible, comprehensible text that's actually quite original. What it does is it looks at the relationship between ideas, words, phrases, and sentences and extracts out the essence of the relationship. That's what it does technically, computationally, and it can do that well enough to continue to converse in that spirit.
- 7.39 And so, it shows that there's even a computationally—there's an ethos underneath the generation of the answer to any question that's actually computationally identifiable. So, the notion that there's an animating spirit that's embedded within any set of ideas, and that is the generating personality of those ideas, is a perfectly reasonable claim. It's very useful to know that an idea is a sub-personality. It has a viewpoint. It has motivations. It has emotions. It has a mode of expressing itself in the world. It has a proclivity towards action. It posits an ideal. There's nothing bloodless and merely objective about any idea.
- 7.40 And then, if the idea is a spirit or a fragment of a spirit, it's perfectly willing to ask, "What's the spirit of the aggregation of the ideas?" We're trying to understand that to some degree, even as we're walking through the Nietzschean text because his notion of the will to power is somewhat ill-defined. It's somewhat vague and still somewhat implicit. So, partly what we're trying to do

when we analyze the text is to see what's the point. What's the central features? How could you reduce the idea of **will to power** to its gist, or its essence, to its essential elements, so that you could understand it?

- 7.41 And that understanding would actually mean—would actually be a form of embodiment because the degree to which you come away from this seminar wiser, let's say, rather than merely more informed, but wiser, that's the degree to which you've extracted out that ethos, that gist, that's like a spirit, and that now you have that at your disposal. You can use that whole set of ideas to orient yourself differently in the world, maybe to aim at a different ideal, to formulate your arguments in a different way.
- 7.42 So, imagine you take the whole corpus of **Nietzschean** thought and reduce it to its gist, which is what you're doing when you're trying to understand it. You can then embody that gist and then carry it forward into the world. That makes you a **Nietzschean** in some way, and if you really grapple with the spirit of any great creator that happens to you, you incorporate some of that ethos, and then it's active within you.
- 7.43 And then, what you're trying to do with a humanities education, and this would be with a true religious education—imagine that you encounter the great spirits of the past. Now, think about the fact that you think of them as great. Well, that means there's some identity across them because they all fit into the category of 'great.' Each of them are different manifestations of what might constitute great.
- 7.44 **Picasso** and **Dostoevsky** are very different people, but they're united by this greatness. The greatness is what's constant across the set of great spirits. What you're trying to do when you become educated, if the education is oriented towards wisdom, is to get at the gist of what constitutes great itself by being exposed to exemplars of the great so that that can dwell within you so that you can then unite with it and then reveal it into the world.
- 7.45 The goal would be then, you're oriented properly towards an ideal worth pursuing, which would give your life meaning and also that it gives you the strength and fortitude that would become—that would be part and parcel of having that great spirit inhabit you.
- 7.46 And then, you could also speculate that—this is a psychologization, although I'm not trying to do it in a reductionist manner. So, you say you have a set of great spirits, and out of that, you extract out what's great. And then, lurking behind that, well, that's —you could say that's a pointer to what's intrinsically divine. So, the divine makes itself manifest in what's great, and then that differentiates, and then you can encounter that in its differentiated forms—the set of great people, let's say—and then that spirit can take up its dwelling place within you. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 7.47 What "they"—this was all an investigation into "they"—it's not so useful to identify this with people. It's sets of ideas that are these abstracted spirits, and the battle between ideas is the battle between super-celestial spirits in an abstract space. The participants are people, but the

war is in heaven. That's a metaphorical way of thinking about it, and maybe more than metaphorical, by the way.

- 7.48 "What they"—I would say this contradictory spirit, it's really the spirit of the adversary, the eternal adversary, one of its manifestations—"what they would like to strive"—it's **Luciferian** intellect, it's the pride of the **Luciferian** intellect—"what they would like to strive for with all their powers is the universal **green-pasture happiness** of the herd."
- 7.49 Remember, we talked yesterday about—or the day before—Nietzsche's idea that it's not **self-preservation** or something like **homeostasis** that's the driving force behind the spirit that properly animates mankind, but something more like the will to exhaust. The will to exhaust yourself in the pursuit of your life, not the will to conserve and protect. **Nietzsche** is pointing out here that that ethos of 'security and safety for everyone'—well, yeah, because infants can't go forage in a field. They're not ready for adventure. There's a certain degree to which security and safety is a precondition, but it's not an aim. It's not a goal; it's a precondition.
- 7.50 Part of the reason you want to make your kids safe and secure is so that you can prepare them for the adventure of their life, and **Nietzsche** here is pointing to the danger of making that security and safety the end goal. That's the nanny state in its technocratic manifestation.
- 7.51 There's this great sculpture by **Michelangelo**, the Pietà, which he did when he was, like, 23. It's beyond comprehension. Such a brilliant piece of work. It's **Mary**, and she's sitting, seated, with the sorrowful look on her face. She has the body of **Christ** on her lap after he's been crucified. This young man, beautiful young man. And I think of that as the female crucifixion. It's the same idea because a mother has to offer her child to be broken by the world. That's what a mother has to do.
- 7.52 And so, the idea in the New Testament that God descends unto **Mary** and asks her if she will—what would you say—voluntarily accede to her destiny as the mother of the Savior is the **archetypal** situation of women. Every woman who is thinking about having a family asks herself, "Do I want to bring a child into a world like this? Is that the moral thing to do?" And now we've added an additional level of moral complication, which is, "Does the world really need another mouth to feed, or does the world really need another destructive consumer or potential oppressive patriarch?"
- 7.53 That's unbelievably demoralizing for women, pathological right to the core. But there's a real question at the bottom of that, which is, "Your children are going to be destroyed by the world. They're definitely going to suffer. And so, if you're going to serve the function of life, if you're going to bring new life into the world, you have to allow, maybe more than allow, that destruction to take place." You have to —what, do you have to encourage it? Do you encourage the sacrifice of the innocent to maintain life? Yeah. Well, the answer to that seems to be yes.
- 7.54 Courageous mothers make courageous children, and they provide them with security and safety to get them going, but not in the service of that. It's in the service of, well, **Nietzsche** would describe it as the **will to power**. You want, it's like, "Get out there. Get out in the world." It's like,

"The good mother"—the Freudians said this—"The good mother necessarily fails." That's her goal: to raise a child that no longer needs her, and that's also extremely painful for mothers.

- 7.55 You can see that when the child starts making the transition from being an infant to a toddler, or when a mother has a newborn, when she has a relatively young child, because she has to sacrifice that intensely tight bond of love that envelops and protects the child, and then, which is a remarkable and necessary thing, but it has to be destroyed in order for the child to continue to develop.
- 7.56 So, my daughter, when my son was about a year and a half old, my daughter was about three. We had taught my daughter to take good care of her brother, and we tried to help her understand that the loss she would experience at age one and a half—because her relationship with her mother was going to be disrupted—would be offset by the possibility of forming a new relationship with this new person and that there could be a gain there and a gain in terms of independence. Otherwise, if you don't manage that, you get sibling rivalry, especially with kids that are relatively close together, because a 1.5-year-old child still needs his or her mother quite a lot, so it's a tricky thing to manage.
- 7.57 So, we encouraged her to take care of Julian; we encouraged Mikhaila to take care of Julian. He started to walk around, and she kept calling him "baby." And we talked to her one day and said, "Julian isn't a baby anymore." This really bothered her, and then she had this crazy dream. She came and told me this dream when I was writing out this book, *Maps of Meaning*, that I wrote and published in 1999.
- 7.58 She said, "Julian went into the forest"—we had a forest nearby—"and a tree followed him home into our backyard. And the tree burnt down to the ground, and then it left a hole. The hole filled with water and Julian fell into the hole and turned into a skeleton. And a little bug went in the water, pulled out his skeleton. And then, when the skeleton came out onto the beach, it regenerated." That was the end of the dream.
- 7.59 I thought, "First of all, that's a hell of a dream for a 3-year-old." Well, they're ancient creatures, 3-year-olds; we're ancient creatures. And so, even though in her current form, so to speak, Mikhaila was only three, her being is ancient. Ancient.
- 7.60 That's why Plato believed that all learning was remembering, that you have to remember who you are. You forget that at the point of birth, and then your whole life is an attempt to remember who you are. You see that in *Lion King* when Simba is initiated. It's his father who appears in heaven and says, "Remember who you are." You're the son of the king. That's what you're supposed to remember.
- 7.61 Anyways, her dream—it was so interesting because her dream was a shamanic transformation dream. She was grappling with the fact that this thing she loved, the baby, which we had taught her to love, was—"What do you mean the baby is no longer a baby? It's like, I love this baby. What the hell's coming next?" Well, she didn't know how to cope with that. She didn't want the baby to go away.

- 7.62 And mothers are in that. Mothers are in that situation so much that the **Oedipal** mother wants the baby never to go away, and that's not good. And Mikhaila's imagination was toying with the idea that there are developmental periods where there's a death and a rebirth. There's a complete transformation of that which is. And that would be a descent into chaos, into the pool, to skeletal form, and then a reclothing, which is a re-emergence of a new form. That's part of the **Piagetian** stage transition. That's another way of thinking about it.
- 7.63 She had this remarkable dream that showed how her imaginative depths were processing this transformation. What she had to do is—she had to learn to have a new relationship with whatever **Julian** was now, which was a toddler, which isn't an infant, and she didn't know how to do that. There was some grief at the loss. And the thing is, there is grief.
- 7.64 My daughter-in-law took her son to daycare, and he was two and a half. Pretty social, and he was ready for it. When she brought him there the first day, for like an hour, he had a bit of a squawk because kids will when that's a big transition. And then, a mother who's not wise will draw that out like mad, and there's narcissism in that because "he needs me so much, and what if he isn't upset when he leaves me? What does that mean about our relationship?"
- 7.65 I've watched mothers do this. They'll hover on the edge of that departure and draw it out like mad. And then, the kid gets—do that like 40 times, and you have the kind of neurosis that can occupy you as a moral agent if you're a mother for the next 15 years. It's like, "My child's very fragile. I have to negotiate these transitions very carefully. It's pretty much all I can do." You have no idea how much narcissism there is in that. It's destructively appalling.
- 7.66 What my daughter-in-law did was leave, which is, you say goodbye. The inference is to the child, "Yeah, you're upset. You can handle this." It's like, "See you later, kid." No problem. And then, the kid's going to squawk a bit, and some kids more than others, but five minutes after the mother leaves—how much attention span does a kid have? They can't dwell in misery. They get distracted by, like, a passing butterfly, and then away they go.
- 7.67 She left right away, which is what she should do. Then, she went home and had a cry, which is exactly what she should have done. Not there. And she had something to cry about because that is a transition, that 'no longer a baby.' And if you really love your baby, then that's a loss. But what you gain, if you have any sense, you gain the independent being, and that continues to make itself manifest as the child develops. All of that is what Nietzsche's warning about here, all that horrible, bloody, god-awful, miserable, hellish **Oedipal** nightmare.
- 7.68 "What they would like to strive for with all their powers is the universal **green-pasture happiness** of the herd, with security, lack of danger, comfort, and an easier life for everyone." That sounds good—an easier life for everyone. It's like, "Is it really what you want?" Are you people here in this audience today because you want an easier life? Or is it because you're searching for something—I don't know what—something noble, something beyond the infantilized herd-like desire for comfort and an easier life? I don't mean you should go out of your way to make

people suffer stupidly, but certainly, with your children, what you want to confront them with is something like **optimized difficulty** rather than ease.

- 7.69 Now, **Vygotsky**, a great Russian psychologist, pointed out that when parents talk to their children, speak to their children—because children, almost all children, learn to talk—the parents speak to them at a level of complexity that slightly exceeds their current capability to understand. So, they can mostly understand, but they also develop their understanding because they're being challenged. A good conversation does that. A good lecture does that. You don't want to understand everything in a lecture. You want to understand 85% of it because the rest of it beckons you forward.
- 7.70 You're looking for something like an optimal challenge. That is not at all the same as security, lack of danger, comfort, and an easier life for everyone. **Dostoevsky**, writing at the same time in **Notes From Underground**, said, "Here's the problem with the socialist utopia: 'plenty for everyone.'" Imagine we set up a world where **Dostoevsky** says everyone could do nothing but "eat cakes and busy themselves with the continuation of the species."
- 7.71 He said, "We'll lie about in warm pools of water so that nothing but bubbles of bliss bubbled up to the surface." He said, "What would people do if you provided them with that?" He said that they would immediately go on a rampage and break everything that gave them that utopian comfort, just so something crazy and interesting could happen, just so they could have an adventure. And it's absolutely brilliant. **Notes From Underground**. A great adjunct to **Beyond Good and Evil**.
- 7.72 It's a devastating critique of this all-encompassing, quasi-maternal, comfort utopianism. It's like, "No, people are way too insane for that." Thank God for that. That isn't what we're like. We're built not for comfort, arguably, let's say, but for adventure. And that's a very different thing.
- 7.73 **Nietzsche** is pointing out, too, the danger of this alternate viewpoint not least because it tears down everything that's high that could serve as a judge that would—that would indicate to you your inadequacy because that's what a judge does. The thing about every ideal is a judge because if you have an ideal, it's not you. It's distant from you. And the distance between you and the ideal is felt as a judgment. You can't have an ideal without a judgment.
- 7.74 So then, you might say, "Let's tear down all ideals because why do we want people to feel judged?" One answer might be, "They should be judged because they're not all they should be." We don't want to get rid of the ideals. It's like, we're going to destroy the idea of beauty because everyone isn't beautiful? Well, for me, that's not worth the sacrifice. I know it's a pain—all of our inadequacies give us pain in relationship to the ideal.
- 7.75 One solution is, "Get rid of the inadequacy or be grateful or be humble." It's like, "Yeah, maybe you're not the world's most beautiful person, but there might be some other places where you're more capable of approaching the ideal." You have to have everything? You can't leave some ideal for some other people? That's a little greedy, wouldn't you say?

- 7.76 And then, also, without an ideal, nothing unites you, because you have no purpose that you can unite your will behind. You have no hope because you experience hope in relationship to an ideal. You have no real psychological security, because if you're not united, within yourself even, in pursuit of an ideal—"I don't know what to do with my life"—well, what are you? Hopeless, for sure, but you're also anxious. It's not as if when you don't know what to do, you're calm.
- 7.77 Right now, you may have an ideal that's difficult to pursue and feel judged, but no ideal means you're lost. Lost isn't good. It means anxiety. And so, without the ideal, that terrible judge, you're doomed to anxiety and hopelessness, and also to social disunity, by the way, because if we can't share an ideal, we can't inhabit the same space, not peacefully.
- 7.78 "With security, lack of danger, comfort, and an easier life for everyone; the two songs and doctrines which they repeat most often are 'equality of rights.'" Remember, this is written in, like, 1870? That's pretty damn good. "'Equality of rights' and 'sympathy for all that suffers'—and suffering itself they take for something that must be abolished."
- 7.79 You want to give the devil his due here. Well, "equality of rights" is not the same as equality of outcome. And equality of rights is reflective of something like universal recognition of the intrinsic dignity of the soul, and that's fine. And then, "Sympathy for all that suffers." Well, no sympathy for all that suffers? That's not the Nietzschean claim. The question of suffering is a real question. The proper stance towards that is, it's difficult to determine exactly what the proper stance towards that might be.
- 7.80 With children, the proclivity, in some ways, is to protect them from the suffering. Maybe your child's being bullied at school. What do you do? Do you keep them home from school? The answer to that is no because they're going to suffer more even if you do it. But you can imagine that might be a temptation. It might be a temptation to pity them as well. But it's also an opportunity. It is an opportunity to help your child determine what to do if they're being bullied.
- 7.81 I taught my kids to punch when they were very young, and to do that with a certain degree of force, and to discuss the conditions under which not only might that be necessary, but the conditions under which it might be required. And so, you don't want to protect your children from suffering. You don't want to protect clinical clients from suffering. First of all, good luck with that. What you want to do is encourage them to be the sort of people who can voluntarily take on their suffering.
- 7.82 And that's so interesting because that makes them braver, not more secure. It's way better to be braver than it is to be more secure, because good luck with security. You know perfectly well, in some fundamental sense, you'll lose everything. There's no security. You owe God a life. That's happening, and so you're stuck with that. So, with security, you can stave off that problem, but that hardly constitutes security. If you know death is lurking around the corner, it's not like you're secure. You're then faced with the problem, "How do you cope with that reality?"
- 7.83 The answer, to some great degree, is to confront it voluntarily. And then, that catalyzes a transformative process. We know this perfectly well from psychotherapy. Every school of

psychotherapy has figured this out. If you encourage people to voluntarily confront that which they are avoiding or disgusted by, say, in relation to a goal they want to pursue, you don't tell people to go out and play in traffic because they're afraid of it. But let's say you need to get somewhere, and you're afraid, and you're stopped. What do you do with that?

- 7.84** Well, sometimes you can reconfigure the goal, but more generally, what you do is get people to take the thing they're afraid of, reduce it in magnitude, and then confront it voluntarily at the rate they can manage. There's no difference between that and learning. Every time we set out to learn something, that's what we're doing. We're taking some fraction of the infinite that we have not yet mastered, reducing it to the point where it's still a challenge but not an overwhelming challenge, and then voluntarily facing it. That's the very pattern of adaptation itself.
- 7.85** You foster that in psychotherapy. You certainly do that with your kids, too. It's like, "Get the hell out there." And how much danger should you expose your child to? You'll wrestle with this when you have children, especially multiple children, because it varies with the child. Some kids—my son, for example, if you took him to the playground when he was a kid, he was like a puppy that you hold over water. They'll start moving their legs. He'd be moving his legs to run into the playground before you put them on the ground. It's like, "Zoom. Go on."
- 7.86** My daughter, who was no shrinking violet, by the way, would hover around us for a while and watch. Take a look at the playground. She was exposing herself in this graduated, incremental way. And then, she'd look more and more, and eventually, she'd go. It took her a little longer to propel herself out. You have to calibrate the rate at which you expose, well, anyone you love, yourself and your children, to the terrors of the world.
- 7.87** That's actually what you do when you form a relationship with them. You learn—you get to know the kid well enough to know where that edge is. And then, you put them on the edge all the time, or as much as they can manage. You do that with your partner too, and yourself. If you do it really well, if you do it really well, it's a brutally playful edge.
- 7.88** Men are good at this with kids when they wrestle with them. They always put them on the brutally playful edge. It's hard on women to watch that because men will throw the kids up in the air and catch them, hang them upside down by one foot, or spin them around and push them to the limits of their comfort. And what you're doing with a child is you're showing them the difference between what's dangerous and what's frightening by pushing them to the edge of fear.
- 7.89** It's like, "No, this is still fun." And you see where that edge is, where it's almost fear. That's where the most fun is. The kids get so excited that they can hardly—you can't do it for long because they get so excited that they get uncontrollable. So, it's a play that verges on the brutal, and the harder you push it, the more excited the kids get.
- 7.90** It's because it puts them in a place where they're manifesting this capacity for adaptive change as rapidly as it can be manifested. And so, it's so good for them when you teach the kid which

way they can bend, how far they can be moved, and how much physical force they can tolerate, and if they're wrestling with you, what the rules are for embodied interaction—like when you can't put your thumb in someone's eye, you can't put your fingers in someone's mouth, you can't take their glasses, you can't pull their hair, et cetera. They learn that, not in some abstract sense, but in an embodied sense.

- 7.91 Kids learn that a little bit when they're breastfeeding, too, because they have to learn right away, newborn, what the rules are for that intimate social interaction. And so, that's part of socialization that occurs very early.
- 7.92 "And suffering in itself they take for something that must be abolished." Well, first of all, good luck with that. And second, it sounds right. Abolish suffering. It's like, yeah, it's not so simple. You might say, "Do you want to suffer in a good cause?" Well, you might say, "I don't want to suffer at all." That's not going to happen. That's not a good solution. So then, is the only viable alternative something like suffering in a cause sufficiently noble to even justify the suffering? That would be the solution to the problem of life. You could say, "We struggle with the reality of our naked mortal vulnerability."
- 7.93 What are the conditions under which that could be justified? If you're an **anti-natalist**, you say, "The whole damn game is so corrupt, it would be better if you didn't bring new beings into existence." That's a **Mephistophelean** stance. When Goethe wrote **Faust**, the character **Mephistopheles**, a variant of the satanic spirit, let's say, basically justifies himself as the adversary of being, as Satan himself, by saying, "Look, the conditions of life are so intolerable. History, biology, nature, culture. It's so brutal, it's so intolerable, that it would be better if there was nothing at all." It would be more morally appropriate if there was nothing at all.
- 7.94 This injunction that's put upon us increasingly, that you shouldn't have children, or this fear that women and men have that it's immoral to bring a child into this world—it's the same idea. The idea lurking under that is the conditions of being are so intolerable that the whole game should be brought to a halt. And it's not a weak argument; it's a comprehensible argument because there's a lot of suffering.
- 7.95 But one of the problems with the argument is that if you act out that proposition, things get way worse. If you adopt an **anti-being** stance out of resentment and bitterness—**Mephistopheles** might say, "Well, I'm doing this because I'm empathic." It's like, "Yeah, you're not a saint. So, no." And so, the bitterness and resentment creeps in.
- 7.96 And my sense of the—there's an inevitable political consequence to that kind of **nihilism**, and it tends to involve genocidal massacre. And so, it's not a doctrine that ends well for those who adopt it or for those who are around those who adopt it, because that **anti-being** ethos manifests itself in **anti-being** actions.
- 7.97 Look, when the Nazis started their extermination campaigns, they started with people who were suffering in mental hospitals and people who were physically ill. The whole propaganda was all propaganda of compassion, and it was done extremely professionally in the mental hospitals of

the time. They were brutal. There was no psychiatric medication, and there were people who were manic and had to be in straitjackets all the time. And 'all the time' meant, like, for 15 years.

- 7.98 And so, it doesn't take much camera work in a ward full of people like that before you start thinking, "Maybe it would be better if—I would rather be dead than have that happen." And then, it's not that hard, having concluded that, that maybe the compassionate thing to do with people like that—we're moving towards that in Canada extraordinarily rapidly with this medically assisted death program that's been—30,000 people already—has been put forward. It's like, "Is the compassionate thing to do to stop the being, to kill?"
- 7.99 That was certainly the basis of the Nazi propaganda. You can find it online, part of the euthanasia campaigns that the Nazis put into place as they were ramping up towards the eventual genocide of the Jews. There was that, "These people are suffering so terribly; it's only the bad people that would object to them being mercifully killed." And then, that segues into, "Plus, they're a burden on the state."
- 7.100 It doesn't take much to move beyond that to "They're a detriment to the state" or "They're really enemies of the collective." Once you get there, it's like, "Look out, Jews," that's for sure. It's an open question, and this is the question Nietzsche is asking. It's like, "Suffering itself they take for something that must be abolished."
- 7.101 Well, you're the center of suffering. And maybe the simplest solution to the problem of suffering is to solve the problem of you. Death. No more suffering. And maybe not. Maybe that's too pessimistic a viewpoint, but the Freudian Oedipal nightmare is real, and there's a longing in it for the cessation of consciousness. The mother who holds her infant too close for too long is destroying their consciousness. And the purpose is the cessation of suffering.
- 7.102 Nietzsche's point here is that excessive compassion can be—it's more than murderous; it's anti-being. And that's a strange thing, especially for modern people to contemplate because—and this is something Nietzsche knew was coming, too—we identify compassion with God himself, essentially. It's the only unquestionable moral virtue—compassion.
- 7.103 Well, what about encouragement? Those aren't the same thing. Encouragement takes place in spite of compassion. "Get the hell out there. Take on your suffering. You can do it." Now, you could say that's a higher form of compassion. It's faith in what you could be rather than what you are.
- 7.104 I see that as the dichotomy between the maternal ethos and the paternal ethos. The maternal ethos is, "I love you the way you are," and I can understand the utility of that. But the paternal ethos is something like, "Yeah, you could use some sprucing up in five or six different directions." There's a harshness about that that Nietzsche is also a fan of, by the way, because the harshness is the judgment about your current state of being. But there's a meta-compassion in that, which is, "I know what you could be, and I'm on the side of that."

- 7.105** One of the things I loved about being a psychotherapist, kind of made this into an explicit contract with my clients, was—I told them, "I'm on the side of you that wants things to be better for you and everyone else." There's going to be a bunch of you that does not want things to be better. I'm not on the side of that part of you. That's not unconditional love, which is, say, what Carl Rogers suggested should be the proper basis of the psychotherapeutic contract.
- 7.106** I never bought that. The unconditional is, "I will listen to anything you have to say. We're not going to falsify your experience in the service of your development. You have a right to express all your doubts. But make no mistake about it. The goal here is: the best in me serves the best in you." And that was a relief to my clients because they knew that they were doing all sorts of things—some of them more than others—that were leading them down the path of abject misery. They wanted out of that.
- 7.107** It's such a good thing. It's a real lack in your life, terrible lack in your life, if you never have anyone on the side of you that's striving up. It's unbelievably useful. And so that's not the abolition of suffering; it's the formulation of a mode of being that ennobles suffering.

8. Views on Christianity

AT A GLANCE

Addresses Nietzsche's hostility to Christianity, which he identified with infantilizing compassion and slave morality's revenge on noble Rome. Argues that Nietzsche misread the crucifixion, missing its voluntary element and its inversion of sovereignty, in which the highest serves the lowest. Uses the Buddha, Simba, Chartres, Socrates' daemon, and Solzhenitsyn's refusal of victimhood to illustrate the heroic archetype that Jung later recovered. Warns of resentment allied with power in the French and Russian revolutions and the Holodomor, and closes with Nietzsche's praise of Greek gratitude and the Old Testament.

- 8.1 Now, Nietzsche believed that Christianity tilted towards this universal infantilizing compassion. That's really what made him a formal anti-Christian. That's complicated because, as I said, Nietzsche continually manifests admiration for the Old Testament stories. He doesn't seem to be a fan so much of the New Testament. But the reason for that is he identifies Christianity with this global infantilizing compassion.
- 8.2 It's an open question. Did the social justice movement of the 20th century, with its all-encompassing maternal compassion, emerge out of the Christian metaphysic? I think the answer to that is no. I think it's a perversion of the metaphysic, but Nietzsche thought that that was the basis of it. He identified Christianity with the slave morality that rails against fate, that justifies the moral pretensions of victimization, that wants to tear down the social order and anything of rank and difference, anything of quality and distinction. As I said, he identified that with Christianity.
- 8.3 "We opposite men, having opened our eyes and conscience to the question, where and how the plant 'man' has so far grown most vigorously to a height—we think that this has happened every time under the opposite conditions, that to this end the dangerousness of his situation must first grow to the point of enormity, his power of invention and simulation (his 'spirit') had to develop under prolonged pressure and constraint into refinement and audacity, his life-will had to be enhanced into an unconditional power-will."
- 8.4 Optimized challenge. Again, it's a doctrine of optimized challenge. And even more than that, it's like you should—within the confines of this developmental doctrine, the proper relationship and the proper quality would be one that pushes right to the edge of your limit. Right to the point of discomfort. Now, you know, if you go to the gym, for example, that unless you're pushing yourself to an edge, there's not sufficient necessity for transformation. You won't grow new muscle mass unless your current muscle mass is insufficient for the task at hand. Now, if you overdo it, well, you can tear yourself and hurt yourself and become too sore at minimum that you can't go to the gym.

- 8.5 You have to find that edge, but the edge isn't exactly an edge of comfort. It's an edge of **optimized discomfort**. That's what you're after as well when you're playing a game or any sport. You want to be playing against opponents that are pushing you maybe a little past your current limit. Then, you get into the zone, and you find out that your limits are less than you had presumed. That's a form of discovery. New possibilities within yourself reveal themselves to you. New physical capabilities, new modes of conceptualization.
- 8.6 It's not the same thing at all as an ethos of security. These are tricky things to get right because it's not as if the attraction of security doesn't beckon. You certainly feel that when you're tired, for example. "I just want to lay down somewhere safe and recover." You need that as well. But that's not—did you ever see the movie Wall-E? You remember in Wall-E, there was these spaceships that people were cruising around the galaxy, and they're all like 400-pound blobs on these carts that took them everywhere. That's the danger of being fed hand-to-mouth.
- 8.7 If everything's done for you, what's there for you to do? You might say, "I don't really want to do anything." It's like, "Yeah, that's the problem here." It isn't your empathy that's driving you to envision a world like that. It's this delusional infantile vision that you could have everything you needed and wanted without taking any responsibility on your part.
- 8.8 Technically, I would say, imagine there's a contribution to an ethos of compassion from agreeableness, from compassion itself. "I'm compassionate because I feel the pain of other people." Fair enough. "How much is your low conscientiousness contributing to that?" Do you want to be fed hand-to-mouth, and everyone else, too, not because it's so good for them or because you're compassionate, but because you're utterly unwilling to take any responsibility whatsoever for any of your own needs or wants?
- 8.9 You might even say, "So what? Why couldn't we give everybody what they needed and wanted?" The answer to that is, "It depends on your vision of man." If you think that a satisfied infant is the goal, then yeah, that's what we should do. But if you think that an adventurous hero is the goal, it's like, no, that's not a good vision at all. I think it's worth asking yourself this question for yourself.
- 8.10 If someone offered you that, both on a silver platter—you could have everything you needed and wanted for the rest of your life with no effort on your part, or you could have a magnificent, difficult adventure. A genie—first, choose carefully. It isn't obvious to me at all that the attractions of the first would outweigh the attractions of the second—not to anyone who wasn't already finished, already longing for death, in some real sense because if it's all comfort, why not just be asleep? That's what happens to you when you're sufficiently comfortable. Generally, you fall asleep.
- 8.11 Why? Well, why do you need consciousness? You could even say—**Erich Neumann** pointed this out in his book, **The Origins and History of Consciousness**, a great book. He summarized all of Jung's thought in one book, **The Origins and History of Consciousness**. Jung wrote the intro to that book and said as much in the intro. He basically regarded consciousness as the organ of

heroism. That's what it was. That's what it's for. That's what it does. And so, security? Blissful infantile unconsciousness.

- 8.12 That is the **Freudian** nightmare: the attraction the mother offers to the child, the overprotective mother. "It's okay if you're unconscious. I'll take care of you." Consciousness is only associated with apprehension of suffering. Don't look at things too clearly. Don't delve into things too deeply. Don't go out in the world too far. All you'll discover is suffering.
- 8.13 Like the **Buddha**. The **Buddha** leaves his castle built by his father to protect him from the world. Nothing in there is older, dying, or sick. Nothing. It's all he shielded from him. And as he grows, he becomes curious and goes outside the wall. That's where he encounters sickness, old age, and then death. And that blows his paradise. That's when the **Buddha** starts to wander around the world. His father has set up this walled city, paradise, Eden. Set up this walled city so that the **Buddha** will not be tempted into a life of religious contemplation when he could become an earthly king. That's the whole setup of the story of the **Buddha**.
- 8.14 And when the **Buddha** is—it's an interesting story because the walled city that's set up for him by his father does facilitate his development sufficiently so that he now wants to go outside the city. But then, he encounters the catastrophe of life, and that's what sends him on his religious journey. So, it's very much—the story is very much characterized by the same structure as the fall in the garden of Paradise. It's a very, very similar story.
- 8.15 "We opposite men, having opened our eyes and conscience to the question where and how the plant 'man' has so far grown most vigorously to a height—we think that this has happened every time under the opposite conditions, that to this end the dangerousness of his situation must first grow to the point of enormity, his power of invention and simulation had to develop under prolonged pressure and constraint into refinement and audacity, his **life-will** had to be enhanced into an unconditional **power-will**."
- 8.16 One of Nietzsche's propositions was that cultures that fostered nobility did that by maximally exposing their children to pressure and danger. The Stoics, for example, when they were creating warriors—can hardly even imagine in our culture what a culture would be like if its goal was to turn its children into warriors. That's so far from us that, well, our first response is, "That's just pathological to try to foster that spirit of cruelty and harshness in children." We can't even imagine that.
- 8.17 But then, the **Nietzschean** response to that would be, "Don't be so sure that's not a manifestation of your utter weakness." I'm more sympathetic to that claim because my sense, generally, is that if people make a high moral claim, I think the probability that you're the sort of person who has the right to make that high moral claim is very low. The probability that it's being motivated by something that's base on average is extremely high. A very small proportion of people have the right to make high moral claims.
- 8.18 You know that because to make a high moral claim and to justify it means you have to be as together as the claim. That's a real problem with the planetary saviors. "I'm really trying to save

the world." That's a Messianic claim. You really think you have the right to make that statement, do you? Under what authority? Exactly. And then, under what pretension? You're so sure that the spirit that animates you is the world-engendering spirit, are you? And not something underground and serpentine that's using you for its own purposes?

- 8.19 "We think that hardness, forcefulness, slavery, danger in the alley in the heart, life in hiding, stoicism, the art of experiment, and the devilry of every kind"—that's Nietzsche's romantic spirit —"that everything evil, terrible, tyrannical in man, everything in him that is kin to beasts of prey and serpents, serves the enhancement of the species 'man' as much as its opposite does."
- 8.20 Then you might think, too, so if you expose your children optimally to challenge, what do you catalyze within them? Well, a certain hardness, that's for sure, a certain degree of aggressiveness, a certain ability to stand up for themselves. Nietzsche's point here would be by obliterating the desire for security at any cost and by introducing the idea of **optimized suffering**, or maybe suffering even pushed slightly beyond that point, what you catalyze is the integration of these drives that would otherwise be regarded as evil. That's part of the **revaluation** of good and evil, **Beyond Good and Evil**.
- 8.21 Certainly, this is the case. I've seen this happen time and again in my psychotherapeutic practice. In **The Lion King**, the animators capture this so brilliantly because **Simba**, as an animated character, has a face like this. It's open; it's juvenile. He looks like this. And his father, who has the same physiognomy, looks like this. The authority is going out rather than the world being overwhelming and coming in. And when **Simba** is initiated by **Rafiki**, the baboon, he goes down into a pool and sees his own reflection, and then he sees that he's his father. His face changes. The animator switched the face. So, now he looks like an amalgam of juvenile **Simba**, who's out there with his idiot friends in the adolescent paradise, and his face hardens.
- 8.22 I used to see that in my clients all the time when they started to become assertive. They were juvenile to begin with. You could even tell by their speech patterns because they used uplifts. An uplift is when you talk like this, and every statement you make is actually a question, and it's juvenile because what you're doing is you're seeing if your utterances meet with the approval of the authority with whom you're speaking.
- 8.23 The less assertive people that were in my practice tended towards uplifts, and they had this open juvenile face. Maybe we would go through a year of strategizing about how they needed to confront their tyrannical boss, and then, one day, they'd come in, and their face had hardened. You could see it. I think what had happened was that the part of them that was aggressive, you could imagine that as a neurophysiological circuit, that possibility— because if you poked and prodded someone like that enough, they would get angry. That would come out of them, but it was not integrated. They'd be impulsively angry. You get that integrated into their personality; it changes the set of their musculature. It's that profound a transformation.
- 8.24 You can see, some people—you're intimidated by them as soon as you look at them, and it's because of the way they hold their gaze. They'll look at you. They don't look away. They're not

different. They don't crouch. They stand up. They occupy maximum space. There's all these subtle signals that are part and parcel of an embodied mode of being. You might say, "What catalyzes the development of that embodied mode of being that has that forthright confrontational characteristic?" Some of that is, well, it's fire and pressure that compels that out of you. You have to put yourself in a situation where you will fail unless that makes itself manifest.

- 8.25** There's a very old idea. In the Chartres Cathedral, there's a maze, a circular maze—north, east, south, and west. It's a huge circle inscribed on the floor of the cathedral, and it's a mock pilgrimage. Now, why would you go on a pilgrimage? You grew up in a village; you're a little village girl. What the hell do you know? Only a little bit of your personality has made itself manifest because you've been so constrained in your wanderings. You go on a pilgrimage. You walk 500 miles to the Holy City, and you have all sorts of adventures on the way. You're not the same person when you get there, and you're certainly not the same person when you come back. It's because now you've been everywhere and done everything, and that calls something out of you.
- 8.26** The circle, the maze, on the Chartres Cathedral floor is a symbolic representation of that. You enter in the south, and then you walk through every quadrant because it's a maze. Every quadrant, every step of the way, you go everywhere there is to go. And then, when you're done, you're at the center. That's the center of the cross, and that's the center of the cathedral, and that's the sacrificial center of the town, and that's the sacrificial center of the community, the state, all of that, that Christendom, so to speak. You get to the center by going everywhere you can, by hitting yourself against all the corners of the world.
- 8.27** You know this if you ever have a puppy. What you do with a puppy, if you don't want to have an insane dog, is you take it everywhere. You socialize it. You take it to meet other dogs and other people. You take it out in the traffic, and you expose it to everything on that edge of development. That's exactly what you're supposed to do with your children. If you want them to be able to thrive anywhere, you have to take them everywhere. That's going to catalyze their development away from you as a dependent being.
- 8.28** This is also why—this idea of the emancipation of women, which Nietzsche actually has some qualms about, seems to me exactly appropriate because the right message from a woman to her child is, "I love you a lot, but I have some things to do." Adults have some things to do. They're adult things, they're important, and lots of the time, they take priority. "If you're in trouble, fair enough, but if I'm busy, leave me the hell alone."
- 8.29** Now, in order to do that, you have to be doing something important. And women tear themselves up about this, especially once they have kids. It's like, "I'm so conflicted by my career versus my children. I never feel that I can get them both right." This is a real problem because it's a full-time job to have kids, and it's a full-time job to have a full-time job. And it's hard to mediate that morally.

- 8.30 But first of all, you think, look, your job isn't to make the kid happy. Your job is to make the kid into an adult. They're going to spend most of their life as an adult, not as a kid. The goal isn't kid —although the goal might be an adult who rediscovers what they lost in childhood. That's a more sophisticated idea. That doesn't mean they should remain children. So, you need to model competent adulthood.
- 8.31 A lot of the time, that's going to mean, "Kid, go play by yourself. I've got things to do." Then, the kid looks up and thinks, "Adults have important things to do." And they're really happy about that because they're going to be adults. They're going to squawk about it because kids want attention all the time, generally speaking, but they want to see that there's a barrier there because it indicates to them that adulthood is the goal and that it's better to be an adult than a child, and that even if you're a mother and a loving mother, there are things that adults are doing that are so crucial that that should be the primary focus.
- 8.32 So, I think, as a woman, you can have your cake and eat it, too. And I think that's far better for your kids. The best predictor of childhood educational status—eventual—is IQ first. You can predict the IQ of a child by taking the IQ of the mother and the father and averaging them and subtracting a little bit if it's high and adding a little bit if it's low. So, there's a heavy biological component, but there's a cultural component.
- 8.33 But there's no effect of father education on the educational attainment of the child, only maternal education. We don't know why. No one knows why, but it's quite a striking finding. And so, it's extremely useful, I believe, even if you want to optimize the relationship between a mother and child, that you open the doors of opportunity as broadly as possible to women to take their place as fully functional adults in the complex economic community. It's better for the children, too, for the women to have their cake and eat it, too.
- 8.34 I think that's where the moral mediation takes place. You can do a great job as a mother by not doing too great a job as a mother. It shouldn't be all you are. The problem is, if it is all you are, and for lots of women, that's extraordinarily attractive because they might be a little cynical about having kids to begin with, but once they have a kid, they think, "Oh, man, I like this kid way more than I thought I would."
- 8.35 I've seen this with so many women, even ones who've had spectacular careers. They come back after six months, after having a baby, and they say, "I had no idea how important this would be. It's way more important than anything I've ever done on the career front." These are people with high-end careers, and that's the right response. But if you don't have that, and the child now is everything because that's where you found your identity, it's really easy to fall into that Oedipal trap.
- 8.36 If you don't have your own life, why are you going to let your children grow up? Because they actually need you. They've given your life significance in the most fundamental sense, and it's certainly possible that you won't be willing to let that go. You have to ask yourself, "Under what conditions am I willing to relinquish my children?" And one of those has to be, "You have some

things to do with your partner and with your own life." You don't want to be guilty about that. It's something you should do.

- 8.37 "What is Religious?" Part three. This is part of Nietzsche's anti-Christian criticism. "Modern men, obtuse to all Christian nomenclature, no longer feel the gruesome superlative that struck a classical taste in the paradoxical formula 'god on the cross.'"
- 8.38 I really think this is where Nietzsche goes really quite substantially sideways. I don't think he got it. He didn't get it. He missed something important. Jung figured that out in the intervening 80 years. Nietzsche's objection is this. He really is an admirer of the classical world and its elevation of what is noble. And then, he believed that slave morality subjugated what is noble to what is most base, and that would be for him symbolized by the crucifixion, the notion that the highest is now the most abased. He interpreted that as a vengeful victory of the slave.
- 8.39 But it's not. It's the introduction of a paradox. It's a furtherance of the investigation by the human spirit into the true nature of sovereignty. What's the true nature of sovereignty and power? This is acted out in the Gospels when Christ washes his disciples' feet because the feet are base, especially in those archaic cultures. The idea, then, is that one of the things that's intrinsic to what is truly sovereign and noble is the willingness to elevate that which has not yet been elevated. It's something like that. It's working on behalf of that which has not yet attained its final form; it's serving that.
- 8.40 That's the same as serving the poor and the alienated, not because of sympathy for their victimization. That's not the idea. It's that there is much yet there that has not been made fully manifest, and the goal is to serve that in a manner that can make it manifest. You don't educate poor children in the third world because you're sorry for them. You educate them because you think, "How many Michelangelos are there there? How many Einsteins are there there?" Or, on a slightly less grand level, "How many great fathers and mothers that are languishing in the realm of potential because they don't have the opportunity to fulfill that potential?"
- 8.41 Then, what's sovereign becomes the willingness to serve that elevating principle. Nietzsche criticizes that as something like compassion gone wrong in enmity against what's noble. And fair enough, because there is this strain of pathological compassion that has this proclivity to only tear down. But I believe Nietzsche overgeneralized. Dawkins and Harris, these famous atheists, the reason they're atheistic in part is because they identify the religious enterprise with the totalitarian spirit. They don't distinguish them. It's obviously the case that there's no shortage of manifestation of the totalitarian spirit within especially corrupt religious practice. That's what a totalitarian theocracy is, precisely that.
- 8.42 But if you're a sophisticated thinker, you think the totalitarian spirit manifests itself all over. It's not—what would you say—reducible to the religious. It's like, what about the bloody communists? Which is often where the atheist types really hit a wall. They say, "They were atheists." "Well, not really. It's like a full religion." It's like, "Yeah, well, have it your way." It's still a thorny problem.

- 8.43 See, the other thing about the cross that I think Nietzsche missed is that there's a voluntary element to it. When the guards come for Christ in the garden of Gethsemane, they don't know what he looks like. And so, they ask where he is. And he says, "Here I am." And they all fall to the ground. Why? It's because he knows they're going to cart him off to his death, his torture and death. He doesn't hide from any of it.
- 8.44 That's the injunction. It's not to hide from any of it, and, worse, to accept it voluntarily. That's worse. Or even worse than that, to accept it with what? With resignation and joy? Well, how do you want to face your death? It's a lot to ask because you could certainly imagine that you have every reason to face your death with fear and trembling, and you're not going to be able to avoid that to some degree. But if you could optimize it, do you think you could have that much courage? Maybe the answer is yes. Maybe you should, and maybe that's what you should strive for.
- 8.45 I saw this very interesting triptych in Australia in an Orthodox cathedral, and it was Christ standing on this hill upon which the cross was mounted. He was pointing to it, inviting people. I thought, "I'd never seen an image like that." I tried to think through, "What exactly does that mean?" That's your destiny one way or another: a certain amount of torture, a certain amount of betrayal, a certain amount of disappointment, a certain amount of innocent suffering, and certainly death. That is definitely coming your way. Well, is that an invitation? Oh, my God, that's a remarkable way to reconceptualize it. That is at the core of this Christian axis around which the whole Western world turned 2,000 years ago. It's a revaluation of that notion and an invitation to the deadliest game.
- 8.46 Nietzsche, as I said, regarded that as the triumph of slave morality over this former noble view that was more characteristic of the classical world. There is a strain of Western, Protestant, liberal thought that tends towards that overarching destructive compassion. It's an open question how much of that is rooted in the Christian ethos, but I think it's a corruption of the ethos and not a manifestation of its central spirit.
- 8.47 "Never yet and nowhere has there been an equal boldness in inversion, anything as horrible, questioning, and questionable as this formula: it promised a revaluation of all the values of antiquity." Well, it did, and I don't think Nietzsche gives the devil his due here either because, in Rome, it's not this simple. The Romans were reasonably sophisticated, but essentially, those who had the power were those who were moral. It's like, "If I can impose my will on you—" Nietzsche is very ambivalent about this because he does worship this to some degree.
- 8.48 That is part of what tangled up his thought with the proto-Nazi movement. His sister warped his thought, but there are seeds in Nietzsche that allowed that warping to take place. Some of this was this worship of will to power and confusion about what power is. Nietzsche believed that the spirit of domination, the noble spirit of domination, was massively preferable to slave morality.

- 8.49 What Christianity called into question, most particularly, was the notion that might meant right, even in terms of works. Let's say you're rich. "I'm rich because God smiled on me. God smiled on me because I'm moral. The fact that I'm successful is an indication of the fact that I'm moral and that God smiled on me." The Christians said none of that. That's not an acceptable doctrine. They separated the notion of sovereignty from the notion of power. Nietzsche is concerned about that because he believes that that introduces some confusion about the value of what's noble compared to what is base. But I think he overgeneralized. But in any case, it is an inversion. The idea that what's most truly sovereign voluntarily serves that which is lowest. But you know that. You know this is true.
- 8.50 Look, there's a huge anthropological literature on elders. If you're a patriarchal theorist, you think, "Elders are the most dominant and oppressive members of the patriarchal society, the old men who have all the power." But that isn't how you get to be an elder in a traditional society. No one elects you. You don't run for office. And no one goes and asks the tyrant for advice. They might go in trembling to the tyrant to find out what they have to do, but that's not the same thing. The elders are those people that everybody goes and asks for advice.
- 8.51 Who do you ask for advice from? Who do you admire spontaneously? Well, here's the formula. Productive people who are generous. So, if you're really productive and you're really generous, well, people are going to admire you, and they're going to be the people who are sought out for advice, and those are the people who are elevated to the position of elder. So then, you have the dawning awareness that if you're a good man, you're going to take care of yourself. That's the least. Don't go live on the street. That's not good enough. In a tent, you can't take care of yourself. That's not good enough. You have to at least take care of yourself. And then, you might think, "Is that enough?" The answer is no. You know that by the way you respond to people.
- 8.52 Who do you admire? Well, it's someone who can take care of themselves, and then, if there was something left over or even more left over, to take care of some other people, maybe a wife or a husband, some children, that'd be good, maybe a bit of an extended family, maybe the community to some degree or even to some great degree. You admire people whose productive generosity is overflowing. You only need to be productively generous in some sense to people who have less because the people who don't have less, well, you don't need to take care of them. They're all off there taking care of themselves. Maybe you can enter into reciprocal arrangements with them, but you don't have to take care of them.
- 8.53 So, we already have this notion, instantiated in our sense of admiration itself, that people whose boundless productive generosity overflows are admirable. And so, we're striving towards this. It's something like an ethos of productive self-sacrifice. It's worth thinking about because the Christian notion—and this is embedded in Jewish thinking as well—is that you sacrifice to what is highest, which means you work towards an end. Those are the same statement. It means exactly the same thing.
- 8.54 "What's the highest?" "Well, it is something like service to others." "Which others?" Well, this is where the lefties have it right in a very warped manner. "It's to the dispossessed, to the

outsiders, to those who haven't been gathered in." But it's not based on pity. It's not based on this desire to infantilize. It's not even based on this desire to take care of. It's more like the desire to foster the growth of. If you have a great boss, it's not that he pays you a lot of money, although that might be helpful, or that he takes care of you; it's that he teaches you how to stand on your own feet.

- 8.55 One of the things that's very interesting about this, and also a reason why people should be grateful about the patriarchal culture when it's functional, is—my graduate advisor, Robert Pihl: I loved working with him. Bob's fundamental joy in life—clearly, he's a good father, he was a good clinician, and a good scientist—but his fundamental joy in life was mentoring. He loved finding young people and opening up opportunities for them, and he was really good at it. That wasn't a secondary pleasure. It was a primary pleasure, and it's definitely the case.
- 8.56 You can ask yourself this. Just think it through. See if you think it's true. You do something for someone. It takes a little work. It's a sacrifice. They come to you and say, "Look, that thing you did, it really helped me. Here's how. It made me a better person." So, it's the gift that keeps on giving. You'll go away from that glowing if you—if you don't, it's mere resentment. You're so cluttered up that you can't see it. But if you're not, you'll think, "Oh, there's nothing better than that. There's literally nothing better than that."
- 8.57 And so, this notion that the highest should serve the lowest is a call to that mode of life, a generous mode of life. It's a **will to power** mode of life in the **Nietzschean** sense. It's the expression of your capacity. It's the exhaustion of your capacity in the service of the world. There's nothing more deeply meaningful than that. There's nothing that sets the scales right better than that. There's nothing that gives you more armament against suffering than that.
- 8.58 If you're generous and productive, you're going to build a community. And if you stumble and fall, you'll have a community. Maybe you're going to need it then. And if you've established the genuine basis of a community, then that community will be there for you when you need it. It's partly what you do in a marriage because each of you is going to stumble and fall, and both of you sometimes at different times. You want to build a structure that allows you—it's an arc that gets you through the troubled times. It requires a tremendous amount of commitment and building of trust so that when the storms come, the trust isn't violated. It has to be a deep trust. It's not some metaphysical abstraction. It's literally what will save you when the horrors of life come knocking.
- 8.59 "It is the Orient, deep Orient, it is the Oriental slave who revenged himself in this way on Rome and its noble and frivolous tolerance, on the Roman 'catholicity' of faith. It has always been not faith, but the freedom from faith, that half-stoical and smiling, unconcerned with the seriousness of faith, that enraged slaves in their masters—against their masters."
- 8.60 **Nietzsche** believed that Christianity really was a slave rebellion. I also don't think—that's not an accurate reading of the historical reality. Out of Judaism, Christianity emerged. The Jews weren't slaves. They were oppressed by the Romans. Welcome to the club; everyone was oppressed by

the Romans. But they weren't slaves. The Jews put up a pretty good scrap against Rome. The Romans were not happy with the Jews for a very long time. They crucified a lot of them right along the Appian Way—an absolutely brutal takedown of the Jewish rebellions. The Jews weren't exactly slaves.

- 8.61 So, they were more—they were people of the Book, and they eventually killed Rome with the Book, which is really something to think about. If you think about Christianity as an offshoot of the Jewish prophetic tradition, which is a perfectly reasonable way of reading it, the damn Jews wiped out the Roman Empire. That's really something. And they did it with a book. Well, it wasn't just a book, but that's quite something. And it didn't take that long by—what was it—year 400, something like that, you have the first cathedral in the rebuilt Jerusalem. And then, Constantine is a Christian. It's hard to see that as anything but a miracle. It's definitely the triumph of the lowest over the powerful.
- 8.62 It's the same thing that Solzhenitsyn did in relationship to the communists, to the Soviets, because he was as ruined as a person could be—terrible health problems, cancer in these terrible, brutal gulag wards. He had to hide his pencil. You couldn't imagine anyone with less power than Solzhenitsyn. He'd been victimized, that's for sure, by the two greatest tyrants in human history. He was on the World War II front when Hitler invaded the Soviet Union. What a conundrum for you. You're going to fight for Stalin, or are you going to fight for Hitler? What a choice that is.
- 8.63 What happened to Solzhenitsyn is he got crushed between both of them. So, if anyone ever had a case to be made for truly being a victim of the tyrants of history, while the Russians in general were, certainly Solzhenitsyn was one of them, but he didn't construe himself as a victim. Even after being imprisoned by Stalin for notes that he sent on the Western front, criticizing the Soviet lack of preparedness, they threw him into a prison camp, and he was there for a very long time and utterly powerless, facing starvation, worked three-quarters to death, froze almost to death like many people were.
- 8.64 Instead, under those terrible conditions of privation, he memorized this book, like 2,000 pages long, marshaled his arguments, and published that in 1970, and dealt a death blow to the intellectual integrity of the entire utopian radical left-wing movement. It's miraculous, and it's a testament to the power of the refusal of victimization, even under those conditions where you'd say, "Yeah, yeah. Stalin, Hitler—tyrants for sure. How would you construe yourself as anything other than a victim?" And Solzhenitsyn thought, "No. If I have the truth on my side, I'm not a victim." More than that, "To the degree that I have the truth on my side, I cannot be made into a victim," certainly not by tyrants, because in the final analysis, they're actually weak because they don't have reality and the spirit of reality itself. They don't have that on their side. Quite the contrary.
- 8.65 In the Book of Exodus, God tells the Jews that if they abide by his law, they'll be unstoppable unto their enemies. It's pretty bloodthirsty because, in those books, the narrative unfolds the catastrophe that awaits the Canaanites, for example, if they encounter the Jews. But the idea

lurking underneath is that if you're aligned with the—what would you call it—the glorious animating spirit of mankind, that productive, generous ethos that's at the core of any valid culture, you're literally and metaphorically unstoppable even if you die. Do you believe that? Well, it's a rough one to think through.

- 8.66 When Socrates was facing death, the Athenians didn't really want to kill him. They just wanted him to go away. So, they said, "We're going to try you six months from now, hint, hint. And if you're still around, hint, hint, we're going to kill you." And so, the notion was, "You're a troublemaker. It'd be convenient for us and good for you if you left." So, Socrates thought about this, and all his friends said, "Look, it's time to hit the road, Jack."
- 8.67 Socrates went out, and he said in his *Apologia*, which was his defense at his trial, this is where he recounted this story, said, "Look, the Delphic Oracle herself has said that I was the wisest man in Greece." That was really something for the Greeks because that was the center of their religious ethos, and for the Delphic Oracle to identify you as the wisest person, she was right. That was the Delphic Oracle. He said he tried to puzzle that out and thought, well, he was the wisest man because he knew he didn't know anything. There's humility in that. Socrates was always searching for enlightenment, which is why he used the Socratic method.
- 8.68 He also said, "One of the things that distinguishes me from other people is I have this daemon inside me." It's a spirit. That's a way of thinking about it. It's conscience. That's the way modern people think about it. It's the voice of conscience. He talked to the voice of conscience all the time, to his daemon. And he said, "I always do what it tells me to do, no matter what. I swore that I would do that." That's the spirit of truth. That's another way of thinking about it. "That's what's made me different from other men."
- 8.69 That's worth thinking about because that was Socrates who said that. Was there a more influential person in history? Buddha, Christ, Socrates. That's pretty much—it's those three. He wasn't a religious leader, so even for people who are atheistic, Socrates is a major player. No one disputes the fact that he existed. So, Socrates is someone worth paying attention to as the father of philosophy and maybe of thought itself.
- 8.70 "I always paid attention to this voice. I always did what it told me to do, no matter what." He said, "I went and had a conversation with my daemon when I was sentenced, and it said, 'Don't run away.'" And he said, "I thought, what do you mean, 'Don't run away?'" They're telling me to run away, and they're going to kill me. I'm still teaching people. I'm not that old. What do you mean, 'Don't run away?'" "No, don't run away." And so, he said, "Well, I'm not running away." Then, he said, "And I revalued my presumptions."
- 8.71 He said, "Look, I'm at the prime of my life here, and I have an impeccable reputation, apart from these people that are trying to take me out. I'm someone who's been esteemed for my wisdom and clarity of thought, and I'm starting to get old. That means, perhaps, the degeneration of my ability and the descent into feebleness, and God only knows what sort of catastrophe. Now, I'm being offered this opportunity, which is to put my affairs in order, to say what I have to say to

my enemies, to make a last statement to my friends, and to face my departure voluntarily and simply. Maybe it's a gift."

- 8.72 That's the presumption upon which he proceeds. And then, he goes to trial. It's worth reading the *Apologia*. It's very short. It's a remarkable document. There's two variants of it, two court reporters who were there. I think *Aristophanes* is the other one. It's so interesting because then *Socrates* flips the trial around. Now he's not afraid of the—he knows what the jury, the verdict, is going to be. That's foregone.
- 8.73 So, he goes from jurist to jurist and says, "Here's some things I know about you and the relationship between you and your drunken suicidal son. This is why he's a suicidal drunk, and that's on you." And then, he goes to the next person and does the same thing. And you think, "It's no wonder they wanted to kill him." But he flips the tables. It's really something to read.
- 8.74 It's written in a very clear style. You can really see yourself there. And then, he bows out gracefully, having won, in all intents and purposes. It's thousands of years later, and here we are discussing this story. It's not obvious at all that he didn't win even though he died. That's a tough one. Can you win even though you die? Well, you'll spend your whole life figuring that out. That's really what your life is; it's figuring that out.
- 8.75 "'Enlightenment' enrages: for the slave wants the unconditional, he understands only what is tyrannical in morals, too, he loves as he hates without nuance to the depths." Part of what *Nietzsche* is trying to delineate here, and he had an inkling of what was coming, is just because you're victimized doesn't mean you're moral.
- 8.76 There's an injunction that's so cool in the Book of Exodus. I believe it's in the Commandments, but if it isn't—no, it's in the laws. Imagine there's a poor man who has a complaint against a rich man in a trial. Now, one proclivity would be to take the side of the rich man and ally yourself if you were a jurist with power. But the other proclivity would be to say, "The poor man's poor and victimized, and the rich man has all these advantages. Why don't we tilt the scales of justice in the favor of the poor?" That's really the social justice claim, by the way, and that's expressly forbidden in the Jewish law.
- 8.77 You are not to distort the cause of justice in the service of those who are poor, and neither the rich, and so that's a principle of superordinate law. It's a remarkable moral accomplishment, a permanent moral accomplishment, that the poor have just as much right to justice as the rich. That's a bloody miracle that anybody ever thought that up. But the reverse, too: that the rich have just as much right to justice as the poor. That is a proposition that's being seriously called into question in the modern world, where the whole social justice ethos is clear. It's restorative justice.
- 8.78 It's like, "No, no, if you're poor, no matter what's happened to you because you're a victim, you're justified, and what justice means is restoration to you, regardless even of what you've done." It's immoral to claim anything other than that, and that's sweeping across the United States at the moment like a plague. That did happen in Russia, especially during *dekulakization*,

when the ethos was, if you were rich, well, because it's all power, all that richness that you've gathered—and these were, like, these **kulaks**, these successful farmers that were killed by the thousands—they were peasants. They were serfs, like, in 1860. It's only 50 years later.

- 8.79 So, these were serfs who struggled out of the muck over three generations and maybe had a house and a cow or two and a bit of land, and maybe could hire someone to work on the farm. Then, imagine these horrible little towns in Russia where there's five or six people like that. All the good people admire them and wish that there were more of them because they produce all the food. But then, there's the resentful and bitter ones who have nothing and drink themselves half to death bitterly in the local tavern and who are gloating away about how obviously all these successful people are nothing but thieves and scoundrels because that justifies their own lack of usefulness to themselves.
- 8.80 Then, the goddamn intellectuals come parading into town with their idiot communism, and they find these bitter and resentful people and say, "You know those people that you think are thieves?"—so conveniently for you— "they actually are thieves. If you had one bit of morality in you, you'd lead an uprising, and you'd go take everything they stole and distribute it to those who are in need, wink, wink, one of them being you."
- 8.81 So, now you have this mob scene where the worst people in town are leading the mob and they show up at the door of the successful farmer. Then, the peasants who have any sense ring the house of the successful farmer, trying to fight off the mob. But no, the mob has the support of the new emergent state, and they go in there and destroy everything. They steal everything. They demolish the house. If they don't rape the wife, which they do, they pack off the whole family into a bloody train cart and cart them to the middle of Siberia where there's nothing and leave them to die of typhoid or freeze. That happens to hundreds of thousands of successful farmers.
- 8.82 And then, what happens? One year later, you have the **Holodomor** and six million people die of starvation. What's the communist response to that? You're a mother. Your children are literally dying of starvation. You've been collectivized. You do not have a farm. It is your job to take every bit of grain there is, to gather it up, and to ship it to the cities. Fine. So then, you think, "Okay, fair enough. Here's all our food, and even though our children are starving, I'm going to go out into the field"—the mother—"and pick up the grains of wheat that the harvesters missed, to go out there and glean this dirty grain that's trampled into the dirt." You imagine how much work it would take to generate a meal out of that.
- 8.83 That's a capital offense. You get shot for doing it. You certainly get shot if you don't turn over what you've gleaned to the state. You think, "Is there an attempt to free the people from the predations of the capitalist overlords, or is there just this unbelievable desire to kill everyone of any use in any manner you can possibly imagine, and then to do something even worse, which would be to punish maternal sacrificial behavior in service of the utopian state. That's like Ukraine for most of the 1930s.

- 8.84 So brutal. You can't even imagine it, not without permanent damage. It's something. And then, to understand that no one in the West knows anything about this. It's not like our kids are taught this in school. It's just, "Oh, well, that was utopia. It went a little wrong there. We'll—don't have to draw attention there. It was only six million people." That was just the beginning.
- 8.85 "Nor was skepticism concerning suffering, at bottom merely a pose of aristocratic morality, the least cause of the origin of the last great slave rebellion which began with the French Revolution." I actually like that phrase a lot, and this is why Nietzsche is such a difficult thinker.
- 8.86 There is a stream of French thought, and I do believe it had its first true tyrannical manifestation in the French Revolution: this slave morality rebellion, this desire to overturn the social order based on the Rousseauian notions that we've already described, this inversion of the social order and its Luciferian intellect at its highest manifestation of pretension, which is exactly what you'd expect from French intellectuals, by the way, and the same ones who trained Pol Pot before he went back to Cambodia and killed one-third of the people who lived there by emptying out the cities, which were just parasites on the state, which is what he was taught at the Sorbonne by these same French intellectuals steeped in this revolutionary French tradition. Absolutely appalling.
- 8.87 There's this intellectual pretension. It's the elevation of rationality and its alliance with a pseudo-compassion. That's what Nietzsche is aiming at here in his criticism of slave morality. He's got something there. We see that flowering again with the dawn of Postmodern thinking and its alliance with the Neo-Marxists. The Postmodernists were influenced by Nietzsche to a great degree because they're looking underneath the story to see what the true motivations are. And they know that the philosophy is a story. The Postmodernists also figured that out. It's a major accomplishment, an intellectual accomplishment, that philosophy and knowledge itself is narrative in structure.
- 8.88 But then, they do two things that are very strange. One is that they say, "There's no master narrative. There's no centralizing narrative. There's no meta-narrative." Skepticism about meta-narratives is one of the defining characteristics of Postmodernism. It's like, "Yeah, but there's no uniting narrative? At any level? There's no uniting narrative for you? There's no uniting narrative for you and your wife about your family?" Like, if you're skeptical about narratives, meta-narratives, when does the narrative become a meta-narrative?
- 8.89 Are you skeptical about all narratives? You might say, "Yes." It's like, "Where does that leave you then? Because without the narrative, you have no goal and no hope because there's no hope without a goal." And you have nothing but confusion because, without a narrative, you have no direction, which the Postmodernists also know.
- 8.90 So, when you're skeptical about meta-narratives—that's why diversity is so important—it's like, "Is it infinite multiplicity?" Well, that's what it looks like because we're bound hand and foot now to worship endless multiplicity. It's like, "There's a problem with that because there's no unity in multiplicity." "Then, it's peace." It's like, "No, it's not." It's not the state of nature

reinstated with some **Rousseauian** view. It's the **Hobbesian** nightmare. If there's nothing that unites us, then there's nothing that unites us, man. It's every man against every other man and every man for himself.

- 8.91 Then, you get the doctrine of power. It's so weird to see the **Postmodernists** do this, to claim lack of allegiance to any **meta-narrative** and then to jump right into Marxism and say, "Yeah, it's all about power. That's the only uniting narrative." It's like, "Which is it?" No uniting narrative or power? And if it's the uniting narrative, why is it power? "Well, just look at the whole course of human history." It's like, "You really think the defining marker of the relationship between men and women throughout history has been power?"
- 8.92 It's so funny. I told this woman who interviewed me, **Helen Lewis**. She said that that's what she believed, that the defining ethos was even between men and women. "Marriage is a patriarchal institution." I said, "Good luck in your relationships with that." She said, "My relationship is doing perfectly fine," and was divorced one year later. Surprise, surprise. I was right. Well, if that's what you believe, look, if you have a relationship, it will be contaminated with power, some of which you'll express in your female way and some of which your partner will express in his male way. When you guys wander off the path, your relationship will be predicated on power. And that'll be a problem. It'll be something you always have to look out for.
- 8.93 That problem is a deviation from the central ethos. And so, look, think about the story of romance. That's not a story of power. It's a story of mutual voluntary attraction. And then, it's the story of the dance, and maybe it's the story of the playful erotic dance. And you could say, "That's the unifying spirit of an intimate relationship." It's the playful erotic dance, and when that degenerates into power, then that fractures that ethos and it's a constant problem.
- 8.94 But that isn't the same as to say—to note that the most potent force of corruption is the attraction of power. It's not the same claim as that's the central ethos of a relationship or the only ethos of a relationship. And then, as a good psychoanalyst, I always think, so you think it's all about power, do you? Why am I not to presume that's a confession? You're telling me the way you view the world. And are you one of these people who can say it's all about power and then not turn to power? I don't think so because you'd have to be quite the saint to manage that. And if you were glowing while you were sitting there, I might think, "You're a saint," but otherwise, I'm not going to go down that road.
- 8.95 And then, I think, "Why make the claim that it's power?" How about because it justifies your power? And then, I might think, "Why do you make that claim to begin with?" "It's because you're resentful." **Nietzsche** was a great student of resentment and knew it was the most pathological of political forces. It's like, "Yeah, you want to harbor power to justify your revenge against your resentment."
- 8.96 Well, I don't want to play with you. That's a really bad game because you have a moral justification for your tyranny. "Of course you're a tyrant. You were victimized. You should be a tyrant." The person you want to be away from the farthest is the person who thinks that they

have a moral case for being a tyrant. Look, if you're just an exploitative tyrant, that's the typical male criminal. It's like, "Up yours. I'm going to take what you have." It's like, "I can understand you. I have what I want, and you want it. We agree on a lot." But if I'm playing with someone who says, "No, no. I've been victimized. I'm hurt and because of that, I'm owed something, and now my tyranny has no bounds." You can't imagine—at worst, that's the totalitarian nightmare. If you're trying to figure out why 100 million people were sacrificed to the great god of the Communist state in the 20th century, it's the alliance of power with resentment and envy. Man, nothing more toxic than that.

- 8.97 Nietzsche is pointing out the emergence of a spirit, that same spirit, well, in France. Marx's Communist Manifesto was written right during this period. I think it's 1860. So, that spirit is making itself manifest, and Nietzsche is seeing that, and he's seeing its emergence out of Christianity. Like I said, I think he overgeneralizes on that front. But it's not like he didn't have a sense of what's coming.
- 8.98 "What is amazing about the religiosity of the ancient Greeks is the enormous abundance of gratitude it exudes: it is a very noble type of man that confronts nature and life in this way." It's such a lovely statement. So, if you conceptualize trust—we talked about this yesterday in a sophisticated way—you can start to think about it as a form of courage. It's like, "I know you're trouble, but our best bet is to move forward in courageous trust." And so, that transforms the world, that courageous trust.
- 8.99 Nietzsche is making the same case here about gratitude. Gratitude isn't an attitude that you adopt. It's a practice that you strive to embody. You have your reasons for being doubtful about the plenitude of the world. You could count up all the terrible things that have happened to you in your life and the people you love. "How can I be grateful for that? How can I be grateful for the suffering of children?" That's tough. All of that. Well, Nietzsche's point here is, "Yeah, it's hard." It's a virtue. It's not exactly a grace that descends on you, although it can be. It's not an attitude that you adopt. It's something you strive to make manifest.
- 8.100 Nietzsche believed that the nobility of the Greeks was the great gratefulness. It's like, "Can you strive to be grateful?" And maybe, and here's something more—despite everything, despite everything. Not because you're covering everything up or because you don't have reasons to be ungrateful. That's not the point. Of course, you're the victim of terrible historical forces and your own biological inadequacy, obviously. So, what's the stance then? Is it an oppressed victim with endless justification for tyranny, or is it this courageous gratitude?
- 8.101 So, I'm going to be grateful despite everything, and that might mean I'm going to serve. It means something like I'm going to prepare to serve good regardless of the evidence. I have my reasons to be bitter and grasping, but no matter what the reasons are, they're not sufficient. That's a statement of faith: no matter what the reasons are for my bitterness. That's a walloping statement. No matter what the reasons are, the bitterness is not justifiable. And still, that doesn't mean you shouldn't stand up for yourself. It's a tricky thing to manage.

- 8.102 "It's a very noble type of man that confronts nature and life in this way. Later, when the rabble gained the upper hand in Greece, fear became rampant in religion, too; and the ground was prepared for Christianity." Freud took a page out of that with his doctrine that "no religion was a defense against death anxiety." We talked about that already in this seminar. Or Marx, too: "Religion is the opiate of the masses." It's this sop that's handed out to people to shield them from the bitter truth of the real world, handed to them by their bourgeoisie overlords to satiate them so they don't rebel. That's the Marxist theory of religion.
- 8.103 Again, it's a preposterous theory. It runs up upon the rocks of the shores of reality immediately. Why the crucifix as a central symbol then? That's the first question. There's nothing about that symbol that screams out defense against death anxiety. If you read the Old Testament, and as I said, Nietzsche was an admirer of the Old Testament, you don't wish you were a prophet when you read the Old Testament. It's not like these people are just waltzing through life. Abraham is the father of the multitudes. His life is just one catastrophe after another. It's starvation and war and death and betrayal. It's brutal.
- 8.104 So, the idea that somehow this belief shields you from death anxiety, or that it's merely the manipulation of those in power to keep you enslaved, it's like, "Maybe that's an exciting idea when you're 15, and you've never encountered an idea before in your life." You think, "Oh, that explains everything." It's like, "Well, that's a problem to begin with because, really, it explains everything? That's a lot of explanation, and you figured it out in 10 minutes?" It seems highly improbable.
- 8.105 But you get Nietzsche's point. He's still so concerned about this resentment that's going to emerge out of something like slave morality. That's certainly what happened in the Communist Revolution. He absolutely knew that was coming. We won't get to it today, but Nietzsche did point out that "the problem of the Jews," so to speak, although he wasn't anti-Semitic and was very pro-Jewish, and Russia would be the cardinal problems of the 20th century. That's a hell of a remarkable prediction for 1860. He nailed it. He also knew that this spirit of resentment making itself manifest right at that point with Marx was going to be an utter bloody, nightmarish catastrophe and a replacement for the God who had just died.
- 8.106 "In the Jewish 'Old Testament,' the book of divine justice, there are human beings, things, and speeches in so grand a style that Greek and Indian literature have nothing to compare with it." Very interesting contrast because he just expressed his admiration for classical civilization. And he says, "Classical civilization, with all its grandeur, didn't hold a candle to the narrative of the Old Testament, the Jewish narrative."
- 8.107 In fact, I think you can say, even historically, that Western civilization itself is an amalgam of that great classical Greco-Roman tradition and the Judeo-Christian tradition, both the traditions of the logos and that the motivational impetus of Western civilization is the power derived from both of those stories, the conjunction of both of those stories. It still sits uneasily on us because we don't know how to reconcile enlightenment logic, let's say, the Greek logos with the Judeo-

Christian **logos**, but Western civilization is trying to utilize both sources of motivation and to mediate between them. That is what our civilization is.

- 8.108** "With terror and reverence, one stands before these tremendous remnants of what man once was, and will have sad thoughts about ancient Asia and its protruding little peninsula Europe, which wants by all means to signify as against Asia the progress of man. To be sure, whoever is himself merely a meager, tame, domestic animal and knows only the needs of domestic animals (like our educated people of today, including the Christians of 'educated' Christianity) has no cause for amazement or sorrow among these ruins—the taste for the Old Testament is a touchstone for 'great' and 'small': perhaps he will find the New Testament, the book of grace, still rather more after his heart (it contains a lot of the real, tender, musty true-believer and small-soul smell)."
- 8.109** Nietzsche here is reacting, too, to the insular, narrow, full-moralizing Christianity that is in some sense the expression of the willingness to use God's name in vain and to clothe the morality of cowardice and conformity—mindless, resentful conformity—in the guise of divine morality. That's really what Nietzsche is objecting to.
- 8.110** I've read a lot of comments from atheists in the comments section on YouTube, in the comments on my Genesis lecture. A lot of the atheists, a lot of them—what did a friend of mine say yesterday? "To be an atheist, you have to say, 'I don't believe in God, and I hate him.'" That's the atheist stance. And you might say, "Why?" Often, the reason is that the intellectual, the budding intellectual who becomes atheistic, was tormented to death by idiot fundamentalists who weren't religious in any real sense but who used that bitter, consensual, crowd-pleasing—what would you call it—conforming mediocrity as a signifier of their commitment to faith, and then insisted that that be imposed on their children, let's say. And so, **the free spirit** who becomes an atheist rebels against that. That's what Nietzsche is objecting to here. Although, as I said, he tends to overgeneralize.
- 8.111** "To have glued this New Testament, a kind of rococo of taste in every respect, to the Old Testament to make one book as the 'Bible,' as 'the book par excellence' —that is perhaps the greatest audacity and 'sin against the spirit' that literary Europe has on its conscience." You could hardly have a more pro-Jewish statement than that.
- 8.112** Now, I think what Nietzsche was attempting to wrestle with, and reasonably, was that you have this vision of the crucified God in the New Testament, and Nietzsche is saying, "There's a remarkable disjunction between that and the grandeur of Abraham, let's say, or of Moses." He thinks of those images as of a different type and that that attempt to force them together was paradoxical beyond reconciliation.
- 8.113** Now, as I said, Jung sorted that problem out in the 80 years after Nietzsche because he delved deeply into the symbolism of Christian narrative and broadened it because one of the things that Jung did was to look at religious stories all over the world, comparative mythological analysis. He was a real pioneer of that effort, along with Frazer, who wrote **The Golden Bough**,

the first person who really compared mythologies in some systematic manner. Jung's observation was, "There's a narrative of heroic transcendence that's universally apprehensible in uniting mythologies." It varies in its form, but there's a core pattern there.

- 8.114 Jung believed, like C. S. Lewis, so you could think about that as an archetype. Imagine there's a set of adventure—okay, imagine an amalgam of an adventure story and a romance. Okay, now imagine the perfect amalgam of those two things. Okay, now imagine a hundred variants of an adventure romance. And then, imagine that you extracted out the gist of that combination. So, you have the perfect romantic adventure. Now, imagine that people differ in their ability to embody that perfect archetypal narrative. So, Jung's claim and C. S. Lewis's claim was that Christ perfectly embodied the archetype so that the story, the archetypal story, and the particularized reality met.
- 8.115 So, you can make of that claim what you will, but that was the claim. And that's not a claim that Nietzsche is making because Nietzsche can't see the heroic in the New Testament. He just sees the manifestation of this inversion of morality that he characterizes as slave morality and is trying to push back against. Can I have sympathy for Nietzsche because I know he could see this bureaucratization of mediocrity and this elevation of victimization. I know he could see that beckoning. He knew the communists were coming. He knew that. He predicted that in Will to Power. He knew the nihilists were coming. He knew it. And he knew that the victim moralizers were coming.
- 8.116 So, we've had, well, we still have the nihilists. We definitely had the communists, although we haven't got rid of them yet, or that spirit we haven't got rid of. And the victimizing moralists, like, man, they've got the upper hand now. Unbelievably prescient. And so, when you read someone great, you separate the wheat from the chaff. Nietzsche could go too far and did in many directions because he was a plant that overgrew. It needed trimming back. And I say that with all due caution because I've also read parts of Nietzsche that I bounced off, and then I later thought, "Oh, I see. I just missed that. It wasn't that Nietzsche was wrong." You should be careful about concluding that. It's that I didn't understand.
- 8.117 When you ever encounter a great thinker, you always have to ask yourself, "Are you rejecting it? On critical grounds, do you have the perspicacity to actually manage that? Or are you just too stupid to understand? Or are you stumbling against one of your moral prejudices?" You should assume the latter two before you assume the former. I'm doing this seminar on Exodus right now—this book that's lasted thousands and thousands of years—and it's going very well. The group of very good thinkers aggregated around the table. The reason it's working is because every single person at the table, and they're high-caliber people on the intellectual front, treat the book with reverence. They assume that if it's opaque, it's because they're stupid.
- 8.118 You can reverse that and say, "This is just a doctrine of archaic superstitions, and we're above that." Could be. You'll approach the text in one way, or maybe you read it through a feminist lens or a Postmodern lens or something like that, which means you make it subordinate to your ideology. All that does is serve the purpose of your ideology. You don't grow as a consequence

of that. Or you can say, "There's a mystery here, and we're trying to make its revelations manifest," and you take a completely different attitude.

- 8.119 That's certainly what Jung did, by the way, when he went around the world and compared multiple mythologies. These mythologies united people and provided them with purpose. They're probably worth a certain degree of reverence. He found this compelling underlying pattern, and I said it was what split him from Freud because Freud believed the central uniting narrative of humanity was the Oedipal story. It's a failed hero myth because Oedipus sleeps with his mother, so he infantilizes himself, essentially. He's too close to his mother; he blinds himself. It's a failed hero story.
- 8.120 Freud's conclusion was, "The fundamental human story is a failed hero story." And Jung said, "No, the fundamental human is the hero story, right to its successful conclusion." You might say, "Do you believe that?" The answer to that question is, "Do you act it out?" That's the only answer because that's what the belief is. Maybe you sit on the fence instead and look for security when that's convenient. You look for adventure when that's convenient. But the alternative— or maybe you throw yourself into security—but the alternative is to say, "I'm all in on this. I'm all in on this."
- 8.121 And that's really what Nietzsche is attempting to, I would say, attempting to motivate himself and his readers to do precisely that, is to leap all in. You're all in anyways, man. It's not really a choice you have. You're all in. So you're going to be voluntarily all in, or are you going to be involuntarily all in? Those are your choices. And that's that.
- 8.122 We didn't get through Beyond Good and Evil. I'll add another four sessions to this at some point. Thank you very much for taking the time and effort to come and attend as the audience. To everyone watching: thank you very much.